Cthulhu Eternal

A System Reference Document for

Modern Age



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What is Cthulhu Eternal?

The *Cthulhu Eternal* System is a multi-era, multi-setting ruleset for tabletop roleplaying in versions of our familiar world, afflicted and altered by the horrors of H.P. Lovecraft's Cthulhu Mythos. It excels at supporting investigative styles of play although also caters to action-oriented games of survival horror.

The only assumptions made by the *Cthulhu Eternal* rules are that:

- The game takes place in an era of our planet's past, present, or future where humanity is the prevailing — although not necessarily only —species actively shaping the world.
- The world is haunted by secret and mysterious survivals of otherworldly or extra-dimensional forces of Lovecraft's mythos; clues to their existence are scattered through written accounts (if such exist) or folktales passed from generation-to-generation.
- Players take on roles of everyday people from the era, without special pulp-like "super-powers"; regardless of their frailty they pursue the truth about the Cthulhu Mythos and ultimately work to thwart its corrosive influence.
- Player characters are physical human beings that can be hurt, fall unconscious, or die if subject to physical damage — and conversely, they can be healed using whatever knowledge of "first aid" exists in the historical era.
- Player characters are conscious and intelligent beings whose sanity can be adversely affected by witnessing terrible things beyond normal human comprehension — and conversely, they can have their mental state made better by whatever folk-remedies or medical science exists in the historical era.

Cthulhu Eternal is intended to be an "open source" system — its core rules are available as free downloads, and provide everything needed to run a game session. Because the rules are all designated Open Content under the (Wizards) Open Gaming License, other creators can reuse, re-cycle, or re-purpose them to form part of their own creations. Such new inventions can be freely distributed (for free, or for profit) as long as the terms of the OGL are adhered to.

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Cover Art & Interior Illustrations: Stock art, composited by Dean Engelhardt

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Layout: Dean Engelhardt

This illustrated edition published by Cthulhu Reborn Publishing in February, 2026.

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Lovecraftian Investigations in the Modern Age

This version of *Cthulhu Eternal* is specifically tailored to support Lovecraftian games set in the "modern day" — that is, the era we live in (give or take a decade or so). This is an attractive option for a game setting: after all, everyone is already familiar with what life is like in our current real world so it's not something that needs to be particularly explained or portrayed for players. Plus the range of research resources that are available to describe the real world of our era is vast — if you want to find some detail to add color to your game version of a place or real-world organization, just go to a search engine or Wikipedia and you'll find more than you could ever use.

Some purists may argue that modern-day settings are less "Lovecraftian" than the particular time-period when his original stories were set. However, it's worth remembering that when those pieces were written, they were (for the most part) set in contemporary times. Lovecraft was, in fact, making use of the "modern era" at the time when he was crafting his tales of horror. So, there's plenty of precedent to making your Mythos tales dark takes on the familiar world of today. Fill them with twists on cozy, familiar topics and set them in the uncanny space between the mundane world and the outre Mythos-ridden reality that sits behind it.

While there are huge advantages to setting your Lovecraftian game in the current day, there are also a few potential pitfalls you should try to work around. Most of them stem from the fact that, as well as being a very familiar place that your players will instantly recognize, the present is also the most common setting for every TV show, movie, and novel that your players will have read. Those other fictions all have their own storytelling conventions which people will naturally (perhaps even subconsciously) expect of the game world and the stories set within it. While there are many benefits to there being well-worn pathways set up by our modern obsession with "genre", such things also skew what players will find a satisfying in their game narratives.

Of course you can throw genre out the window completely and chart your own course in making a Lovecraftian game, but you will find that much more work than taking a well-established genre (with all its tropes and conventions) and tweaking it just a bit to put Lovecraftian themes or world-views into the mix. Picking an existing genre that is already somewhat dark or obsessed with hidden knowledge makes things easiest. But if you're up for a challenge you could just as easily go against form and pick a genre that is nothing like that and shoe-horn darkness into it as a form of contrast to the normal.

Here are a few ideas for modern-day fictional genres that seem ripe for adaptation as Lovecraftian game worlds:

- **Mystery Genres:** there are no shortage of modern-day tales about nefarious crimes and betrayals by people, whether they be murderers, serial killers, or madmen. It's not too much of a stretch to switch out the human motivation driving such malign behavior and replace it with a diabolical devotion to some Mythos titan or race of creatures.

- **Conspiracy Genres:** in the past few decades, there's been an explosion of fiction which posits that some shadowy entity (whether a government organization, a shadowy religious order, or something else) is secretly behind the woes of our modern world. Why couldn't the truth be a shade more "cosmic horror"?

- **Dystopian Science-Fiction Genres:** our dependence on technology has spawned an entire sub-genre of sci-fi that explores what happens when the people (or artificial intelligences) controlling our devices is motivated by darker desires. It's not a huge step to consider a "Green Mirror" storyline where it's actually ancient and alien horrors from beyond space and time that are the ultimate power pulling the strings.

Those examples don't specifically draw on the rich and varied range of sub-genres that make up modern-day horror. Whereas once there were only a few types of horror tale to draw upon, the explosion of films and TV with differing takes on the 'scary story' have spawned many different families of tales, each with their own traditions and conventions.

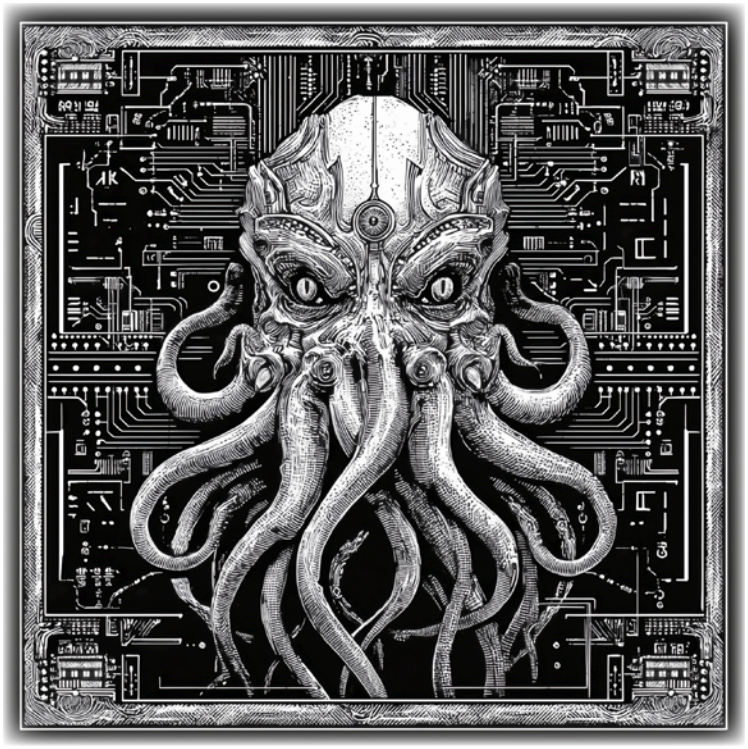
Some forms of modern horror — like the slasher film — don't seem very compatible with the ethos of Lovecraft's fiction (but you could still, certainly, merge the two into an unholy union). Others feel very adjacent, for example:

- **Occult Horror:** stories about witchcraft typify the idea that some ancient tradition lives on in secret, buried somewhere in our midst. That's a very Lovecraftian idea. The same is true of haunted houses, demonic possession, and (if you put a scientific spin on it) stories about ghosts and spirits.

- **Horrors from Hell:** although references to Christianity (or other real-world religions) as the basis for horrors is definitely not Lovecraftian, the types of stories that have been written about Satan and his minions on Earth can readily be re-purposed. Just file off the Biblical references and put in some Necronomicon stuff, and you're cooking.
- **Eastern Horrors:** compared to English-language horror, some of the traditions prevalent in horrific films from Japan or Korea have a more personal nature to them. Some seek to embed horrific situations in everyday situations, highlighting how our day-to-day comforts forever harbor the potential to turn horrific if the supernatural decides to take an interest.
- **Psychological Horror:** much of the scariness in Lovecraft is implied rather than being delivered by "in your face" splatter and jump scares. As such, films and TV that seek to build up an unsettling psychological form of dread — whether by playing on the audience's own fears or dealing with disturbing mental states — can serve as a good template to leverage for investigative horror games.

As with everything in storytelling, the secret to success is finding the right balance between the familiar (e.g., genre expectations) and the brand new.

As long as you keep that in mind — and listen to what your players say they want out of a game experience — you will never fail when it comes to bringing a compelling investigative horror game alive at the table.





PART I: RULES OF THE GAME

This section describes the rules that all players will need to know to play a game of *Cthulhu Eternal*. It describes:

- How to **create characters** whose roles players will adopt in the shared Lovecraftian stories;
- How characters make use of their **skills and attributes** to try to overcome challenges they encounter;
- How **combat** works, when things turn violent;
- How the fragile **sanity** of each player's character may become eroded by encounters with horrors, both mundane and unnatural;
- What player characters can do during the quiet **downtime** between perilous adventures against unnatural entities.

1.0 Core Game Concepts

These rules tell you everything you need to know in order to play *Cthulhu Eternal*.

As with most tabletop roleplaying games, when playing *Cthulhu Eternal* one player takes on the responsibility of setting the scene and narrating the events which make up a *Cthulhu Eternal* adventure. That individual is termed the **Game Moderator**. All other players take on the roles of individual every-day people from an era of human history who are swept up in investigating the Cthulhu Mythos. These characters are called **Protagonists** (with the term capitalized for clarity). Protagonists will encounter a multitude of other characters whose roles are not being played by other players — those characters are called **Non-Player Characters** (or NPCs) and their actions are controlled by the Game Moderator.

In this book you'll find rules for creating Protagonists and a full set of rules for running adventures in a Lovecraftian world of your group's choosing or devising.

In addition to this book, you also need pencils to record changes to your character sheet, scratch paper to draw sketches and take notes, and dice.

Cthulhu Eternal uses polyhedral dice common to tabletop role-playing games: four-sided, six-sided, eight-sided, ten-sided, twelve-sided, and twenty-sided. The game plays best when you have a few of each on the table. Or you can find automated dice rollers on the Web and as mobile apps.

1.1 Rolling the Dice

When the rules need you to roll dice, they use a particular nomenclature to save time and space: "#D#," as in "1D8" or "4D6." The first number is the number of dice. The "D" stands for "dice with the following number of sides." The second number is the number of faces on the die. "1D8" means roll one eight-sided die. "4D6" means roll four six-sided dice and add the numbers together. Sometimes you add or subtract a number from the roll. If it says "1D6+2," that means roll one six-sided die and add two to the result.

1.2 Percentile Dice ("1D100")

Actions in Cthulhu Eternal are resolved using **percentile dice**. That means you roll two ten-sided dice to get a number from 1 to 100. To do this, you don't add the individual die values together but instead treat each number as a digit (0–9). Before you make the roll, designate one die as the tens digit and the other as the ones digit. A zero (0) on the tens die counts as zero except when the ones die is also 0; then the 0 on the tens die counts as 10.

For example:

- The tens die comes up "0" and the ones die comes up "3": 03, or 3.
- The tens die comes up "3" and the ones die comes up "0": 30.
- Both dice come up "0": 100.
- The tens die comes up "6" and the ones die comes up "2": 62.

2.0 Protagonists

Your Protagonist represents the fictional persona that you will control in the game. You will spend a lot of time navigating your Protagonist through exciting and dangerous situations, so it is worth investing time in creating a character you will enjoy playing.

2.1 What Makes a Protagonist

All Protagonists are composed of six elements:

STATISTICS (STATS): Core capabilities for every Protagonist.

DERIVED ATTRIBUTES: Ratings that indicate physical and mental resilience, derived from stats.

ARCHETYPE: The type of role your Protagonist performs, which informs how many skill points and Bonds they have.

SKILLS: What training and education your Protagonist has picked up from being taught, or from life in general.

RESOURCES: An abstract rating that reflects your Protagonist's access to useful equipment or items.

BONDS: The people and communities your Protagonist fights to protect.

2.2 Protagonist Creation

Follow these steps to create a new Protagonist, or see **HOW TO CREATE A PROTAGONIST** on page 7 for a quick reference.

2.2.1 STEP 0: Establish Harshness of Protagonist's Upbringing

Most Protagonist's upbringings will have been unremarkable — but it's possible that yours grew up under especially challenging and punishing circumstances. For example, growing up amid a turbulent period of warfare or plague that killed most of those near-and-dear to the Protagonist. If you think that upbringing might have been harsh enough to scar your Protagonist, discuss it with your Game Moderator. Between you, decide whether the upbringing you envisage is best characterized by the descriptor **Normal(-ish)**, **Harsh**, or **Very Harsh**. See page 8 for a few examples of real-world disasters which could have brought tragedy to your Protagonist's childhood.

Usually, an upbringing warranting the descriptor **Harsh** will involve the Protagonist having spent at least

3–4 years of adolescence in a highly dangerous or adverse situation that only affected the specific region. This calamity is likely to have caused the untimely death of at least a couple of the character's immediate family.

For an upbringing to be considered **Very Harsh**, the whole of the Protagonists childhood and adolescence was likely marred by a dangerous, deadly, or otherwise toxic environment that was particular to their region. This terrible situation is likely to have resulted in the majority of the characters' family suffering greatly, with at least half having perished.

Any upbringing that isn't **Harsh** or **Very Harsh** is considered **Normal(-ish)**.

A harsher upbringing might make them a little stronger or hardier (since only the strong and hardy would have survived), but at the cost of mental scarring from the many horrific sights marring their childhood.

2.2.2 STEP 1: Determine Statistics

Statistics are Strength (STR), Dexterity (DEX), Constitution (CON), Intelligence (INT), Power (POW), and Charisma (CHA). They range from 3 (the worst) to 18 (the best), with an average of 10 for an ordinary adult. Statistics represent core capabilities possessed by all Protagonists. All are important. (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: STATISTICS,** opposite.)

You can create stats in two ways: rolling them or assigning points. Pick a method.

1. **ROLL STATS:** For each stat roll 4D6, drop the lowest of the four dice, and add up the other three. Place the six rolls in whichever stats you like.
2. **ASSIGN STATS:** Divide 72 points among the six stats however you like, or pick one of the sets from page 6 and assign each score to one statistic.

After the basic values are assigned for each statistic, modify according to the Harshness Descriptor for the Protagonist's upbringing:

- For Protagonists with **Harsh** upbringings: add 1 to *either* STR *or* CON (player's choice)
- For Protagonists with **Very Harsh** upbringings: add 1 to *both* STR *and* CON

2.2.3 STEP 2: Calculate Derived Attributes

Hit Points, Willpower Points, Sanity Points, and Breaking Point are derived from stats. They represent physical and mental resilience. When your Protagonist is hurt, exercises mental fortitude, or is traumatized, those scores can drop. If your Protagonist has a STR score that is outside the average range (9—12) they also have a modifier to the damage inflicted from hand-to-hand combat. (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: DERIVED ATTRIBUTES & DAMAGE BONUS** on page 8.)

2.2.4 STEP 3: Select Archetype

What does your Protagonist do for a living (or just to stay alive)? Archetype dictates what skills your Protagonist has, their basic resource level, and the number of Bonds they possess. (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: ARCHETYPES** on page 9.)

2.2.5 STEP 4: Calculate Resources Rating

The Resources rating is a number between 0 and 20 that reflects the Protagonist's access to valuable or useful equipment. A Protagonist's base Resources rating is dictated by their Archetype, however during later steps, you can sacrifice other potential bonus skills in favor of a higher resources score; conversely, you can agree to drop Resources rating of 0 (entirely without access to resources) and receive additional skills. (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: RESOURCES** on page 13.)

2.2.6 STEP 5: Define Bonds

Bonds indicate the strength of relationships with the most important people and communities in your Protagonist's life — like a spouse, child, a long-time travelling companion, or a local community of people. Bonds help Protagonists resist mental trauma — but as your Protagonist's life falls apart under the stress of the Mythos-haunted world, Bonds deteriorate.

There are **two types of Bonds** — bonds with individuals and bonds with an entire community. The latter reflect the Protagonist's standing as part of the community and their ability to influence the group.

Each Individual Bond has a value that starts equal to your Protagonist's Charisma (CHA).

Each Community Bond has a default value equal to half the Protagonist's Resources rating, however during creation of the Protagonist the player may elect to sacrifice potential skills in favor of a higher value. Conversely, the player may elect to take a Community Bond with a value of 1 (lowest possible social standing) and receive additional skills. (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: BONDS** on page 16.)

2.2.7 STEP 6: Select Bonus & Adversity Skills

Skills require special training, and come from schooling, experience, or personal interest. Skills are measured from 0% (no training) to 99% (foremost expert in the world). (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: SKILLS** on page 20.)

2.2.8 STEP 7: Determine Mental Damage from Harsh Environments

Protagonists that have grown up in difficult and brutal conditions are likely to have picked up some mental scarring along the way. This can leave them hardened to certain types of traumatic stimuli, distant from those around them, or afflicted with mental disorders. (see **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: MENTAL DAMAGE FROM HARSH UPBRINGING**, page 27.)

2.2.9 STEP 8: Add the Final Details

Start filling in the details that make your Protagonist interesting. How old is your Protagonist? What do they look like? Where did they grow up? What's your Protagonist's name? What is your Protagonist's role in the community and what's your personal life like? And why, despite all the terrifying dangers, does your Protagonist venture out to pursue adventure or investigate weirdness?

2.3 Detailed Description: Statistics

Every Protagonist has six core capabilities: Strength, Constitution, Dexterity, Intelligence, Power, and Charisma. These are called their statistics (or "stats" for short).

Statistic	Abbreviation	Description	Stat Test Examples
Strength	STR	Physical power, size, and musculature.	Drag an innocent to safety. Break down a locked door. Hold a struggling victim down.
Constitution	CON	Health and physical resilience.	Resist illness, exhaustion, or pain. Hold your breath for a long time. Keep running longer than everyone else.
Dexterity	DEX	Agility, coordination, and nimbleness.	Keep balance. React quickly.
Intelligence	INT	How well a Protagonist notices, remembers, and connects things. Along with Archetype, it indicates education and overall brilliance.	Recall a detail. Piece together disparate data.
Power	POW	Force of personality, motivation, and psychic resilience.	Keep your head in a crisis. Stand up to pressure.
Charisma	CHA	Charm, leadership, and personal appeal. May indicate physical attractiveness.	Make a good impression. Talk your way into a private club. Look like you belong.

During Protagonist creation, you can either roll **STATISTIC** scores (see left) or simply divide 72 points between the six stats however you wish. The table nearby gives some examples of possible assignments.

Description	Stat 1	Stat 2	Stat 3	Stat 4	Stat 5	Stat 6
Well-Rounded	13	13	12	12	11	11
Focused	15	14	12	11	10	10
Highly Focused	17	14	12	10	10	9

Each stat has a test score equal to the stat × 5: STR×5, INT×5, POW×5, etc. This means roll five times the stat or less on percentile dice (1D100) to succeed. When your Protagonist attempts a difficult action and no skill covers it, the Game Moderator may ask you to roll a stat test for whatever stat is the closest fit.

2.3.1 Stat Adjustments for Harsh Upbringings

Protagonists who have managed to reach adulthood in a dangerous or deadly environment are likely to be hardier or stronger than average– weaker individuals simply don't make it through such horrible upbringings. To reflect this, such Protagonists receive a bonus to STR and/or CON as follows:

- Normal(ish) upbringing: no bonus
- Harsh upbringing: +1 to either STR or CON (pick one)
- Very Harsh upbringing: +1 to both STR and CON

2.3.2 Distinguishing Features

A stat below 9 or above 12 is exceptional. Spare a word or two to describe stats outside the average; see the table nearby for some examples. These descriptors help give your Protagonist personality.

Statistic	3—4	5—8	9—12	13—16	17—18
Strength	Feeble	Weak	(Average)	Muscular	Huge
Constitution	Bedridden	Sickly	(Average)	Perfect Health	Indefatigable
Dexterity	Barely Mobile	Clumsy	(Average)	Nimble	Acrobatic
Intelligence	Imbecilic	Slow	(Average)	Perceptive	Brilliant
Power	Spineless	Nervous	(Average)	Strong-Willed	Indomitable
Charisma	Unbearable	Awkward	(Average)	Charming	Magnetic

How To Create A Protagonist

Determine Harshness of Protagonist's Upbringing

- Discuss with Game Moderator Harshness of Protagonist's upbringing — Normal(ish), Harsh, Very Harsh.

Stats & Derived Attributes

- Roll **STATISTIC** scores (see page 5) or divide 72 points between the six stats. See page 6 for suggested sets.
- Modify STR and/or CON statistic scores based on Harshness:
  - Harsh — add +1 to STR or CON (player's choice)
  - Very Harsh — add +1 to STR and CON
- Calculate **DERIVED ATTRIBUTES** (see page 8).
  - HP = (STR + CON) ÷ 2, rounded up.
  - WP = POW.
  - Recovery SAN is always POW × 5, regardless of harshness of Protagonist's upbringing.
  - Determine Starting SAN based on Harshness Descriptor:
    - Normal(ish) — SAN = POW × 5.
    - Harsh or Very Harsh — SAN = POW × 4.
  - BP = SAN − POW.
- High and low stat scores can tell something about your Protagonist's physical description. (See **DISTINGUISHING FEATURES** on page 6.)
- If STR is below 9 or above 12, look up **DAMAGE BONUS** (see page 36).

Archetype, Skills, Resources & Bonds

- Choose an **ARCHETYPE** from the lists starting on page 9.
- Write down the **ARCHETYPAL SKILLS** for your Protagonist's Archetype and record the starting **RESOURCES** rating associated with the Archetype.
- Your Protagonist may get **ADVERSITY SKILL POINTS** (see page 13) which can be used to increase one of the four setting-specific skills defined as adversity skills. Each pick provides +20 rating to the chosen skill.
  - Harsh — 1 pick
  - Very Harsh — 2 picks
- On a piece of scrap paper, record the Protagonist's number of available **BONUS SKILL POINT** picks (see below). This starts at 10.
- **(Optional)** Modify your Protagonist's **RESOURCES** rating (see page 13):
  - Increase rating by sacrificing one or more **BONUS SKILL POINT** picks; the first sacrifice gives +5 to **RESOURCES** rating, each subsequent sacrifice gives +2.
  - Alternatively, choose to reset rating to 0 and receive one extra **BONUS SKILL POINT** pick.
- Once the final **RESOURCES** rating has been established, look up the breakdown (see page 14) of "at-hand"/stowed/stored points and number of Resource checkmarks and copy these to Protagonist sheet
- Define your Protagonist's **BONDS** (see page 16).
  - The Protagonist's Archetype determines how many Bonds they have.
  - Each Bond is either a Community Bond or an Individual Bond (player's choice).
  - Each Individual Bond refers to an individual with special significance and begins with a score equal to your Protagonist's CHA.
  - Each Community Bond refers to a community within which the Protagonist has a particular standing and begins with a value equal to half their **RESOURCES** rating (see above).
  - **(Optional)** Modify Community Bond Values:
    - Improve the rating of any Community Bond by sacrificing **BONUS SKILL** picks; the first sacrifice for any given Bond gives +5 to its value, each subsequent sacrifice for the same Bond gives +2.
    - Alternatively, choose to take a rating of 1 for a Community Bond (reflecting the lowest possible standing in the society) and receive one extra **BONUS SKILL POINT** pick.
- After resolving any optional spends of **BONUS SKILL POINTS** (page 19) for non-skill benefits, use the remainder to improve ANY skills (except Unnatural). Each pick provides an increase of 20 points.
  - No skill can start higher than 80%

Mental Damage from Harsh Environment

- If Harshness of Protagonist's background is anything other than "Normal(ish)", determine any **MENTAL DAMAGE FROM ENVIRONMENT** (see page 27). This may mean:
  - Protagonist begins play with **MENTAL DISORDERS**.
  - Protagonist loses points from Bonds due to emotional distance.
  - Protagonist begins play **ADAPTED** to Violence or Helplessness.

Final Details

- Choose **NAME**, **AGE**, **SEX**, **BIRTHPLACE** and Current **HOME**.
- As you play, describe up to five **MOTIVATIONS** that are not Bonds.
- When your Protagonist develops a new **MENTAL DISORDER**, it replaces a motivation.

What Makes An Upbringing Harsh?

For games set in the modern day, catastrophes in the characters' background would likely have occurred in the late 20th Century. A (non-exhaustive) list of historical possibilities include:

- **Wars:** The Vietnam War (1955-1975), the Angolan Civil War (1975—2002), the Soviet-Afghan War (1980—1988), Yugoslav Wars (1991—2001)
- **Famines:** Ethiopia (1972–1973), Bangladesh (1974), Cambodia under the Khmer Rouge (1975–1979), Ethiopia (1983–1985), Somalia (1991–1992), North Korea (1994–1998), War and famine in Congo (1998–2004)
- **Plagues/Accidents:** Hong Kong Flu (1968–1970), Russian Flu — Worldwide (1977), Chernobyl Nuclear Disaster (1986), Swine Flu — Worldwide (2009–2010), COVID-19 Global Pandemic (2020–)
- **Massacres:** Massacres in Rwanda and Burundi (1959—1997), Indonesian anti-communist killings (1965—1966), Cultural Revolution in China (1966—1976), Indonesian occupation of East Timor (1974—1999), Violent anti-communist purges in Ethiopia (1977—1978), Iraqi destruction of Kurdish settlements (1977—1991), Gaza (multiple)

2.4 Detailed Description: Derived Attributes & Damage Bonus

The derived attributes — Hit Points, Willpower Points, Sanity Points, and Breaking Point — represent your Protagonist's physical and mental toughness.

Damage Bonus reflects whether their brawn (or lack thereof) will affect damage inflicted through brawling and hand-to-hand weapons.

HIT POINTS (HP): Hit Points represent how much damage your Protagonist can sustain. When the Protagonist is injured, subtract the damage from HP. At 2 HP, your Protagonist falls unconscious. At 0 HP, your Protagonist dies. Hit Points are regained through rest and medical attention.

Hit Points equal CON plus STR, divided by two and rounded up.

WILLPOWER POINTS (WP): Willpower Points represent mental fortitude. They fall when your Protagonist attempts to suppress the symptoms of mental illness (see **RESISTING INSANITY** on page 57), becomes exhausted (see **EXHAUSTION** on page 31), attempts to resist persuasion, suffers emotional burnout (see **FUMBLE** on page 29), or tries to fuel unnatural phenomena. At 2 WP, your Protagonist has a temporary emotional collapse. At 0 WP, your Protagonist falls unconscious. Willpower Points are regained with rest. (See **WILLPOWER POINTS** on page 31.)

Willpower Points equal POW.

SANITY POINTS (SAN): Sanity Points represent mental health: how much mental trauma, or exposure to the unnatural your Protagonist can endure before going insane. In moments of mental trauma your Protagonist must make a Sanity test by rolling SAN or lower on 1D100. If that fails, your Protagonist loses SAN. (See **SANITY** on page 51.) Sanity Points are regained through remedial care or by overcoming unnatural threats. At 0 Sanity Points, your Protagonist goes irretrievably insane and becomes an NPC permanently under the control of the Game Moderator.

A Protagonist's starting Sanity Points depends on the Harshness of their upbringing — the harsher the situation, the more brutality and horror the Protagonist has been scarred by.

Normal(ish) Upbringing: Sanity Points begin equal to POW×5.

Harsh or Very Harsh Upbringing: Sanity Points begin equal to POW×4.

BREAKING POINT: The Breaking Point is the point at which loss of SAN triggers a long-term mental disorder. (See **INSANITY AND DISORDERS** on page 53.)

A Protagonist's Breaking Point equals SAN minus POW.

The instant the Protagonist's SAN reaches the Breaking Point, they gain a disorder. Reset the Breaking Point to equal the new SAN score minus POW.

MAXIMUM SAN: The is the absolute maximum number of Sanity Points your Protagonist can EVER reach, by any means. Learning more about the true nature of the Cthulhu Mythos (represented by the Unnatural skill) reduces this number.

A Protagonist's Maximum SAN always equals 99 minus skill rating in the Unnatural Skill.

RECOVERY SAN: This is the highest Sanity Point total that your Protagonist can possibly achieve through mundane methods – relaxation, personal pursuits, caring for loved ones, and seeking help for mental illness. See **RECOVERING SANITY** on page 77.

A Protagonist's Recovery SAN equals POW×5, regardless of the harshness of their upbringing.

If this number would be higher than Max SAN, Recovery SAN equals Max SAN.

DAMAGE BONUS: High or low Strength modifies the **DAMAGE** the Protagonist inflicts through successful unarmed and hand-to-hand weapon attacks (see page 35). This modifier to damage should be recorded on the Protagonist sheet for later reference.

Damage Bonus from STR Score				
1–4	5–8	9–12	13–16	17–18
-2	-1	0	+1	+2

2.5 Detailed Description: Archetypes

Each Protagonist is a representative of a broad category of character types, usually related to the job they perform in the game world. Each such category is called an Archetype.

An Archetype says a lot about a Protagonist. It grants a "kit" of appropriate skills. It also determines the number of Bonds your Protagonist has when the game begins, and their starting Resource level.

RECOMMENDED STATS: Some Archetypes require people who are particularly fit, stable, or smart. This means the recommended stats should be 10 or higher — or at least they were when your Protagonist first started out being the Archetype.

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS: Each Archetype has a predefined kit of skills with scores that replace the default skill ratings. This represents the baseline training, experience, and education for that Archetype. See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: SKILLS** on page 20 for their uses.

RESOURCES: Each Archetype dictates a base value for the Resources rating.

BONDS: Each Archetype dictates the number of Bonds your Protagonist begins with. Difficult and trying Archetypes mean fewer Bonds but more skills. The player can decide whether each of these Bonds refers to:

- a relationship to an individual (Individual Bonds) or
- standing within a community (Community Bonds).



2.5.1 Customizing Your Protagonist With Other Skills

Don't worry if your Protagonist at this point looks like a generic representative of their chosen Archetype. While the Archetype defines a core set of abilities, those skills and ratings don't represent the full range of everything your Protagonist can do.

Later in the character generation process you will have opportunities to pick other skills they are also good at. There are two different types of skill picks:

- **ADVERSITY SKILL POINT PICKS** (see page 18) represent abilities your Protagonist has because of the harsh environment that they grew up in. These picks can only be used to enhance a few specific skills, and cannot be traded in for other benefits.
- **BONUS SKILL POINT PICKS** (see page 26) represent hobbies and general experience they learned above and beyond the basics associated with the Archetype. You start with ten such bonus picks to use later in the Protagonist generation process. These picks can be traded in for other advantages like increased availability of resources-at-hand or standing in a community.

2.5.2 List of Archetypes

The following Archetypes are appropriate for Modern era games of Lovecraftian investigation. They don't cover every possible character type but focus on likely protagonists in mystery and investigation tales. The GM is encouraged to develop other archetypes to cover other character types suggested by players. Guidelines for developing new Archetypes may be found on page 71.

Artist / Craftsperson

RECOMMENDED STATS: DEX

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Appraise 40%
- Art (choose one) 60%
- Craft (choose one) 40%
- Charm 60%
- Insight 60%
- Persuade 60%
- Search 60%

Choose any 5 of these that you don't already have:

- Administration 50%
- Alertness 60%
- Anthropology 40%
- Athletics 70%
- Craft (choose one) 40%
- Harangue 50%
- Heavy Machinery 50%
- Regional Lore (choose one) 40%
- Technology Use 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 3

BONDS: 3

Author / Blogger

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT, CHA

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Alertness 50%
- Art (choose one) 50%
- Insight 60%
- Research 60%
- Search 60%
- Technology Use 20%

Choose any 4 of these that you don't already have:

- Anthropology 40%
- Archeology 40%
- Foreign Language (choose one) 40%
- Harangue 50%
- History 50%
- Law (choose one) 40%
- Occult 50%
- Regional Lore (choose one) 40%
- Science (choose one) 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 4

BONDS: 4

Conspiracy Theorist / Expert

RECOMMENDED STATS: CHA, POW

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Craft (choose one) 40%
- Firearms 50%
- First Aid 40%
- Natural World 50%
- Navigate 50%
- Search 50%
- Survival (choose one) 50%
- Track 50%

Choose any 4 of these that you don't already have:

- Firearms 60%
- Heavy Machinery 50%
- History 50%
- Melee Weapons 70%
- Occult 50%
- Pilot (choose one) 40%
- Ride 50%
- Survival (choose one) 50%
- Unarmed Combat 60%

STARTING RESOURCES: 3

BONDS: 4



Criminal

RECOMMENDED STATS: DEX

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Alertness 40%
- Appraise 40%
- Craft (choose one) 40%
- Harangue 40%
- Law (choose one) 30%
- Stealth 60%
- Search 50%

Choose any 3 of these that you don't already have:

- Administration 50%
- Art (choose one) 40%
- Athletics 70%
- Charm 60%
- Dodge 70%
- Firearms 60%
- Insight 50%
- Melee Weapons 70%
- Technology Use 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 5

BONDS: 4

Doctor / Nurse

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Administration 30%
- Charm 40%
- First Aid 50%
- Insight 50%
- Medicine 50%
- Science (choose one) 40%
- Search 60%
- Surgery 40%
- Technology Use 30%

Choose any 2 of these that you don't already have:

- Foreign Language (choose one) 40%
- Military Training (choose one) 40%
- Forensics 40%
- Pharmacy 40%
- Psychoanalyze 50%
- Research 50%
- Science (Type) 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 5

BONDS: 3

Historian / Genealogist

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT, CHA

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Administration 50%
- Anthropology 50%
- Archeology 50%
- History 70%
- Research 60%
- Technology Use 30%

Choose any 3 of these that you don't already have:

- Art (choose one) 40%
- Craft (choose one) 40%
- Foreign Language (choose one) 40%
- Law (choose one) 40%
- Military Training (Type) 40%
- Persuade 60%
- Regional Lore (choose one) 40%
- Search 60%

STARTING RESOURCES: 4

BONDS: 4

Law Enforcer / Agent

RECOMMENDED STATS: CON, CHA

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Alertness 50%
- Athletics 60%
- Drive 50%
- Firearms 60%
- Harangue 60%
- Insight 50%
- Law (choose one) 40%
- Search 50%

Choose any 4 of these that you don't already have:

- Disguise 50%
- Dodge 70%
- First Aid 50%
- Forensics 40%
- Melee Weapons 70%
- Persuade 60%
- Regional Lore (choose one) 40%
- Stealth 50%
- Technology Use 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 4

BONDS: 3

Librarian / Archivist

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Administration 60%
- Alertness 50%
- Appraise 50%
- Research 60%
- Search 50%
- Technology Use 50%

Choose any 5 of these that you don't already have:

- Anthropology 40%
- Archeology 40%
- Art (choose one) 40%
- Foreign Language (choose one) 40%
- History 50%
- Law (choose one) 40%
- Occult 50%
- Regional Lore (choose one) 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 4

BONDS: 3

Researcher / Scientist

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Administration 50%
- Persuade 60%
- Research 70%
- Science (choose one) 70%
- Search 60%
- Technology Use 40%

Choose any 4 of these that you don't already have:

- Anthropology 40%
- Archeology 40%
- Art (choose one) 40%
- Firearms 60%
- Foreign Language (choose one) 40%
- Heavy Machinery 50%
- Military Training (choose one) 40%
- Natural World 50%
- Psychoanalyze 50%
- Science (choose another) 40%

STARTING RESOURCES: 5

BONDS: 2

Technologist

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT, POW

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Administration 50%
- Alertness 50%
- Art (choose one) 40%
- Insight 50%
- Persuade 50%
- Search 50%
- Technology Use 80%

Choose any 4 of these that you don't already have:

- Appraise 50%
- Craft (choose one) 40%
- Firearms 60%
- Heavy Machinery 50%
- Military Training (choose one) 40%
- Navigate 50%
- Pilot (choose one) 40%
- Research 50%

STARTING RESOURCES: 4

BONDS: 3

White-Collar Worker

RECOMMENDED STATS: INT, CHA

ARCHETYPAL SKILLS:

- Administration 60%
- Charm 50%
- Insight 50%
- Persuade 50%
- Research 40%
- Technology Use 60%

Choose any 4 of these that you don't already have:

- Appraise 50%
- Art (choose one) 40%
- First Aid 50%
- Foreign Language (choose one) 40%
- Harangue 50%
- History 50%
- Military Training (choose one) 40%
- Occult 50%

STARTING RESOURCES: 5

BONDS: 3

2.6 Detailed Description: Adversity Skill Points

Depending on the harshness of the environment where your Protagonist grew up, they may gain Adversity Skill Point Picks. Each such pick provides a 20-point increase in rating for one skill from a pre-defined list.

The number of Adversity Skill Point Picks your Protagonist receives depends on the Harshness Descriptor relevant to their particular upbringing:

- **Normal(ish) upbringing:** no Adversity Skill Point Picks
- **Harsh upbringing:** 1 Adversity Skill Point Pick
- **Very Harsh upbringing:** 2 Adversity Skill Point Picks

Adversity Skill Point Picks can ONLY be spent to increase ratings in the following list of setting-specific adversity skills:

First Aid, Military Training (type), Regional Lore (type), or Survival (type).

You can pick the same skill more than once.

2.7 Detailed Description: Resources

Every Protagonist has a Resources rating between 0 and 20. This number is an abstraction that represents the size, value, and utility of the **personal pool of resources** to which they have ready access. A Protagonist who is "wealthy" in a material sense will have a high Resources rating, since they have personal ownership — and hence access — to more things. Conversely, someone who is destitute and forced to carry their meagre belongings on their back will probably have a very low Resources rating. The definition of what constitutes "wealth" and "valuable resources" might vary depending on the game setting, but the Resources rating is a handy abstract rating which compares the magnitude of the Protagonist's material possessions against other people's.

The Resources rating represents a pool of previously unspecified items in addition to any named pieces of equipment that appears on the Protagonist's character sheet.

There are two ways in which Resources ratings can become important during a game of *Cthulhu Eternal*:

1. The rating can be used as a measure of status and wealth which dictates how Non-Player Characters react to the Protagonists; a Protagonist who has a sizeable cache of resources might find NPCs more willing to listen to what they have to say … or alternatively more likely to want to take some of those resources away.
2. Game encounters may involve challenges which can be overcome through possession of particular — possibly obscure — items or resources; a Protagonist who fossicks through their trove of (unnamed) personal items may locate just the thing that is needed. Usually this requires a successful **Resources test** (a 1D100 roll against **Resources × 5**).

A Protagonist's Resources rating may change during play as especially significant items are pulled from the "bag of tricks", items are destroyed, or new equipment caches are picked over for useful additions.

2.7.1 Determining Starting Resources rating

Your Protagonist's Archetype determines the starting value for their Resources rating; it is a number listed as part of the Archetype description.

If you would prefer this value to be higher, you have the option to "trade-in" one or more **BONUS SKILL POINT** picks (see page 19). For the first such skill pick traded-in, your Protagonist receives a +5 boost to Resources rating. Each additional pick you trade in beyond the first, grants your Protagonist a further +2 boost to Resources. You may sacrifice as many skill picks as you wish, although each will reduce your opportunities to round-out your Protagonist with extra skills during a later step of Protagonist creation.

Alternatively, if you would prefer to play a Protagonist who is entirely bereft of resources (i.e., has a Resources rating of 0), you can choose to do so and in return receive one extra Bonus Skill Point Pick for later use.

Rating	What the Rating Represents
0	No ownership of any item of value or function. Penury. Near starvation.
1-4	Owns only basic and valueless items; barely enough to eke out a basic life. Always hungry.
5-8	Owns a sparse collection of valuable or useful items, some in terrible condition. Sometimes hungry.
9-12	Owns a modest cache of valuable, useful items. Usually has basic food.
13-16	Owns a fair stock of low-grade valuable items. Occasional access to superior food.
17-18	Owns an impressive collection of useful gear; considered wealthy / well-resourced. Regular access to superior food
19	The envy of most people; owns numerous sought-after items of impressive function. Access to the best food and beverages.
20+	Access to unparalleled quantities of valuable or useful items. A stockpile of wealth. Choice of any available food, in any quantity.

If you need to know how your Resources Rating translates to financial wealth, consult the table in the **BUYING EQUIPMENT** section (page 46).

2.7.2 Permanent Resources, Resources At-Hand, and Resource Checks

The full value established above is called the Protagonist's **Permanent Resources** rating, since it measures the sum total of everything they own — regardless of where it is kept.

Carrying around a lot of bulky equipment everywhere is usually not practical, so Protagonists with significant Resources ratings (7+ points) will usually need to **stow** some of their junk in a vehicle or on a pack animal. Those with even more resources will need to **store** the overflow in a fixed 'home base' location.

The table nearby shows a breakdown of 'at hand' vs 'stowed' vs 'in storage' Resource rating points. There is space on the Protagonist sheet to record this breakdown of the total Permanent Resource rating into the three categories. The three numbers ('at-hand', 'stowed', and 'in storage') must always add up to the Permanent Resources rating.

The Permanent Resources rating measures both the quantity of items your Protagonist has dedicated access to, and their usefulness. This in turn governs how many times per adventure the Protagonist can successfully pull out useful items before the pool is temporarily exhausted.

In game terms this is represented by the number of **Resource Check boxes** the Protagonist has available — these are explained further below. The number of check boxes available to your Protagonist is also indicated on the table nearby: record it on the Protagonist Sheet by blacking out but those boxes available to the Protagonist (e.g., for a Protagonist with only one checkbox available, fill in all but one of the available boxes with solid black — use pencil since your Protagonist may open up more boxes later).

Resources Breakdown & Check Boxes

Permanent Resource Rating	"At Hand" / "Stowed" / "In Storage"	Check Boxes
0	0 / 0 / 0	0
1	1 / 0 / 0	1
2	2 / 0 / 0	1
3	3 / 0 / 0	1
4	4 / 0 / 0	1
5	5 / 0 / 0	1
6	6 / 0 / 0	1
7	6 / 1 / 0	2
8	6 / 2 / 0	2
9	6 / 3 / 0	2
10	6 / 4 / 0	2
11	6 / 5 / 0	2
12	6 / 6 / 0	2
13	6 / 6 / 1	3
14	6 / 6 / 2	3
15	6 / 6 / 3	3
16	6 / 6 / 4	3
17	6 / 6 / 5	3
18	6 / 6 / 6	3
19	6 / 6 / 7	3
20+	6 / 6 / 8+	3

Pushing the Limits

As indicated in the table, it is typically only possible for your Protagonist to keep 6 points of Resources on their person ('at-hand') and another 6 points 'stowed' in a handy vehicle or on a handy animal. These aren't hard and fast limits, but represent what can comfortably be carried/transported without impacting travel speed and convenience. If situations arise where the Protagonist really needs to carry more (e.g., carry the entire 10 points of Permanent Resources by hand while fleeing a burning building), it is up to the Game Moderator to decide what is possible and what impacts might arise from your Protagonist or vehicle being 'overloaded'. The Game Moderator might rule this has an impact on the rate of travel, or require some kind of skill test to keep moving forward under excess load.

Generally, stretching the limits beyond 12 points carried 'at hand' or 12 points 'stowed' is impossible.

There is no limit to the amount of Resources rating points that can be 'in storage' at a fixed location (e.g., a home base or workshop).

Which Rating for a Test?

Any time your Protagonist's Resources rating is the subject of a test, the effective rating number that is used should reflect the situation. It should be determined by the amount of Resources available to your Protagonist at that moment. If they are at home base, that will probably be the full Permanent Resources amount; if your Protagonist is close to their vehicle (or pack animal) that might be the 'at-hand' value PLUS the stowed value. If your Protagonist is far away from both home base and vehicle/animal, the number is likely to be just the 'at-hand' number.

Which Rating for NPC Reactions?

When using Resources as a means of determining Non-Player Character reactions, the rating that is used also depends on the situation. Does the NPC in question know all about your Protagonist's reputation as a 'wealthy' sort? If so, maybe the full Permanent Resources score can be used even if only some of that wealth is currently on display. Alternatively, if the NPC is suspicious of your Protagonist, it might be hard to get them to believe in the existence of any resources beyond what they can see for themselves.

2.7.3 The Bag of Tricks

The higher your Protagonist's effective Resources rating, the higher the likelihood that their accessible personal cache of items may contain something helpful to a situation or problem.

- In situations where **non-specialist resources or items** are needed, simply make a test of your Protagonist's Resources × 5. Success means that something helpful was found.
- In cases where a situation requires a **very specialized** resource or item, the Game Moderator might rule it is too rare to find in your Protagonist's pool of gear. Alternatively, the GM may still permit a test of **Resources × 5** roll to locate the rare equipment — ***but*** rule that success will **permanently reduce** your Protagonist's Resources rating by a few points (the number being at the Game Moderator's discretion).

Depending on the specific game setting, the difficulty of Resources tests and the quality of the items unearthed through successful rolls may vary. See **SCROUNGING EQUIPMENT** starting page 46.

Rules of Thumb:

- Tests to find items or resource types that are considered Hard to Get in the setting are made at HALF the Protagonist's effective Resources rating
- Tests to find items or resource types that are considered Very Hard to Get or Impossible to Get in the setting are made at QUARTER the Protagonist's effective Resources rating
- A test that is a standard success, but which is only just under the target number might yield a sub-standard version of the item or resource. A critical success will always yield the best possible quality available.



2.7.4 Checkboxes and Per-Adventure Limits

While your Protagonist's personal Resources can prove helpful during an adventure, there are practical limits to the number of times that items can be pulled from it during a single adventure.

After each Resources test resulting in success, place a check mark in one of the Resource Check boxes on the Protagonist's character sheet. When all the boxes are full, the Protagonist's resources pool is temporarily exhausted and can't contribute anything more until they have some downtime to replenish or reorganize it (see **REPLENISHING RESOURCES, REMOVING CHECK-MARKS**, opposite).

2.7.5 Pooling Resources

Sometimes, it may be appropriate for two or more Protagonists to pool their personal caches of items to improve the likelihood of finding a rare but crucial component. Any Protagonist can contribute items to the pool, as long as they haven't temporarily exhausted their resource pool (by filling all check boxes).

When making a roll to search such a **combined** resource pool, the effective Resources rating of the collection is equal to the **highest** individual Resources rating included in the collection **plus ONE FIFTH** of the Resources rating of every additional individual stockpile added to the heap (round fractions up). This reflects duplication of items or functions.

Success on a combined test causes a check mark to be placed on the sheet of the Protagonist whose FULL Resources rating was used. Others who contributed a smaller amount to the total do not receive a check mark.

2.7.6 Losing Resources

A Protagonist's Resources rating may decrease due to events that occur during play:

- As described above, producing a highly specialized item as the result of a Resources test may cause the Permanent Resources rating to be reduced by one or more.
- If the Protagonist is robbed or otherwise loses control of a significant amount of their personal equipment, the Game Moderator may decide this warrants a loss of a proportional amount of Resources rating.
- If a proportion of the Protagonist's resources are stowed in a vehicle or on a pack animal, the theft or destruction of the conveyance is likely to cause some or all to be lost, the exact proportion decided by the Game Moderator.
- If a proportion of the Protagonist's resources are stored in a fixed location, a disaster that outright destroys or significantly damages the location will likewise cause a reduction to permanent Resources. The points lost are based on the number of 'in storage' rating points stored at the location (i.e., not carried or stowed). The same loss may occur if the permanent location becomes invaded or overtaken by a hostile party — although in that situation the loss might be temporary, assuming the Protagonists can win back their former stronghold at some future date.

Whenever Resource rating decreases, the player should recalculate the "at-hand"/stowed/stored breakdown of points as well as the number of check boxes available to the Protagonist.

2.7.7 Increasing the Resources Rating During Play

During a *Cthulhu Eternal* adventure your Protagonist may gain access to a cache of items ripe for the taking. When this occurs, the Game Moderator will decide the number of Resources rating points each Protagonist might potentially plunder. For a small find this might be modest (1 point or 1D2 points), but for a massive discovery it could be a healthy improvement (1D6 or higher).

Increasing your Protagonist's Permanent Resources rating requires a die roll. With percentile dice, attempt to roll above **Permanent Resources rating × 5**. This reflects the fact that the more your Protagonist already owns, the harder it is to acquire additional new items they do not already have. If the test is successful, increase the Resources rating by the amount or die roll indicated by the GM.

Whenever Resource rating increases, the player should recalculate the "at-hand"/stowed/stored breakdown of points as well as the number of check boxes available to the Protagonist.

2.7.8 Replenishing Resources, Removing Checkmarks

The Game Moderator will determine when your Protagonist group can take the time to replenish or reorganize their Resources pools. Usually this happens between adventures, expeditions, or missions (see **DOWNTIME**, page 59). Once the Protagonists have invested an appropriate period of downtime all check marks can be erased from the character sheet.

2.8 Detailed Description: Bonds

Bonds measure your Protagonist's relationships with the vital people and societies in their life: loved ones, family members, and wider communities. A Bond can protect your Protagonist from SAN loss (see **PROJECTING ONTO A BOND** on page 57) or offer a chance to repress the effects of a disorder or temporary insanity (see **REPRESSING INSANITY** on page 57).

Bonds are not merely motivations or things your Protagonist likes. They are your Protagonist's connection to humanity and its social structures. A Protagonist with no Bonds is more susceptible to psychological trauma than one who has people waiting back home.

Your Protagonist's Archetype determines how many Bonds your Protagonist begins with. The more trying and time-consuming the Archetype, the fewer Bonds your Protagonist is able to maintain.

There are two distinct types of Bonds, each handled slightly differently — they are Individual Bonds and Community Bonds. When creating a Protagonist, you are free to choose which of their starting bonds is of each type.

2.8.1 Individual Bonds

An Individual Bond is an emotional connection to a single person. It could be familial or marital, or it could just be a close friendship or association. To qualify as an Individual Bond the person must be someone the Protagonist believes (hopes?) to be still alive.

Each Individual Bond begins with a score equal to your Protagonist's CHA. It cannot typically go above this value.

Sample Individual Bonds

- Spouse or ex-spouse
- Son or daughter
- Parent or grandparent
- Best friend
- Members of the same gang or band (see **BONDS FORMED THROUGH SHARED ADVERSITY**, below)
- Spiritual counsellor

Changes to Individual Bonds During Play

Bonds' scores often deteriorate because of your Protagonist's experiences of the horrors of the Mythos-haunted world. A Bond increases if it is cultivated between adventures (see **DOWNTIME** on page 59). An Individual Bond can never have a score higher than your Protagonist's CHA. Any time CHA drops, each Individual Bond drops by the same amount.

Individual Bonds are vulnerable. If the Protagonist learns that the individual has died or gone permanently insane, the Bond is destroyed. The Bond is also permanently broken when its score drops to 0 (see **BROKEN BONDS**, nearby).

2.8.2 Community Bonds

A Community Bond is a relationship between the Protagonist and a broader community of individuals; it reflects the Protagonist's status within that community, and the likelihood of other people following their instructions or desires.

A community may be a geographical association of people or it may be a society of like-minded individuals (e.g., a club, congregation, or association). A Protagonist can have more than one Community Bond, each describing their status within the hierarchy of a different societal structure.

Community Bonds are measured on a scale of 1 to 20, with an indicative meaning shown below:

Rating	What the Rating Represents
1	Disgraced member; on the verge of being banished from the society.
2–4	Shunned member of the community; someone who is actively looked down on by most
5–8	Standard member of the community; one of the pack, whose opinion is unlikely to matter
9–12	Well-regarded member of the community; favorably viewed by many other members
13–16	Important member of the community; respected by most other members
17–18	Influential member of community, involved in most decision-making; liked by most
19	An extremely influential member of the community, looked up to by virtually everyone
20	Top-tier of leadership in the community; the head honcho.

If a Community Bond is chosen during the creation of your Protagonist, it typically begins with a default rating of half the Protagonist's Permanent Resources rating, rounded up (see **RESOURCES** on page 13). In a few cases, a Protagonist's Archetype indicates that they have a Community Bond with a certain fixed rating — the final rating should be either that value or half the Permanent Resources rating, whichever is higher.

This value can be optionally increased during the creation of your Protagonist by sacrificing one or more **BONUS SKILL POINT** picks (see page 19); the first skill pick sacrificed in this manner gives a bonus of +5 to the Community Bond's rating; each subsequent sacrifice adds +2 (to a maximum of 20).

It is also possible to elect for your Protagonist to take a Community Bond with a rating of 1 (and suffer the social effects of being a pariah to fellow members) and receive one extra Bonus Skill Point Pick to use on purchasing skills later in the process.

Sample Community Bonds

- Group which shelters in the same place
- Church or support group
- Craft or trade guild
- Secret society

Changes to Community Bonds During Play

The rating for a Community Bond applies individually to every member of that community, and to the community as a whole. If a Community Bond decreases in value, the relationship with each member of the community deteriorates. A Community Bond is permanently broken when its score drops to 0 (and the Protagonist is likely cast out of the nominated community).

If the community itself is entirely destroyed (e.g., every member killed or sent insane), or if the Protagonist permanently leaves it (e.g., by relocating to live in a new region) the bond is destroyed.

If a Community Bond is broken by either means, the Protagonist will likely suffer negative impacts (see **BROKEN BONDS**, nearby).

During play, events may arise where the reactions of NPCs from the Protagonist's bonded community (or the community as a whole) have an impact. In some cases, the Protagonist may instigate such situations (e.g., by requesting aid from the community or trying to convince them of impending danger). In such situations the Game Moderator may ask for a test against **Community Bond Rating × 5**. Success means that the NPC or the community reacts favorably.

2.8.3 Describing Bonds

Identify each Individual and Community Bond: "My Wife." "My Husband and Kids." "My church congregation." "The Society of Amateur Sleuths."

An Individual Bond must be a real person or group of people who the Protagonist believes to be alive, and with which there is some (potential) opportunity to interact.

A Community Bond must be a real group who recognizes the Protagonist as a member.

2.8.4 Broken Bonds

When a Bond deteriorates, that relationship becomes strained. Exactly what shape that takes in play is up to you and the Game Moderator (playing the NPCs).

Bonds often fall apart because of events beyond your Protagonist's control. An example for Individual Bonds: your Protagonist's husband might leave for another woman. An example for Community Bonds: a new leader might ascend to power who is actively antagonistic towards your Protagonist.

If such a disaster harms the subject of a Bond, that reduces the Bond's value by 1D4. If that disaster permanently removes the subject of the Bond, that Bond is gone. Cross it off the sheet.

When damage to a Bond reduces it to 0, the relationship is damaged beyond repair. Cross it off the sheet. The only way to regain a Bond with that character or community is to build it from scratch as if it had never existed (see **DOWNTIME** on page 59 for details on creating new Bonds).

The breaking of any Bond is almost certainly traumatic and is likely to trigger a Sanity test due to Helplessness (see page 51).

When you cross a Bond off your Protagonist's character sheet, don't erase it. After all, there's no forgetting a vital relationship that went bad.

2.8.5 Bonds Forged Through Shared Adversity

Protagonists often band together into small tight-knit groups, to enhance their chances. This is true when the group is alone in the wasteland; it's often also true even when they are outsiders in a larger settlement. If those tight-knit groups go through terrifying ordeals together, there is a strong chance that they will become psychologically bound together through that shared experience.

In game terms, groups of Protagonists tend to form individual bonds to one another when they spend most of their time fighting the forces of the Mythos. Whenever your Protagonist is part of a team that completes a harrowing adventure, there's a chance of such trauma-generated bonds forming or deepening. This is the case if the scenario played out in a way where:

- One or more members of the team suffered temporary insanity, or
- One or more members of the team gained a new psychological disorder, or
- One or more members of the team died or was incapacitated by physical injuries, or
- Any other event occurred that the Game Moderator thinks was shocking enough to constitute severe trauma.

In the downtime after the adventure (see **DOWNTIME** on page 59), all Protagonists that made it back must make a SAN test. If the roll succeeds, nothing changes. If your Protagonist fails the SAN roll, they gain or strengthens an individual bond with EACH fellow Protagonist who also made it through the same trauma (up to a maximum of five fellow Protagonists).

For each such fellow trauma-sufferer,

- If your Protagonist has **no previous bond** with that person, they gain a brand-new individual Bond to that person at a rating equal to half your Protagonist's CHA. Add the new Bond to your Protagonist's character sheet. This focusing of attention comes at a detrimental cost to other pre-existing Bonds — you must lose 1D4 points from one other bond of your choice (either an Individual or Community Bond).
- If your Protagonist **already has an Individual Bond** with that person, the bond is increased by 1D4 points (up to a maximum value equal to CHA); at the same time 1 point must be subtracted from another bond of the player's choice (either an Individual or Community Bond). Note that even if all your Protagonist's existing bonds are already at the maximum score (and hence can't increase), you still need to pick a bond to weaken by 1.

Remember that if a Bond is ever reduced to 0 or less it is broken, as per the previous section.

When choosing a Bond to weaken during this process you *CANNOT* pick a bond to an individual who was with your Protagonist on the recently completed adventure. You MAY, however, pick an Individual Bond gained from an earlier shared traumatic encounter.

Rather than treating this as a mechanical process, you and your Game Moderator are encouraged to work together to describe the changed dynamic between your Protagonist and those around them. If points have been gained with fellow adventurers, does that mean they are beginning to feel comfort that their colleagues will always have their back? Or has the shared experience kindled a romance of sorts? Conversely, if a bond has been weakened, does that mean the Protagonist has been neglecting a member of their circle of friends and both are now feeling their friendship is slipping away?

If a community bond has weakened does it mean that the excessive time spent socializing with the tight-knit group has alienated others in the community to the point that they have lost confidence in the Protagonist? Or have they just missed so many gatherings that their standing as a high-status member of society has eroded?

Trading-in Skill Point Picks

As described in previous sections on **RESOURCES** (page 13) and **BONDS** (page 16), you have the option during Protagonist creation to trade-in one or more Bonus Skill Picks in return for non-skill advantages. Alternatively, your Protagonist can earn an extra Bonus Skill Pick or two if you are willing to sacrifice some of the normal benefits of those other starting ratings.

Trading Skill Point Picks for Resources Rating

You may elect to sacrifice one or more Bonus Skill Point Picks to improve your Protagonist's starting rating in Permanent Resources:

- Sacrificing one Bonus Skill Point Pick grants a +5 increase to Permanent Resources.
- Sacrificing further Bonus Picks grants +2 for each extra pick sacrificed.
- There is no limit to how high the Permanent Resources rating can go.
- Note that boosting Permanent Resources rating will also increase the starting value of all Community Bonds (which start equal to half this value).

As an alternative, if you are willing for your Protagonist to have a Resources rating of 0 (absolutely without any worldly goods), that sacrifice earns one EXTRA Bonus Skill Point Pick.

Trading Skill Point Picks for Community Bond Rating

You can elect to sacrifice one or more Bonus Skill Point Picks to improve the starting rating of your Protagonist's Community Bonds.

- Sacrificing one Bonus Skill Point Pick grants a +5 increase to the value of one Community Bond.
- Sacrificing further Bonus Picks to the same Bond grants +2 for each extra pick sacrificed. Sacrificing a pick towards a different Bond achieves the full increase stated above.
- Community Bond strengths can only be increased to a maximum of 20 (at which point your Protagonist is the community's top leader).

Alternatively, if you are willing for your Protagonist to set a Community Bond to a value of 1 (ready to break at the slightest provocation, with possibly disastrous social outcome), that sacrifice earns one EXTRA Bonus Skill Point Pick. You can claim this reward multiple times if you wish to set several Community Bonds to 1.

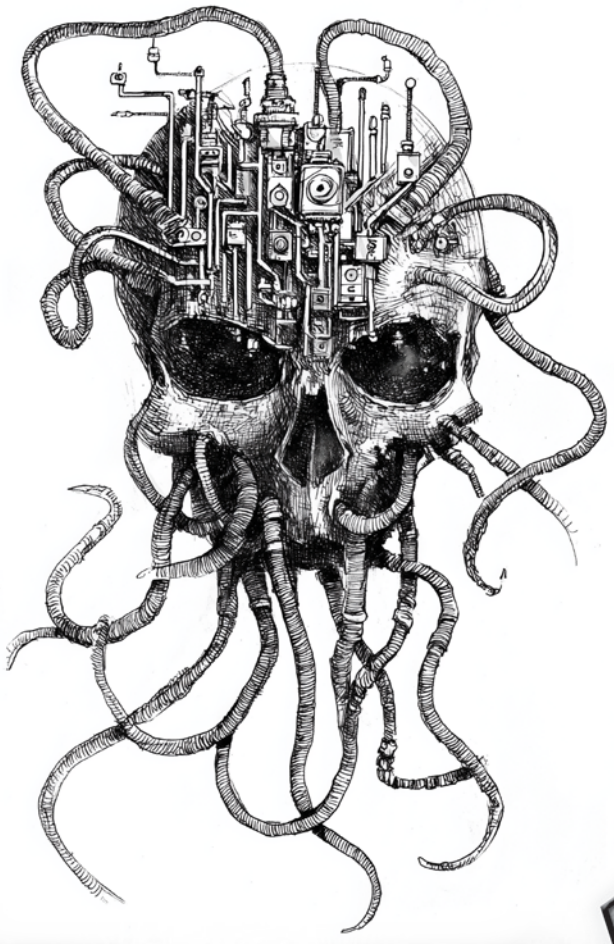
2.9 Detailed Description: Bonus Skill Points

The skill package associated with your Protagonist's Archetype coupled with the Adversity skills from the harshness of their upbringing, represent their core proficiencies. But they certainly aren't the full story about everything the Protagonist is good at.

Each Protagonist begins with ten Bonus Skill Point Picks. Each pick provides a boost of 20 points to whichever skill it is applied. Alternatively, some of these skill picks can be traded-in for non-skill benefits instead (see box nearby).

When applying a skill pick to a skill which has NOT been set by the Protagonist's Archetype or increased through Adversity Skill Picks, then add the 20 to its base rating. Otherwise, add 20 to its current score. This allows your Protagonist to specialize in certain Archetypal skills or to learn a little about skills not included in their Archetype. You can even boost a single skill more than once, adding +20 each time.

Unless the Game Moderator says otherwise, you can't raise a skill higher than 80% during Protagonist creation. You must assign (or trade-in) all bonus points to skills before play begins.



2.10 Detailed Description: Skills

A skill represents expertise gained with intensive training or study. If you make a skill roll, your Protagonist is doing something that would leave untrained people lost.

Anyone can attempt a **DEX×5** test to keep from falling over in an out-of-control semi trailer; only someone who's been trained in the Drive skill can steer the battered vehicle away from the grasping, howling thing tearing at its cabin..

Roll your Protagonist's skill or lower on 1D100 to succeed at using the skill under dire circumstances. Skills improve through practice and experience.

2.10.1 Base Rating

Every skill lists its base rating. If a skill has a base rating of 1% or greater, anyone can attempt to use it. A skill at 0% can't be used at all. No skill can be higher than 99%.

Rating	What the Rating Represents
01% to 19%	Dabbler.
20% to 29%	A dedicated hobbyist; with a foreign language you can have rudimentary conversations.
30% to 39%	Equivalent of a dedicated basic training.
40% to 59%	Equivalent of a dedicated advanced training or years of practical experience; with 50% in a foreign language you have native fluency.
60% to 79%	Decades of experience, or equivalent of the highest level of advanced training.
80% to 99%	A lifetime's pursuit or equivalent of multiple related training qualifications.

2.10.2 How Skills Work

For details of specific skills, see the listing in **SKILL DESCRIPTIONS** starting on page 21.

When your Protagonist uses a skill, sometimes you roll dice and sometimes you don't.

USING A SKILL WITHOUT A ROLL: When circumstances are calm and controlled, you don't roll dice to have your Protagonist use a skill; the Game Moderator just needs to know how high your Protagonist's rating is.

For example, driving a truck when things are calm might simply require a certain amount in the Drive skill.

Using a skill without rolling means randomness is not a factor. It's about having the right skill, looking in the right place, and asking the right questions. The more subtle the clue, the higher the skill your Protagonist must have to figure it out.

USING A SKILL WITH A ROLL: Roll skill dice only when the outcome is in doubt. That usually means there's a crisis or the circumstances are not under your Protagonist's control. The higher the skill rating, the better your Protagonist's chance of success. For details, see **USING SKILLS** on page 27.

2.10.3 Common Knowledge

Most Protagonists picked up some basic knowledge as they grew up. Because of this, they have some basic understanding of common things like how their society works and what types of jobs do what; and some basic abilities like how to flee danger. These don't require

Skills and Base Ratings

Administration (10)	Forensics (0)	Psychoanalyze (10)
Alertness (20)	Harangue (10)	Regional Lore (Type) (0)
Anthropology (0)	Heavy Machinery (10)	Research (10)
Appraise (10)	History (10)	Ride (10)
Archeology (0)	Insight (10)	Science (Type) (0)
Art (Type) (0)	Law (Type) (0)	Search (20)
Athletics (30)	Medicine (0)	Stealth (10)
Charm (20)	Melee Weapons (30)	Surgery (0)
Craft (Type) (0)	Military Training (Type) (0)	Survival (Type) (10)
Disguise (10)	Natural World (10)	Swim (20)
Dodge (30)	Navigate (10)	Technology Use (0)
Drive (20)	Occult (10)	Track (10)
Firearms (20)	Persuade (20)	Unarmed Combat (20)
First Aid (10)	Pharmacy (0)	Unnatural (0)
Foreign Language (Type) (0)	Pilot (Type) (0)	

specific skills. Skills represents deep, specialized training or education, but Protagonists can sometimes get by on common knowledge. Calling on common knowledge requires an INT×5 test or having a certain level of INT. Charming someone with unskilled art is usually a CHA or DEX test. Other efforts use other stats. The Game Moderator decides whether a task requires the general ability of a stat or the specialization of a skill.

2.10.4 Improving Skills

We learn from failure. If your Protagonist has at least 1% in a skill (any except Unnatural), it can improve when your Protagonists attempts to use it and fails. Gaining an entirely new skill requires special training (see **DOWNTIME** on page 59).

On the character sheet, next to every skill except Unnatural, there is a check box. When your Protagonist tries to use a skill and ***fails***, put a checkmark in that skill's box. At the end of each game session, add 1D4 percentage point to every skill that has a check next to it and erase the check.

FAILING WITHOUT ROLLING: If your Protagonist attempts a challenging task that requires a certain level of skill but not a roll, and fails because the task requires more skill than your Protagonist has, put a check in the box.

2.10.5 Skill Descriptions

Administration

Base Rating: 10%

A knowledge of how bureaucracies work and what kinds of forms, paperwork, journals, etc. it invariably generates. Use it to sift through detailed financial records or proceedings of club meetings to find that one quirky point that just doesn't seem to fit the usual pattern.

Use this skill to rapidly navigate your way adeptly through administrative records to find what's important. Note that this skill is primarily about interpreting information you have; if you need to actively go out and track down books, records, etc. that would be covered by the **Research** skill.

Alertness

Base Rating: 20%

Alertness detects danger. Use it to hear a weapon being readied, to understand the mumbling on the other side of a wall, to spot a concealed item hidden under a jacket, or to catch someone who is trying to escape notice using Stealth.

Anthropology

Base Rating: 0%

The study of living human cultures. Use it to understand morals, religious beliefs, customs, and mores, and to identify (but not translate) obscure languages. Where History is about the distant past and Archeology studies physical artifacts, Anthropology is about the behaviors of living cultures and how they relate to each other and the past.

Appraise

Base Rating: 10%

The ability to quickly determine the true (intrinsic) value of an item. This is an important skill in ensuring that bartering exchange deals are favorable to you. It is also helpful in knowing what items or resources others might be willing to trade to obtain.

Archeology

Base Rating: 0%

The study of physical remains of human cultures. Use it to analyze a ruined structure to determine useful information about its purpose long ago or the circumstances of its destruction. Where Anthropology is about living cultures and History is a broad study of the past, Archeology discerns meaning from the artifacts left behind.

Art (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Expertise at creating or performing a work that sways emotions and opinions. It also encompasses knowledge of techniques and trends in your field, and the ability to tell a particular creator's real work from a fake. Anyone can draw a rough sketch; the Art skill reflects knowledge, practice, and talent. Each type of Art is a separate skill: Acting, Dance, Forgery, Music, Poetry, Sculpture, Singing, Storytelling, etc.

Athletics

Base Rating: 30%

Your Protagonist trains to get the most out of their strength and agility. Strength and Dexterity cover raw physical power and manual dexterity; the Athletics skill represents long practice doing things like running, jumping, climbing, and throwing.

Use Athletics to:

- Outrun someone (see **OPPOSED TESTS** on page 30).
- Jump an intimidating gap.
- Climb in a crisis.

- Land safely in a fall of up to three yards.
- Hit a target with a thrown knife or put a grenade exactly on target.
- Catch something without warning, such as intercepting a thrown grenade.

Charm

Base Rating: 20%

Changing someone else's viewpoint or convincing them to do something for you through guile, cunning, "buttering-up", or other such subtle techniques. It's not about threatening them (that's covered by the **Harangue** skill) or using cold logic to convince them (that's **Persuade**) but covers all those other soft-touch methods. With Charm you might be able to connect with an individual on a more personal level — maybe even seduce them — and such changes can become long-held attitudes or beliefs. If the target of the skill starts from an antagonistic viewpoint, some form of **OPPOSED TEST** will probably be needed to overcome their negative impression.

Craft (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Making and repairing sophisticated tools and structures. A job that most people could figure out does not require the Craft skill, only an INT or DEX test. Use Craft for specialized work that needs training: Craft (Mechanic) to get a broken apparatus working — or to sabotage one beyond repair; Craft (Locksmith) to open a lock without a key, and so on.

A common specialization is **Craft (Jury-Rigging)** which represents an ability to create lash-ups of equipment to perform a function when the proper tool for the job is unavailable.

The Game Moderator decides whether a task requires Craft. Each Craft type is a separate skill: Blacksmith, Carpenter, Farmer, Jury-Rigging, Locksmith, Mechanic, etc.

Disguise

Base Rating: 10%

Alter your Protagonist's appearance, voice, posture, body language, and mannerisms to avoid recognition without drawing attention.

Dodge

Base Rating: 30%

Evading danger through instinct and reflexes. Use Dodge to avoid an attack. Against firearms and explosives, the Dodge skill is only useful to get to cover (see **DODGING RANGED ATTACKS** on page 35).

Drive

Base Rating: 20%

Handling any ground-based vehicle or conveyance safely in a crisis. Unless the Game Moderator says otherwise, every Protagonist can drive safely in normal conditions. Use this skill to keep a vehicle safe in a tense pursuit or on dangerous terrain.

Firearms

Base Rating: 20%

Safe and accurate shooting with common firearms in combat. Use it to hit a target despite the adrenaline, panic, and shock of violence interfering with hand-eye coordination.

First Aid

Base Rating: 10%

The initial treatment and stabilization of injuries. Use it to help a character recover lost Hit Points. By comparison, Surgery corrects a severe wound and Medicine ensures long-term recovery. (See **HEALING** on page 36.)

Foreign Language (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Fluency in another language. Each foreign language is a distinct skill. Having 20% allows halting conversations; at 50% your Protagonist speaks and reads like a native. The greater the skill, the greater the complexity of the information your Protagonist comprehends and the less time it takes. You don't need to roll a Foreign Language skill unless the Game Moderator says the situation is exceptionally difficult.

Forensics

Base Rating: 0%

Gathering detailed information and evidence based on an assessment of human remains. Use it to hypothesize about the cause of a fire, trace the trajectory that a bullet followed, or determine whether a pool of blood is consistent with a major or minor injury.



Harangue

Base Rating: 10%

The art of browbeating someone into agreeing with your point of view or agreeing to do something you want them to do. This technique is not a subtle attempt to engage with their good nature (that's covered by the Charm skill) or their logical reason (that's Persuade) — instead it's all about bluster, shouting, and threats. But sometimes these can be more successful than other techniques, although the individuals on the receiving end are unlikely to enjoy the interaction quite so much.

Heavy Machinery

Base Rating: 10%

Safe operation of a tractor, crane, thresher, steam train, or other big machine in a crisis.

History

Base Rating: 10%

Uncovering facts and theories about human antiquity. Use it to remember or find a key fact about the distant past, recognize an obscure reference, or comb through records that nobody without your deep education could find. While Anthropology is about living cultures and Archaeology studies the meaning of ancient relics, History is a broad study of humanity.

Insight

Base Rating: 10%

Insight obtains information about a person — especially information the subject would rather conceal — through observation, conversation, or examining patterns of behavior and relationships. Use Insight to recognize signs of dishonesty from verbal cues and body language, gauge attitude and intentions, cultivate sources of information about a subject, determine what it would take to get a subject to cooperate, or recognize clues of what a subject wants to conceal.

Insight can notice signs of mental illness but Psychoanalyze would be needed to assist with a specific malady. A subject who deliberately tries to deceive your Protagonist can attempt an opposed test comparing their Persuade against your Protagonist's Insight (see **OPPOSED TESTS** on page 30).

Law (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Use this skill to understand and manipulate the power structures that exist within society, to either influence outcomes or bullshit your Protagonist's way out of trouble.

Different societies have their own systems of law — the understanding of each is a separate skill. Because all societies are based on common human behavior, you can attempt to use your Law skill at *half* chance to navigate the vagaries of an entirely new and unfamiliar social order.

Medicine

Base Rating: 0%

The study and treatment of injury and illness. Use it to diagnose the cause of an injury, disease, or poisoning, identify abnormalities such as toxins or diseases, identify the cause and approximate time of death, identify a dead person's last meal, or prescribe proper long-term care. By comparison, First Aid keeps a patient alive until surgery is possible, and Surgery corrects a severe wound. (See **HEALING** on page 36).

Melee Weapons

Base Rating: 30%

Lethal use of melee weapons in combat. Use it to hurt or kill an opponent with a knife, axe, club, or other hand-held weapon.

Military Training (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Many people spend a part of their careers in some form of military service to a crown or other empire — whether as part of an army or navy, or even on boats in coastal waters. A great many people are also employed in the giant bureaucracy that keeps the military supplied and functioning. This skill represents first-hand training and experience obtained through time spent in one such military service. Use it to apply military tactics or strategies to a situation, to recall specific details about a particular military unit or corps, or to know your way around common military-issue equipment.

Natural World

Base Rating: 10%

The common understanding of the natural world as practiced by farmers, fishermen, and others who make a living based upon the changing patterns of the weather, tides, etc. It also covers the broad understanding of the natural habits of animals, as well as the different uses of specific plant species. Use this skill to determine whether observed behavior of natural forces or creatures is consistent with "normal" or common patterns, or not.

Navigate

Base Rating: 10%

Finding your way quickly with maps, charts and tables, orienteering, compass, or dead reckoning.

Occult

Base Rating: 10%

The study of the supernatural as understood by human traditions, including things like magick, folklore, and secret societies. Use Occult to examine and deduce the intent of a ritual, or to identify occult traditions, groups, grimoires, tools, symbols, or legends.

Occult can never tell a Protagonist what's genuinely unnatural and what's just superstition or mythology. That's the province of the Unnatural skill.

Persuade

Base Rating: 20%

Changing another's deeply held decision or desire. Use Persuade to get your Protagonist's way when the subject is so stubborn, what your Protagonist wants is so valuable, or the deception is so flagrant that Charisma isn't enough.

With Persuade, your Protagonist might convince a witness that what they saw was innocuous and not unnatural, talk a compound leader into helping you cover up an outbreak to avoid a mass panic, or draw useful information out of an unwilling subject.

This skill also allows your Protagonist to resist persuasion and interrogation in opposed Persuade rolls (see **OPPOSED TESTS** on page 30).

Pharmacy

Base Rating: 0%

Knowledge of drugs and herbal remedies, from their ingredients and creation, to their effects, uses, and misuses. Use it to identify and produce medicines and antidotes — as well as poisons.

Identifying a drug or medicinal herb requires at least 20% skill. Preparing a particularly powerful treatment safely, such as one with psychoactive effects, requires at least 40% skill or a successful roll. Misusing Pharmacy is a quick way to kill a patient (see **POISON AND DISEASE** on page 43.

Pilot (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Piloting, navigating, and captaining waterborne, or airborne vehicles. Use it to keep a vessel safe in a crisis, such as through a storm or in a dangerous pursuit. Each vessel type is a separate skill: Airplane, Drone, Helicopter, Airship, Small Boat, Ship, etc.

Psychoanalyze

Base Rating: 10%

The diagnosis and treatment of mental illness. Use it to identify a mental disorder, help a patient recover, talk someone down when a disorder begins to take over, and treat mental illness in the long term. You cannot use Psychoanalysis on yourself. Using Psychoanalysis to aid someone who suffered exposure to Cthulhu Mythos forces might cost the therapist SAN; see **THREATS TO SAN** on page 51.

Regional Lore (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

Most educated people know a little bit about every place, but if you've spent a long time living in (or studying) a specific region you learn so much more. This skill represents a deep understanding of the people, places, and common practices that are unique to one particular region. Use it to recall folktales that villagers tell, unique local words, or unusual ruins and earthworks found in the region. It can also cover quirky superstitions and rites that are particular to the region.

Research

Base Rating: 10%

The ability to find specific information in a large repository or buried in files, records, or ledger books. Use this skill to navigate a library catalogue system, pull out buried details in account records, or otherwise locate whatever relevant information lies buried.

Ride

Base Rating: 10%

Handling, training, and riding an animal — horses, donkeys, camels, whatever. Use it to keep safe on an animal in a crisis and to keep riding animals safe, calm, and healthy.

Science (Type)

Base Rating: 0%

The deep study of the processes of the world. This is more than common schooling; anyone can attempt an INT test to remember facts from whatever (rudimentary) schooling they received. Science is used to find a key insight about the way the universe works — or at least, the way it's supposed to work. Each Science is a separate skill: Astronomy, Biology, Botany, Chemistry, Engineering, Genetics, Geology, Mathematics, Meteorology, Physics, Planetology, Zoology, etc.



Search

Base Rating: 20%

Finding things that are concealed or obscured from plain sight. Searching an abandoned dwelling may not require the Search skill, only time and effort, or a sufficiently high INT. Use Search to find an object that was hidden with the Stealth skill or is otherwise so well hidden or disguised that it needs an expert. The Game Moderator may roll the Search attempt, so you don't know whether your Protagonist succeeded or failed.

Stealth

Base Rating: 10%

Concealing your presence or activities. Use it to hide a weapon, camouflage a position, conceal an occult amulet, pick a pocket, move silently, follow without being seen, or blend into a crowd. A Protagonist attempting Stealth can be detected only by an opposing Alertness or Search skill (see **OPPOSED TESTS** on page 30).

Surgery

Base Rating: 0%

The treatment of an injury or abnormality, by invasive means. By comparison, First Aid keeps a patient alive until surgery is possible, and Medicine ensures long term recovery. (See **HEALING** on page 36)

Survival (Type)

Base Rating: 10%

Knowledge of the natural world. Use it to plan an expedition, predict weather, recognize when fauna or flora are unusual, use the environment to gather other information, or find food, water, and shelter. Each type of Survival is its own skill. Common types are Desert, Jungle, Tundra, Urban.

Swim

Base Rating: 20%

Most Protagonists can swim for leisure. Use the Swim skill in a dangerous crisis: going a long distance in choppy water, keeping a friend from drowning, or getting to a boat before the tentacled thing below grabs you.

Technology Use

Base Rating: 0%

Nobody needs to make a skill roll to use devices and technologies that are in common use in the era and setting of the game. However, making effective use of highly-specialized or technical apparatus is a different question. In the hands on the untrained, such devices are at best useless, and at worst dangerous. Technology Use is an umbrella skill allowing your Protagonist to successfully use all manner of common technical devices.

For specific applications of Technology Use to by-passing electronic or cyber security, see the box on the next page.

Track

Base Rating: 10%

Use this to locate the tracks of a specific creature or person and follow them. A test must be made to locate the trail and then again once every ten minutes they are being followed. Penalties or bonuses may apply depending on how long it was since the tracks were made, what the ground is like, what the weather conditions have been since the tracks were made, etc.

Unarmed Combat

Base Rating: 20%

Self-defense. A fight between untrained combatants often involves more shoving and shouting than real violence. Use Unarmed Combat to hurt or kill an opponent with your Protagonist's bare hands (or feet, elbows, teeth, or head).

Unnatural

Base Rating: 0%

Knowledge of the fundamental, mind-shattering secrets of the universe. The things that slithered in the dark corners of the world and the cosmos beyond. Use it to remember, recognize, or research facts about the things humans consider unnatural. This goes far beyond the occult, because the Unnatural skill represents things that are real. Use it to sift through the darkest parts of myth and folklore and recognize which of it is true.

Hacking and Cyber Warfare

Many modern settings feature information systems (like the Internet, or forms of Social Media) and real-world items whose operation is controlled by some form of computer or similar device (or A.I.). All such virtual environments and "smart" devices share one important feature — they can be maliciously misused if someone breaks whatever security features exist to authorize legitimate users, control access to confidential information and maintain its integrity, and keep systems available. Efforts to break such controls is normally called "Hacking", although if it is done on a large-enough scale (or by a military force) it might be considered "cyber warfare".

There is no special skill in this version of *Cthulhu Eternal* to cover hacking and cyber warfare — instead they are all considered applications of the **Technology Use** skill. So, whenever Protagonists are trying to guess the password on a laptop or hack into a mainframe to obtain a cult's deepest, darkest secrets they are leveraging their Technology Use skill.

For simple hacking, such as guessing a password, a single Technology Use test can get the job done. However, hacking can get much more complex.

A more difficult hacking attempt might use something similar to the Pursuit rules (a series of **OPPOSED TESTS**, see page 30). In this, the Protagonist (attacker) is the quarry and the defenders — whether they be an autonomous A.I. Eldritch horror or a corporate security operations center — is the "pursuer". The GM should set the number of wins each side needs (default of 2–3); i.e., how many successes are needed for the Protagonist to break into the system and/or how many the defenders need to achieve to fully boot the Protagonist out of the system (and potentially learn their location, either in the real world or on the network).

Each side rolls tests against their **Technology Use** skill. A success counts as a win; wins on both sides cancel each other out. If both fail their rolls, the higher dice roll wins. A critical success counts as two wins.

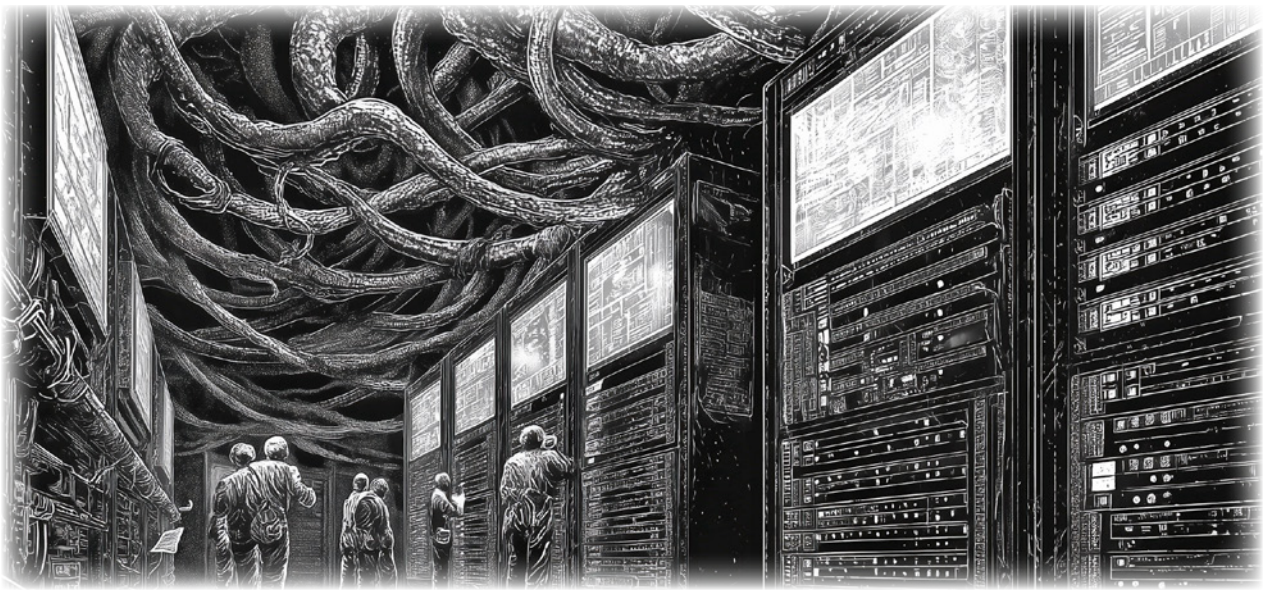
Bonuses and penalties can also be applied to Technology Use tests, increasing or decreasing the chance of a success.

Some examples:

- Password under the keyboard, or on a Post-It Note: Automatic success
- Easy password: +20%
- Hard, complex password: -20%
- Anti-virus Software in place: +10%
- Corporate level monitoring software: -10%
- Security software powered by Alien technology (e.g., a Mi-Go A.I.): -30%
- Good Firewall in place: -15%

If the Protagonists are trying to gain access to an especially large and sprawling system or network, the GM may decide that it has several "layers". Breaking the first might get the hackers some basic access, but to get to the "crown jewels" they will need to get through further security perimeters.

If the entities running the target system are sloppy, there may well be data files in the lower-security "layers" which help someone in escalating their privilege through other layers (at the GM's discretion such lapses might give someone a +20% or +40% bonus to the subsequent attempts).



2.11 Detailed Description: Mental Damage from Harsh Upbringings

Protagonists that have grown up in difficult and brutal conditions are likely to have picked up some mental scarring along the way. This can leave them hardened to certain types of traumatic stimuli. It might also make them psychologically distant from those around them, or even afflicted with mental disorders.

Mental Damage gained from a harsh early life can take several forms:

1. Becoming adapted to specific types of psychological trauma (see **ADAPTING TO SAN LOSS**, page 57),
2. **MENTAL DISORDERS** (page 53), or
3. Generally becoming more distant with other people.

The table below shows the possible mental damage to your Protagonist based on the Harshness Descriptor for the environment they grew up in.

Harshness	Potential for Mental Damage
Normal(ish)	None
Harsh	If CHA or POW Is less than 7, Protagonist loses 1D4 from two Bonds (player choice, each can be either an Individual or Community Bond)
Very Harsh	1. Make a **POW×4** test; failure indicates 1 starting mental disorder 2. If CHA or POW Is less than 10, Protagonist starts Adapted to either Violence OR Helplessness (pick one; apply the necessary modifiers to stats and bonds, see below)

Roll to determine mental disorders first; if any are acquired, work with the Game Moderator to pick something appropriate from the list of mental disorders starting on page 55.

If your Protagonist begins the game Adapted to either Violence or Helplessness place a check mark in the appropriate box on the character sheet and make the following adjustment to statistics and bonds:

- **If Adapted to Violence:** Reduce CHA by 1D6 and subtract the same number from every bond (both Individual and Community).
- **If Adapted to Helplessness:** Reduce POW by 1D6.

3.0 The Game

Cthulhu Eternal is a game about unveiling — and perhaps defeating — the horrific yet hidden entities of the Cthulhu Mythos that haunt our reality. The world seems mundane, but this is a façade. In dark corners and hidden places, the extra-dimensional and extra-terrestrial horrors lurk. Most people never learn of their existence, but some come to worship or follow such inimical forces. Others who learn the true nature of reality — of those dark entities, and insane devotees they inspire — cannot help but make a stand to defeat their terrible plans. These are Protagonists. Their fight might be never-ending, but the cost of losing is too great. They are the line that separates the sane world we know and the Apocalypse.

Protagonists are usually every-day people who have been awakened to the truth about our world. They usually aren't superhuman, powerful, or invulnerable. Rather, they are frequently humble, vulnerable, and fragile individuals who have chosen to fight the unknowable but vast powers of the Cthulhu Mythos. Not because they have the strength to conquer the horrors, but because the consequence of inaction is beyond the pale.

Here's how the game works.

3.1 Using Skills

The *Cthulhu Eternal* rules focus on skills. You decide what your Protagonist attempts to do; the Game Moderator determines what skill to use. In a typical adventure, Protagonists use many different skills.

Sometimes using a skill requires a roll of dice. The most important rule is this: The Game Moderator determines if, when, and what you roll. If the Game Moderator says a roll isn't needed, the skill rating itself determines success or failure.

3.1.1 Resolving a Test Without Dice

If the Game Moderator decides you don't need to roll, it comes down to what you're trying to do and how high your Protagonist's skill is. If the fact is common knowledge for your Protagonist's Archetype, or can be found with a little research, they might be able to get it by just expending time and effort. If it requires special knowledge, your Protagonist may need a certain amount of a skill.

If the Game Moderator thinks a fact should be known by a history expert with at least 60% skill, then a Protagonist with a relevant history-related skill at 60% or better knows the fact without rolling. Or perhaps a Protagonist with 40% can learn some clues but a Protagonist with 60% would learn more.

Sometimes a combination of skills can overcome a lack in one. A clue that needs 60% in a history-related skill might be available if the Protagonist has both a history skill and some other relevant skill at 40%.

How Much Skill Does the Task Require?

Only a little training; a hobbyist	20%
Basic training or minor training	30%
Years of experience or training	40%
Decades of experience or training	60%
A lifetime's mastery	80%

3.1.2 Resolving a Test With Dice

If the Game Moderator tells you to roll a skill, it's a skill test. The dice determine success or failure. Roll two ten-sided dice to get a number from 01 to 00 (1 to 100).

Roll your skill test rating or lower to succeed. Rolling higher than the skill test rating means failure.

There are three criteria for rolling dice for a skill test:

ROLL WHEN IT IS DIFFICULT: A skill test means the Protagonist is attempting something difficult. After all, even an expert in a skill might have only a 60% or 70% rating. A skill test is for a situation when even an expert might fail.

ROLL WHEN THE SITUATION IS UNPREDICTABLE: Having to roll means the situation is out of control. Randomness plays a major role. Surprising, possibly disastrous things can happen, no matter how skillful you are.

ROLL WHEN THERE ARE CONSEQUENCES: Failing a skill roll means ugly things are going to happen. Maybe failing at the crisis is the punishment — or with a failed roll, your Protagonist succeeds but the consequences are severe. The fallout is up to the Game Moderator.

3.1.3 If You Don't Have the Skill

If your Protagonist has a 0 in a skill, they can't even attempt to use it. It requires specialized training or education that your Protagonist lacks.

3.1.4 Using a Stat

If your Protagonist tries to do something that anyone ought to be able to do — something that's hard, but doesn't require specific training like a skill — then the Game Moderator might look to one of your Protagonist's stats, for a stat test. A stat test is the relevant stat × 5. (So with STR 11, a STR test is 55%.)

Use STR if the challenge requires physical power, CON if it requires endurance, DEX if it requires agility, INT if it requires attention to detail, POW if it requires mental resilience, or CHA if it requires charm.

The stat's score itself may tell the Game Moderator whether your Protagonist succeeds, without the need for a roll. Does it need someone with at least average Strength? Then your Protagonist needs a STR of 10 or more. If it needs someone with above-average Intelligence, your Protagonist must have an INT of at least 13. If only one person in a hundred would have enough stamina, your Protagonist needs a CON of 17 or 18. (See **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: STATISTICS** on page 6.)

How Much Stat Does the Task Require?

Anyone could do it	3–4
Nearly anyone could do it	5–8
An average person could do it	9–12
Only an unusually gifted person could do it	13–16
Only a prodigy could do it	17–18

3.1.5 Bonuses and Penalties

Having to make a skill test in the first place means there's a substantial chance of failure. But if the odds are really against your Protagonist, the Game Moderator might impose a penalty, down to a minimum chance of 1%. If the situation is a little more in your Protagonist's favor, the Game Moderator might allow a bonus, up to a maximum chance of 99%.

If a bonus or penalty applies, it's usually +20%/−20% or rarely +40%/−40%.

Bonus or Penalty	Frequency	Description
+40%	Rare	You *almost* shouldn't even bother to roll
+20%	Uncommon	Circumstances are noticeably in your favor
No modifier	Most circumstances	The action is difficult and unpredictable
-20%	Uncommon	Circumstances are noticeably worse than usual.
-40%	Rare	You *almost* shouldn't even bother to roll.

3.1.6 Who Rolls?

A group of Protagonists is searching the cult leader's camp. Who makes the Alertness skill roll to spot a trap? Good question.

If it's a task where having more help is useful, use the highest skill among the team.

If it's a task where a crowd is a hindrance, use the lowest skill among the team.

If it's a task where you need to know whether every Protagonist succeeds or fails ("How many of you get a good look at the thing in the shadows?"), each player rolls.

3.2 Success and Failure

On any skill or stat test, there are only four possible outcomes. From best to worst they are: Critical Success, Success, Failure, and Fumble. Ordinary success and failure are most common. Critical successes and fumbles represent exceptionally good or terrible outcomes.

3.2.1 Critical Success

A critical success is a roll of 01 or any success where the dice digits match one another. So if your Protagonist's skill is 50%, you achieve a critical success with a roll of 01, 11, 22, 33, or 44. A critical success **automatically** succeeds, and exceeds expectations. A critical is twice as good as an ordinary success. What twice as good means must be taken in context of the action. In combat, a critical success means double damage, but during an investigation, it might mean the action takes half as long.

3.2.2 Success

A success is a roll equal to or less than the test chance. With a success, your Protagonist accomplishes what they set out to achieve.

3.2.3 Failure

A failure is a roll that's higher than the test chance. Sometimes that means your Protagonist suffers harm.

There may be times when a failed roll means a Protagonist achieves what they wanted — but it comes with an unpleasant complication. The Game Moderator always decides whether that's the case and what the cost will be. For a few possibilities, see the effects of fumbling a roll.

3.2.4 Fumble

A fumble is a roll of 00 (100) or any failure where the dice digits match one another. So if your Protagonist's skill is 50%, you fumble on a roll of 55, 66, 77, 88, 99, or 00. A fumbled roll fails, no matter how high your Protagonist's chance of success, and has additional, catastrophic consequences.



In a car chase, a fumble might mean your Protagonist crashes. In a gunfight, a weapon might jam, or you might accidentally shoot yourself. The exact complications are up to the Game Moderator. Here are some possibilities.

PHYSICAL STRAIN: Lose 1D6 HP or temporarily lose 1D4 STR, CON, or DEX.

EMOTIONAL BURNOUT: Lose 1D6 WP or temporarily lose 1D4 INT, POW, or CHA.

ALIENATION: Offend an important NPC. All CHA or Persuade tests with the NPC automatically fail until the end of the adventure.

EXHAUSTION: Immediately become **EXHAUSTED** (see page 31).

DISTRACTION: Suffer a −20% penalty to your next test.

CONFUSION: You make a major error and gain false information.

Optional Rule: Critical Dice Rolling for Base Chance Over 100%

By default, a critical result can only be achieved when the two dice digits match. For most situations that means the chance of achieving a critical is about one-tenth that of overall success. However, when the base chance of success is over 100% (e.g., rolling a test of POW×5 for a supernatural entity with POW 30), maintaining this ratio of likelihood requires other, non-matching-digits, dice rolls also designate a critical result.

If this is desired, the table below can be used to achieve this, noting that regardless of the magnitude of the base chance there is always the possibility of rolling a fumble on 00 (see below).

Base Chance	Dice Rolls Indicating Critical Result	Dice Indicate Fumble
101% – 200%	Digits match, 01, or second digit is a 5 (e.g., 05, 15, 25)	00
201% – 300%	Digits match, 01, or second digit is a 5 or 6 (e.g., 05, 06, 15, 16)	00
301% – 400%	Digits match, 01, or second digit is a 4,5 or 6 (e.g., 04, 05, 06, 14, 15, 16)	00

In situations when the base chance is over 400%, the results of the test should likely be driven by story needs rather than dice rolls, and should be decided on a case-by-case basis by the Game Moderator.

As with all optional rules, the GM and players should agree before the game whether this rule is to be used.

Optional Rule: Nudging Skill and Stat Tests

By default, as soon as dice are rolled for a skill test or a stat test the result is set in stone — the number rolled determines whether the test was a success, failure, critical success, or fumble. There is no way to change the roll or to re-roll to achieve a different outcome.

Some players, however, prefer to have an option for dice rolls to be nudged: for "near misses" to be turned into successes at some other cost to the character. This optional rule delivers that, by allowing characters to sacrifice Willpower Points (WPs) to "nudge" the dice rolled for a skill or stat test. Using this optional rule makes the game slightly less harsh in terms of the randomness of the dice, but also adds a resource-management element to players rationing their Willpower Points.

Here's how nudging works for skill tests and stat tests:

- After a test has been rolled, a player can elect to spend any number of WPs, with each spend adjusting the dice roll either up or down as the player prefers.
- Each WP spent adjusts the original dice roll by **1—5 percentiles** (player's choice).
- "Nudging" a dice roll that originally indicated a failure may convert it into a roll indicating standard success; alternatively, a dice roll that was originally a standard success may be turned into a failure.
- This process cannot be used to alter the dice roll for a test performed by someone other than the character making the WP spend. Specifically, it cannot be used to modify the dice roll of an adversary.
- The sacrifice of WPs represents the character investing extra energy and focus to ensure that a borderline situation is resolved in the desired way. Doing this can trigger exhaustion and may make the tired character more susceptible to being affected by arcane powers, and less prepared to participate in rituals.
- "Nudging" a dice roll can never create a critical success or a fumble, and dice rolls that originally indicated a critical success or fumble cannot be "nudged". Even if the dice roll total obtained after a "nudge" is applied happens to be a number with matching digits, the result is still either a standard success or a failure.
- Remember that, as described in **WILLPOWER POINTS** (opposite), consequences may apply to a character whose WP total falls below 3.

Note: only skill tests and stat tests can be "nudged" in this way; SAN test and Luck tests cannot be "nudged".

As with all optional rules, the GM and players should agree before the game whether this rule is to be used. Another question to agree upon is whether "nudging" is available solely to Protagonists in the game or also an action that NPCs can perform.

3.3 The Luck Roll

Events often come down to pure chance.

Are adversaries awake when your Protagonist sneaks into the enemy's camp? Does the stolen car have a first aid kit in the trunk? When an unexpected burst of fire tears down the door, does a bullet find you?

If the Game Moderator calls for a Luck roll, there's a 50% chance that things go your Protagonist's way. It doesn't depend on psychic talent or your Protagonist's connection with the cosmos or anything else. Just roll the dice. With a critical success or a fumble, your Protagonist's luck is extra good or bad.

3.4 Time Required

Sometimes speed counts. The Game Moderator determines how long it takes to perform a test.

TURNS: It takes a few combat turns (see **THE TURN** on page 32) or, at most, sixty seconds. Combat, some skill tests, and most stat tests are resolved in turns.

MINUTES: It takes a few minutes. You can't do it in combat, but otherwise, your Protagonist can get through it rapidly. Many skill tests are resolved in minutes.

HOURS: It takes hours. Your Protagonist can typically attempt two to four such tasks per day (four only if your Protagonist goes without rest; see **EXHAUSTION**, opposite).

DAYS: It takes a day or more. Some extended skill tests, requiring multiple rolls, take days.

LONG-TERM: Efforts that take place outside normal gameplay, like research and training, fit here. It could be a week, a month, or years. It's up to the Game Moderator.

3.5 Opposed Tests

An opposed test happens when someone takes action to interfere with another's action.

This might be a player rolling a Protagonist's Insight to sense the lies in a compound leader's Persuade roll, a Protagonist escaping a pursuer with opposed Athletics tests, a degenerate cultist trying to wrestle a sacrificial victim to the ground in opposed Unarmed Combat tests, or a Protagonist's Dodge trying to oppose an alien monstrosity's attack roll.

Usually, skills oppose skills and stats oppose stats. A stat opposes a skill only when one character must use very specific knowledge or training (and therefore rolls a skill) but the other does not (and therefore rolls a stat). It is up to the Game Moderator.

By nature, opposed tests are very unlikely to succeed. Not only must your roll succeed, but you must overcome the opposition's roll as well.

If two characters' skills oppose each other but neither needs to roll, the higher **rating** wins.

Opposed Tests and Pursuits

	Opponent Succeeds	Opponent Fails
You Succeed	A critical success beats a success. Otherwise, whoever rolled higher succeeds and the other fails.	Your action succeeds and the opposed action fails.
You Fail	You fail to stop the opposed action.	Nobody succeeds; or whoever rolled lower succeeds and the other fails (Game Moderator's choice).

3.6 Pursuit

A pursuit is a series of opposed tests. The most basic chase is a single test for each side, pursuer and quarry. If the quarry wins, they escape and the chase ends. If the pursuer wins, they run the quarry down and the chase ends. Usually that means combat.

A more prolonged chase may require two wins by one side or the other. Wins cancel each other out. If the pursuer wins one but the quarry wins the next, that cancels out the pursuer's win. Then, the quarry needs to win twice more to escape. An especially wide-open chase might require three wins to either catch up or escape.

In each test, one side or the other wins. If both fail their rolls, the lowest failure wins. A critical success with a chase test counts as two wins. A fumble counts as two failures thanks to a wreck or some other disastrous accident.

WHICH SKILL APPLIES: A chase on foot requires **Athletics**; one in vehicles uses **Drive**, **Pilot**, or even **Heavy Machinery**; in the water, it uses **Swim**; on horseback, it uses **Ride**.

AID AND ADVANTAGES: Coordinating with multiple pursuers (whether they're in sight of each other or have constant contact by some means), or being substantially faster and/or more maneuverable grants a +20% bonus to each chase test, or +40% if the advantages are overwhelming.

SEEKING AN EDGE: Instead of the usual roll to catch up or get away, pursuer or quarry may attempt to gain some advantage by testing a skill that applies to the situation.

Possible skills include **Alertness**, **Navigate**, **Stealth**, or **Survival**.

If this test wins the contest, instead of a "win" it grants a +20% bonus to the next chase roll, or +40% with a critical success. Failure and fumbling have the usual effects.

COMBAT DURING A CHASE: A person in a chase may be able to launch attacks at opponents, especially if their skill isn't being used as the test for escaping or evading (e.g., they are a passenger on a conveyance controlled by someone else). These will usually be some form of ranged attack. Such attacks are resolved before the pursuer and quarry roll to pursue and escape. Attacks use the **COMBAT** rules, beginning on page 32. Each contest in the chase is equivalent to one combat turn.

If your Protagonist makes an attack but doing so will seriously impact their efforts to pursue or evade, the attack is considered to occur instead of a roll to pursue or escape — effectively meaning the opponent's roll to pursue or escape automatically wins that exchange. This will always be the case if the pursuit is on foot; in other situations it will depend on whether your Protagonist's skill at controlling their conveyance is a major factor in the chase (if in doubt, the GM can make a call).

3.7 Willpower Points

Willpower Points are mental fuel. Protagonists require Willpower Points to keep going despite exhaustion, to resist unwanted persuasion, to resist the effects of terror and mental disorders, and, on rare occasions, to resist or enact unnatural rituals.

LOW WILLPOWER POINTS: A Protagonist whose WP hits 1 or 2 has an emotional breakdown. The Protagonist suffers a −20% penalty to all actions until their WP rises above 2.

RUNNING OUT OF WILLPOWER POINTS: A Protagonist at 0 WP loses all control. This can look different for every Protagonist and every situation. The Protagonist might collapse in wracking sobs, or lash out wildly, or simply pass out. The Game Moderator controls your Protagonist until WP returns to 1 or higher and describes the reaction. A Protagonist with 0 WP cannot succeed at any tests, including SAN tests. Sooner or later the Protagonist falls asleep, regardless of any disorders or stimulants, long enough to regain WP.

REGAINING WILLPOWER POINTS: When your Protagonist gets a full night's sleep (but no more than once in a 24-hour period), they regain 1D6 WP. If you play up one of your Protagonist's personal motivations in a way the GM finds compelling, your Protagonist regains 1 WP.

3.7.1 Exhaustion

A Protagonist who works too long or faces extreme danger and injury without resting becomes exhausted. When this comes into play is up to the Game Moderator, but a good rule of thumb is that going a night without sleep or refusing to rest after losing SAN or Hit Points leads to exhaustion.

An exhausted Protagonist suffers a −20% penalty to all skills, stat tests, and SAN tests, and loses 1D6 WP. The exhausted Protagonist loses another 1D6 WP after going another night without sleep, after working hard for a few hours, or after running or fighting for a few minutes. A full night's sleep cures exhaustion.

STIMULANTS: Taking common types of stimulants offsets the exhaustion penalty for 1D6 hours. Examples in the Modern Era might include nicotine and caffeine.

Harder stimulants (if any are available) offset it for 2D6 hours. Examples in the Modern Era include cocaine, ritalin, methamphetamine and MDMA.

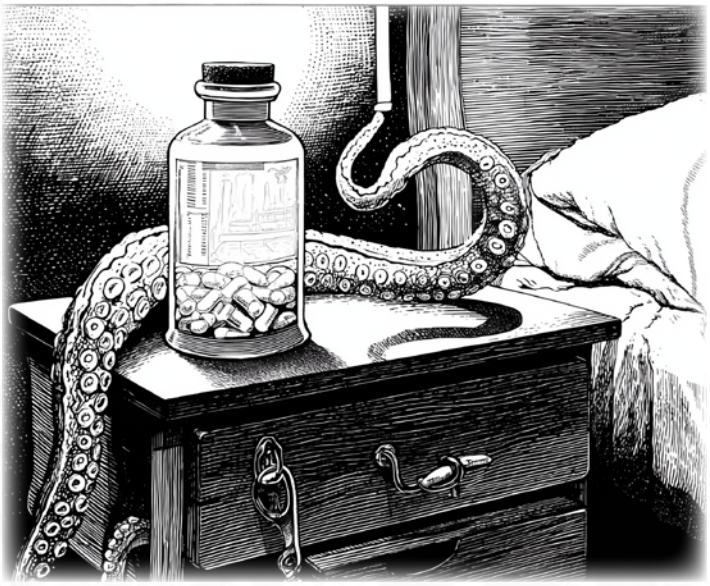
During this time, your Protagonist can't sleep. A Protagonist can take more stimulants to keep going, but every dose after the first costs 1D6 WP.

If your Protagonist gains a new mental disorder while using stimulants, the Game Moderator has good reason to say the disorder takes the form of addiction to them. (See **DISORDERS** on page 53.)

3.7.2 Sleeplessness

The first time your Protagonist tries to sleep after suffering temporary insanity or gaining a new mental disorder (see **TEMPORARY INSANITY** and **DISORDERS** on page 53), you must make a SAN test. If it fails, your Protagonist wakes in terror, losing the possibility of regaining any WP for 24 hours.

ARTIFICIAL SEDATION: A Protagonist may try to overcome sleeplessness via artificial means, such as drinking alcohol or using other similar sedatives. This gives a +20% bonus to the SAN test to get to sleep. If the test fails, the Protagonist gets no rest despite taking sedatives. In addition, the Protagonist is sick the next day, at a −20% penalty to all tests until they get a full night's rest. If your Protagonist gains a new mental disorder while using sedatives, the Game Moderator has good reason to say the disorder takes the form of an addiction to them.



4.0 Combat

A serious fight, where people are trying to kill each other, is chaotic, frightening, and fast. That's what these rules represent. Being skilled, having better weapons, or being in a superior position helps, but the inescapable randomness of combat can claim even the most skilled combatant's life.

Lovecraft's fiction presaged humanity's urge to reduce any confrontation with the unnatural to base combat. However, humanity's weapons are as ridiculous to the unnatural forces that control the universe as an ant wielding a pebble is to the bulldozer razing the field the ant hill stands in. Combat rarely resolves any unnatural threat.

4.1 The Turn

Combat is measured in turns. A turn is a few seconds, or as long as it takes everyone to complete a single action.

The Game Moderator counts down by DEX for all characters, from highest to lowest. Each character acts when their number comes up. If DEX scores tie, the actions occur at the same time or the Game Moderator can choose some tiebreaker.

During a turn, a combatant can attempt one of the following actions.

4.1.1 Aim

Sacrifice one turn to aim and gain a +20% to your attack next turn. Aiming requires no roll. After the next turn, or if your Protagonist suffers any damage before attempting it, the bonus is lost.

4.1.2 Attack

An "attack" encompasses anything from throwing a punch to firing an anti-tank rocket. The "standard" attack (ranged or hand-to-hand) is a skill test to see if your Protagonist hits a target; damage is inflicted based on the weapon used.

- Use **Firearms** for a gun;
- Use **Firearms** for other aimed weapons (e.g., bow or crossbow);
- Use **Athletics** for a thrown weapon;
- Use **Melee Weapons** for a hand-to-hand weapon;
- Use **Unarmed Combat** for a punch or kick.

The number of shots fired in a single firearm attack depends on the weapon used — a bolt-action rifle fires one shot while a semi-automatic pistol might fire two or three shots — but it's always a single attack roll and a single damage roll.

Attacking with unarmed combat or a melee weapon (but not with weapon which acts at a distance) also means your Protagonist is parrying and blocking. See **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details.

One Action Per Turn

A Protagonist can take only one action per turn. In some settings, there might exist advanced weapons which may hit multiple targets, or one target multiple times, with a single roll (see **LETHALITY RATING** on page 38), but it's still just one action per turn. If this seems counterintuitive ("a good brawler can throw three jabs a second!") don't think of every roll as a single action but as a few seconds of fighting or moving.

4.1.3 Called Shot

A called shot is an attack to a particular body part (the head, the hand, the leg).

A called shot allows your Protagonist to roll a grenade past cover to explode on the far side, or to shoot someone in the leg and avoid body armor. If the attack is automatic gunfire that can hit multiple targets, the called shot affects only the first target.

A called shot is more difficult than a standard attack, so it has a penalty:

PARTLY COVERED (–20%): The target is partially covered (half the body).

MOSTLY COVERED (–40%): The target is mostly covered (all but a limb or head).

Making a called shot with unarmed combat or a melee weapon (but not with weapon which acts at a distance) also means your Protagonist is parrying and blocking. See **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details.

4.1.4 Disarm

An attempt to knock an object from the target's grasp using the Unarmed Combat skill. This is possible only if your Protagonist has both hands free and is in hand-to-hand range. If your roll succeeds, the target drops the object.

Attempting to disarm also means your Protagonist is parrying and blocking. See **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details.

4.1.5 Dodge

This is a Dodge skill test to get out of the way of an attack (or a disarm or pin). This opposed test pits your Protagonist's Dodge skill against the attack roll. If your roll overcomes the attack roll, your Protagonist avoids harm. See **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details. If the Game Moderator agrees, a Protagonist can dodge while jogging or running as described in the MOVE action below.

4.1.6 Escape

This is a roll to escape a pin. Roll either STR×5 or Unarmed Combat, whichever is better. This acts as a defense roll against the character pinning your Protagonist (see **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details); it's opposed by the pinning character's attack roll against your Protagonist. If the pinning character is not attacking, the escape is opposed by either Unarmed Combat or STR×5 (whichever is better). If the escape roll succeeds, your Protagonist is no longer pinned — and the escape roll defends against other attacks until your Protagonist's next action. If it fails, your Protagonist remains pinned and cannot defend against attacks.

4.1.7 Fight Back

If someone attacks your Protagonist with a melee weapon or unarmed combat (not a weapon acting at a distance or an explosive), your Protagonist can fight back with Unarmed Combat or Melee Weapons to block and counter-attack. See **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details.

4.1.8 Move

An action that moves your Protagonist a significant distance: 10 yards jogging, 20 yards running, or 30 yards sprinting (or you can move about 3 yards while performing some other action).

Usually moving requires no roll, but if Protagonists are running or sprinting, players may need to make a DEX×5 test to keep their footing. Fail, and your Protagonist falls prone and must spend a turn recovering.

If there's cover at the end of your Protagonist's movement, getting behind it provides protection (see **PROTECTION IN COMBAT** on page 40). This can give your Protagonist armor against ranged weapons and explosives — if the Protagonist is behind cover when the attack happens.

4.1.9 Pin

An attempt to immobilize a target, either on the ground or up against something, using Unarmed Combat. This is possible only if your Protagonist has both hands free and is in hand-to-hand range. If it succeeds, the target is pinned.

All unarmed or melee weapon attacks against a pinned target are at a +20% bonus. A Protagonist pinning a target can attack the pinned target in later turns.

A pinned target can attempt escape once per turn (see the **ESCAPE** action, above) but nothing else.

Attempting to pin a target also means your Protagonist is parrying and blocking. See **DEFENSE ROLLS** on page 34 for details.

4.1.10 Wait

Protagonists can choose to wait to take any action after their DEX order comes up. At any time before your next turn, you can insert your Protagonist's action before the next action in DEX order. Your Protagonist can't wait until another character acts and then jump in before it's resolved, but your Protagonist can jump in before the other character's turn comes up.

4.1.11 Anything Else

Drink a vial full of a glowing liquid, throw open an unlocked door, activate a mechanism, grab a rope, pick something up, stand up from a prone position — anything that takes a moment's concentration. The Game Moderator decides whether it requires a stat or skill test.

4.2 Attack Rolls

An attack is a skill roll which inflicts damage, disarms or pins the target, depending on the attacker's action.

4.2.1 Critical Hits and Fumbles

An attack roll that's a critical success (see page 29) is a **critical hit**. A critical hit inflicts double damage.

An attack roll that fumbles (see page 29) is bad news. The exact outcome remains up to the Game Moderator and can include:

1. A weapon malfunctions in some way, requiring 1D4 turns to fix
2. A weapon drops and it takes a turn to pick it back up.
3. The attacker accidentally hits a friend, a bystander, or themself.
4. The attacker stumbles and falls.

4.2.2 Attack Modifiers

When you make an attack roll, it means the situation is out of control. Combat is chaotic and unpredictable even for the most highly trained fighters. The combatants' skill ratings and the luck of the dice usually tell everything you need to know.

Bonuses and penalties in combat apply only in extraordinary circumstances. The **COMBAT MODIFIERS** table, nearby, lists the likeliest modifiers. If they do apply, Attack bonuses stack up to a maximum +40%. There's no limit on penalties.

No matter the bonus or penalty, **a roll of 01 always hits** and **a roll of 00 (100) always misses**.

4.2.3 Surprise Attacks

If your Protagonist is out to kill someone who's unaware or helpless (and nobody is trying to stop you), that's hardly combat. You may not even need to make a roll.

TARGET IS TOTALLY HELPLESS — BOUND OR ASLEEP: No roll is needed to murder the target in one turn.

TARGET IS ACTIVE BUT UNAWARE AND COMBAT HAS NOT YET BEGUN: Make an attack roll at +20%. Any success is a critical hit. If it fails, the attack misses. Maybe your Protagonist flinched at the last instant or maybe the target moved. Work out the details with the Game Moderator.

Optional Rules: Other Firearm Called Shots

If the Game Moderator agrees, you can make a called shot for some effect other than ignoring armor. Here are some possibilities.

DOUBLE SHOT (–20%): Make two attack rolls. Both must be on the same target. If two potential targets are close enough that you could hit either one, randomly determine which one takes each hit. Not an option with bows, muzzle-loaders, bolt-action or one-shot weapons.

STUN (–20%): A hit stuns the target (see STUN, page 36).

FLESH WOUND (–40%): A hit inflicts half damage (round up).

HEAD SHOT (–40%): A hit is critical without matching dice.

Optional Rules: Other Critical Hits

If the Game Moderator agrees, a critical hit can inflict normal damage (not double) and have some additional effect: STUN or DISARM the target; knock the target PRONE; make the hit a CALLED SHOT; or allow the attacker to immediately roll a SECOND ATTACK.

4.2.4 Firing Into A Crowd

Use a **CALLED SHOT** to hit a particular target in a crowd with a ranged attack. Otherwise a random member of the crowd takes the hit.

4.3 Defense Rolls

Dodging and hand-to-hand combat (with unarmed or with melee weapons) are tests that protect your Protagonist by opposing an attack roll.

4.3.1 Dodging and Fighting Back

Your Protagonist can Dodge or fight back against an incoming attack even before your Protagonist's DEX order in a turn. If you do this, it becomes your Protagonist's single action for that turn. A Protagonist who has already taken another action that turn can't Dodge or fight back until the next turn.

A roll to Dodge opposes all hand-to-hand attacks that turn. It lets your Protagonist duck behind cover to evade all ranged attacks that turn if cover is near. Dodging never inflicts damage.

Combat Modifiers

Circumstance	+20% Bonus	-20% Penalty	-40% Penalty
Very Long or Very Short Range	Firing at point-blank range (3 yards or less)	Beyond base range (up to 2×)	Beyond 2× base range (up to 5×)
Unusual Target Concealment or Visibility	Using a sight to line up a ranged attack	Terrible visibility due to smoke or darkness	Little to no visibility
Called Shot or Area Attack	Explosive weapon	Target about half covered or smaller than a human body	Target mostly covered or very small
Unusual Target Condition —Ranged Attack	Target standing totally still	Target prone or running	Target moving very fast
Unusual Target Condition —Melee Attack	Target pinned down or standing totally still	Target moving quickly (e.g., running)	Target moving very fast
Unusual Attacker Condition	Carefully aiming for a full turn	Suffering from an irritant; exhausted	Suffering from corrosive gas; stunned

Fighting back blocks all hand-to-hand attacks that turn. If you win the contest, you take no damage. It does not protect you against ranged attacks unless you're close enough to push the ranged weapon away. As part of your fighting back roll, choose one offensive action — **ATTACK**, **CALLED SHOT**, **DISARM**, or **PIN** — against a single attacker. If your roll beats that attacker's roll, your Protagonist takes no damage and your Protagonist's action affects the attacker.

In order to Dodge or fight back, your Protagonist must know an attack is coming and be physically able to block or evade it. If your Protagonist is pinned, if the attack occurs before they realize it, or if your Protagonist can't see or hear the attacker, your Protagonist can't Dodge or fight back.

4.3.2 Dodging Ranged Attacks

An ordinary Dodge roll can avoid a slow-moving ranged attack, such as an arrow or a thrown weapon.

Nobody can react as fast as bullets and shrapnel, but your Protagonist can use Dodge to scramble for cover. If your Protagonist is near enough to move to cover and knows gunfire or an explosion is imminent, make a Dodge roll for the Protagonist to get behind the cover. If there's no cover, Dodging does no good. This is why people get nervous when guns come out.

4.3.3 Defending After Attacking

When your turn comes up, declare your Protagonist's action — **ATTACK**, **CALLED SHOT**, **DISARM**, OR **PIN** — and make the roll. Your Protagonist can harm, disarm or pin only one target per turn (the attack might hurt others, but all attacks have a single target).

A roll to attack, disarm, pin, or make a called shot also opposes each Unarmed Combat and Melee Weapons attack against your Protagonist until your Protagonist's next action. If an attack fails to overcome your roll, it does no harm.

To oppose an attack, your Protagonist must know the attack is coming. That requires seeing or hearing the attacker. The Protagonist must also be physically able to block the attack, if it is melee. A pinned Protagonist can't defend, nor can a Protagonist who has already successfully pinned a target.

An attack roll with a ranged weapon does not oppose attack rolls against your Protagonist.

4.4 Damage

Combat is about inflicting damage. Each weapon or attack has a damage rating measured in dice. When an attack hits, roll the weapon's damage dice and subtract the result from the target's Hit Points.

DAMAGE BONUS: High or low Strength modifies the damage of unarmed and hand-to-hand attacks, to a minimum of 0:

Damage Bonus from STR Score				
1–4	5–8	9–12	13–16	17–18
-2	-1	0	+1	+2

STUN: Stun attacks startle and impair. While stunned, your Protagonist can't act. When it's their turn, you may attempt a **CON×5** test to recover and act normally **next** turn. If a single attack inflicts **half or more** of your Protagonist's current HP, the Protagonist is automatically stunned.

UNCONSCIOUSNESS: If your Protagonist is reduced to 2 or fewer HP, they fall unconscious. An unconscious Protagonist is helpless and can be killed with a single attack without having to roll. At 3 HP or more (or after an hour passes), the Protagonist regains consciousness.

PERMANENT INJURY: Any time your Protagonist is reduced to 2 or fewer HP, make a **CON×5** test. Failure indicates permanent injury. The Game Moderator selects a stat to be permanently reduced by the number on the lowest ten-sided die of the failed CON×5 roll. Stats can only be reduced in this way to a minimum score of 3. If STR or CON drop, adjust HP accordingly.

DEATH: If an attack brings your Protagonist to 0 HP, they are dead. HP do not go below 0.

4.4.1 Healing

There are four types of healing: Resuscitation, Stabilization, Treatment, and Recuperation.

RESUSCITATION: Sometimes it's possible to resuscitate a dead character. If the GM says resuscitation is possible, someone must make a **First Aid** test. This must occur within a number of minutes after death equal to the victim's CON score. If it succeeds, it restores 1D4 HP (doubled for a critical success) and allows the patient to recover. If First Aid fails, the victim dies and may not be resuscitated.

STABILIZATION: Stabilizing a wounded character with a successful **First Aid** test immediately heals 1D4 HP. A critical success doubles the amount healed; a fumble inflicts 1D4 damage. Once your Protagonist receives first aid, success or failure, the Protagonist can't benefit from it again until they suffer damage again.

TREATMENT: Treatment is professional care in a clean, calm location with extensive tools and healing supplies.

A doctor can attempt a **Surgery** or **Medicine** test once per week: Surgery for critical care of severe wounds; Medicine for poison, disease, and ongoing healing. If treatment succeeds, the patient recovers 1D4 HP. This is doubled with a critical, while a fumble inflicts 1D4 HP damage. At the Game Moderator's discretion, having worn-out tools or poor quality medicines may incur a penalty.

Optional Rules: Other Permanent Injuries

At the Game Moderator's discretion, a permanent injury may have some effect other than stat loss: a permanent penalty that can't be corrected with surgery. Usually it's a –20% penalty that applies in certain circumstances. Here are some possibilities.

PARTIALLY BLINDED: The Protagonist suffers a –20% penalty to all tests requiring good eyesight.

PARTIALLY DEAFENED: The Protagonist suffers a –20% penalty to all tests requiring good hearing.

ARM CRIPPLED OR SEVERED: The Protagonist suffers a –20% penalty to all tests requiring two hands.

LEG CRIPPLED OR SEVERED: The Protagonist suffers a –20% penalty to all tests requiring movement.

RECUPERATION: Over time, the human body repairs itself. A patient who rests in a safe place with proper food and water can attempt a **CON×5** test once per day to recover 1 HP (in addition to any HP recovered due to medical treatment). On a critical success, the patient regains 1D4; on a fumble, the patient loses 1 HP.

4.4.2 Complications

After treatment, and until the patient heals all lost Hit Points, undertaking strenuous activity (any physical stat or skill test) inflicts 1D4 HP damage as sutures rip, broken bones shift, or fever sets in.

4.4.3 Recovering Stat Points

Unless the Game Moderator says otherwise, temporarily lost stat points are restored at 1 point per day.

4.5 Table of Example Weapons

The tables below summarize some representative weapons and vehicles that characters might have access to.

The *Cthulhu Eternal* Modern Era SRD does not include a specific skill for Ranged Weapons, as they are relatively rare — characters who are firing crossbows etc should use the **Firearms** skill to aim such weapons, while thrown weapons use **Athletics** as a combat skill.

Modern Era Weapons

Unarmed and Hand-to-Hand Weapons

Weapon	Skill	Damage
Bare hands and feet	Unarmed Combat	1D4–1 *
Brass knuckles or steel-toe boot	Unarmed Combat	1D4 *
Taser	Melee Weapons	STUN
Ordinary knife, switchblade, hatchet	Melee Weapons	1D4 *
Combat knife, garotte or nightstick	Melee Weapons	1D6 *
Tomahawk, machete, or baseball bat	Melee Weapons	1D8 *
Large Sword , chainsaw	Melee Weapons	2D6 *

* Damage bonus is added for this weapon

Ranged Weapons

Weapon	Skill	Damage	Base Range
Bow and arrow	Firearms	1D8	150 yds
Crossbow	Firearms	1D10	200 yds
Thrown Rock	Athletics	1D4 *	20 yds
Thrown Knife	Athletics	1D4 *	STR×5 feet
Thrown Spear,	Athletics	1D8*	STR×5 yards
Thrown Hand Grenade	Athletics	Lethality 15%, 10yds	STR×3 yards
Grenade launcher	Military Training	Lethality 15%, 10yds	150 yds
Rocket-propelled grenade	Military Training	Lethality 20%, 10yds	200 yds

* Damage bonus is added for this weapon

Explosives

Weapon	Placement	Damage	Kill Zone
Dynamite Stick	Military Training	Lethality 15%	1 yds
Improvised explosive device	Military Training	Lethality 15%	10 yds

Firearms

Weapon	Damage	Armor Pierce	Base Range
Light Caliber Pistol (.22 revolver / automatic)	1D8	no	10 yds
Medium Caliber Pistol (.32 or 9mm)	1D10	no	15 yds
Carbine or very large pistol	1D12	no	100 yds for carbine; 20 yds for heavy pistol
Rifle	1D12+2	3	150 yds
Shotgun (12 gauge) [see notes on page 42 for other gauges & firing both barrels]	2D10 (close range)	no	50 yds (full damage up to 10yds; reduced to 1D10 for 10–20yds; reduced to 1D6 for 20+ yards)
Submachine gun, Assault rifle, or carbine (short burst, 3 bullet)	Lethality 10%, no kill radius	3 for AR/ carbine	50 yds for submachine gun, 100 yds for Assault Rifle or Carbine
Submachine gun, Assault rifle, or carbine (long burst, 5 bullet)	Lethality 10%, 1 yd kill radius	3 for AR/ carbine	50 yds for submachine gun, 100 yds for Assault Rifle or Carbine
Submachine gun, Assault rifle, or carbine (short spray, 10 bullet)	Lethality 10%, 2 yd kill radius	3 for AR/ carbine	50 yds for submachine gun, 100 yds for Assault Rifle or Carbine
Submachine gun, Assault rifle, or carbine (long spray, 20 bullet)	Lethality 10%, 3 yd kill radius	3 for AR/ carbine	50 yds for submachine gun, 100 yds for Assault Rifle or Carbine
Very heavy sniper rifle	Lethality 20%, no kill radius	5	250 yds
Light machine gun	Lethality 10%, 3 yd kill radius	5	200 yds
Heavy machine gun	Lethality 20%, 3 yd kill radius	5	400 yds

4.6 Lethality Rating

Certain attacks inflict damage well beyond the possibility of survival; a burst of heavy machine gun fire or an artillery shell makes fast work of human anatomy. Rather than rolling many dice for damage or many separate attacks, a weapon like this has a Lethality rating.

If an attack hits with a weapon that has a Lethality rating, there's a chance it simply kills the target outright. Instead of rolling normal damage, roll percentile dice against the weapon's Lethality rating. If the Lethality test succeeds, a human target immediately drops to 0 HP. If the Lethality test fails, add the two dice together as if they were individual D10s (0 is 10) and apply that as HP damage.

Lethality rolls do not fumble or critically succeed, but the attack roll can. If the attack roll is a critical success, double the Lethality rating, and double the HP damage if the Lethality roll fails.

4.6.1 Kill Radius

Some types of especially destructive effects destroy not just one target but spread across an entire (usually circular) zone — the size of the effect is measured by Kill Radius.

If a weapon has a Kill Radius, a successful attack inflicts a Lethality roll on each character inside that radius. The center of the Kill Radius is the initial target of the attack.

With explosive weapons, Kill Radius attacks don't need to be as precise as ordinary attacks; hitting a zone within the Kill Radius of a target is enough. That adds +20% to the chance to hit.

A failed attack roll means the Kill Radius lands harmlessly outside the intended area. The attack does no harm — but may still induce terror in targets (see **FEAR IN COMBAT**, below). Whether a failed Kill Radius attack does unwanted collateral damage is up to the Game Moderator.

MANY TARGETS: A single attack with a Kill Radius usually affects everyone in the Kill Radius. If that doesn't make sense for the situation, the Game Moderator can decide who gets hit.

The Game Moderator is welcome to let players roll the Lethality results for NPCs to speed things up. But really, you need to roll Lethality only for characters who are important enough to track in detail. Since even a failed Lethality roll inflicts between 2 and 20 damage, it's safe to just assume that most humans caught in a Kill Radius are either dead or incapacitated.

4.6.2 Selective Fire

Some small arms, like submachine guns and assault rifles, have selective fire. The shooter chooses how it's used; each pull of the trigger can fire a single shot, a short burst, a long burst, a short spray, or a long spray. A weapon set for single shots attacks normally. A burst or a spray has a Lethality rating.

Why Lethality Ratings?

The Lethality rating replaces the need to roll lots of separate attacks and lots of dice for damage. Without it, a massively damaging attack might require several separate attacks and damage rolls to afflict many different targets. In the middle of combat, rolling that much breaks the tension.

If you'd rather roll damage the old way, it's 1D6 damage for every 3% of Lethality. So a weapon with 35% would do 12D6 HP damage.

A short burst fires three bullets in one trigger pull. It affects a single target. A long burst fires five shots with a Kill Radius of 1 yard. Short and long sprays empty the magazine faster, but cover a larger Kill Radius. Some firearms allow only single shots or short bursts ("three-round bursts").

4.7 Explosions

If your Protagonist wants to disable or destroy a structure or vehicle, an explosive or other form of Lethal attack might be their best bet. Such large objects have their own Hit Points (see **VEHICLES**, page 49), and they are considered huge targets (see **HUGE**, page 41).

For example, if your Protagonist wanted to gain entry into a home safe, they might try lobbing a hand grenade at it. The GM might rule that the safe has 20HP and an Armor rating of 10. Assuming the grenade lands such that the safe is within its kill radius (10 yards from where it lands), the safe will take damage. Because the object is treated like a **HUGE** *target, the normal Lethality 15% damage is translated into an automatic 15 HP damage reduced by Armor down to 5 HP. So, while the explosion makes a lot of noise, the safe is only a quarter broken into. Time to get some more grenades.*

4.8 Fear in Combat

Being involved in combat is inherently frightening for most people. However, certain types of attacks which devastate an entire area are especially terror-inducing. When faced with such destruction — whether from a mundane weapon (e.g., full automatic fire from an assault rifle) or something supernatural — primal instinct kicks in to prevent a person from placing themselves in mortal peril.

The GM can nominate that any massively damaging attack is Terror-Inducing. Any character who knowingly seeks to enter a region targeted by such an attack will hesitate and go to ground — even if the attack does not succeed. The only way to stifle this primal terror is by voluntarily sacrificing 1 SAN.



The types of attacks which might be ruled Terror-Inducing include:

- Attacks (mundane or supernatural) that inflict Lethal Damage to a Kill Zone,
- Attacks which have previously been witnessed to inflict Unnatural effects worthy of a SAN test,
- Anything else the GM believes would strike extreme fear into combatants.

Note that these effects do not apply to a combatant who is not aware that they are straying into an area targeted by the Terror-Inducing attack — when in doubt, call for an **Alertness** test.

A character adapted to violence (see **ADAPTING TO SAN LOSS** on page 57) loses no SAN for braving a Terror-Inducing attack. For NPCs, it's easiest to assume the average human goes to ground when faced with such attacks. Only insane, hardened, or fanatical enemies stand up to such intense fear.

4.9 Protection in Combat

We've seen how to injure, kill, and dismember targets, but how do you protect them?

There are five stages of protection, categories that determine how easy a Protagonist or other creature is to harm, regardless of their ability to get out of the way.

4.9.1 Fragile

Fragile targets drop to 0 HP instantly if they suffer any damage from a deliberate attempt to injure them. A helpless human is Fragile and may, at the Game Moderator's discretion, be reduced to 0 HP with one attack without bothering to roll damage.

4.9.2 Exposed

Exposed is the default for humans and many creatures. It means the target is aware of danger and trying to avoid it, but doesn't have any real protection. Attacks operate normally against Exposed targets.

4.9.3 Armored

Being Armored reduces the damage of attacks.

Armor has an Armor rating which reduces the HP damage of attacks. Armor 5 means reduce damage by 5.

Armor comes in two forms: body armor and cover. They both reduce the damage of ordinary attacks, but have different effects on Lethality attacks. If you have more than one source of armor (such as wearing body armor while behind a wall), add them all together.

Some weapons are armor piercing, which in turn reduces armor (see **ARMOR PIERCING WEAPONS**, opposite). Furthermore, damage arising from wholly supernatural effects (e.g., mystical energy or psychic attacks by Mythos entities, or damage generated through rituals) completely ignores all armor. In cases where it isn't clear whether traditional armor should protect against damage dealt through otherworldly means, it is the GM's call.

BODY ARMOR: Body armor reduces the damage of an ordinary attack by its Armor Rating. Body armor protects against the damage of a failed Lethality roll, but does nothing whatsoever against a successful Lethality roll.

COVER: Finding cover means using a hard barrier as armor against attack. Cover protects more completely than body armor. If you have cover against a Lethality attack, the Lethality roll automatically fails, but still inflicts the sum of the dice as damage. Subtract the cover's Armor rating from that damage.

What if your Protagonists are completely enclosed in a structure or conveyance? That's definitely cover, but it's the Game Moderator's call. Maybe they take damage reduced by the cover, or maybe they take no damage until the cover is breached.

Being behind cover does not make Protagonists immune to the terror of combat (see **FEAR IN COMBAT** on page 38). If your Protagonist is terrorized, their next action must be to hide behind that cover instead of attacking.

Optional Rule: Creating Terror Through Concentrated Fire

Normally, mundane ranged weapons won't be damaging enough to inspire terror. What if several combatants team up to concentrate simultaneous shots — none of which themselves are Terror-Inducing — on a single point? In such a case the GM might decide that the combined effect is sufficient to create 1 yard-radius circular zone centered on the point of concentrated fire. All combatants firing at the spot make an attack roll — if the majority succeed, no damage is inflicted but the designated zone is treated as Terror-Inducing. If one or more of the attackers scored a critical on their roll, a random target in the zone is hit for normal damage and everyone else in the zone is affected by the Terror effect. If fewer than half of the attackers succeeded on their rolls, no damage is inflicted and no terror is generated.

As a rule of thumb, for a concentration of smaller attacks to be ruled as creating a Terror-Inducing effect the sum of their individual maximum damages should be at least 30HP (i.e., three attacks each delivering 1D10 or five attacks each delivering 1D6). Any coordination of two or more attacks with Lethal effects would also qualify.

Armor	Armor Rating
Kevlar helmet (adds damage reduction to other armor)	+1
Kevlar vest (concealable)	3
Reinforced Kevlar vest (typical for uniformed police)	4
Tactical body armor (typical for soldiers and SWAT teams), wall or thick door, makeshift vehicle cover	5
Bomb suit; thick wall, concrete, or moderate rock; light vehicle armor	10
Reinforced wall, big rock, or sandbag; medium vehicle armor	15
Heavy vehicle armor or light tank armor	20
Heavy tank armor	25

4.9.4 Huge

A huge target loses Hit Points from ordinary weapon damage as usual. But Lethality ratings don't affect huge creatures in the same way they do a human sized target. Instead, the Lethality attack does flat HP damage equal to the Lethality rating.

4.9.5 Transcendent

Transcendent entities are immune to physical damage. This might mean they exist partly in dimensions we barely perceive, or are so organized that mere excesses of force and matter cannot harm them.

Nothing of this Earth is Transcendent. Only through the use of unnatural techniques, under extremely dangerous and limited situations, can humans become Transcendent.

4.9.6 Armor Piercing Weapons

An armor piercing weapon reduces the Armor value of a target by a number of points. If the weapon description notes it as armor-piercing it will normally also specify the reduction — if no number is given, assume the attack reduces effective armor by 5.

4.10 Optional Spot Rules for Weapons

There's a staggering variety of personal firearms and weaponry. Their usefulness in adventures may be limited, of course, depending on who or what the Protagonists face.

The primary game statistics relating to different types of weapons may be found on the **Example Weapons Table** on page 37. The availability of any class of weapon will be dictated by the scarcity of weapon resources in the particular game setting (see preceding section).

What follows are some spot rules for Protagonists who have access to common 'modern-day' (20th or 21st Century) weapons.

4.10.1 Concealing Weapons

Knives and pistols can be concealed under ordinary clothing. Someone deliberately looking for a concealed weapon can attempt an **Alertness** test to spot it. A heavy pistol or especially big knife means a +20% Alertness bonus.

If a Protagonist is wearing an overcoat or duster, they can attempt to conceal a bigger gun like a submachine gun or sawed-off shotgun, or a larger hand weapon (e.g., a hatchet or machete) and incur no Alertness bonus.

There's no way to conceal a full-size rifle or a large melee weapon.

Combat Protection Summary

Target Status	Effect of Normal Damage	Effect of Lethality Success	Effect of Lethality Failure
Fragile	Reduced to 0 HP	Reduced to 0 HP	Reduced to 0 HP
Exposed	Roll HP damage. If Armored, subtract the Armor value from the damage.	Reduced to 0 HP	Add up the Lethality dice to determine HP damage. If Armored, subtract the Armor value from the damage
Behind cover	Roll HP damage. Subtract the cover's Armor value from the damage.	Add up the Lethality dice to determine HP damage. Subtract the cover's Armor value from the damage.	Add up the Lethality dice to determine HP damage. Subtract the cover's Armor value from the damage.
Huge	Roll HP damage. If Armored, subtract the Armor value from the damage.	Take the Lethality rating as HP damage. If Armored, subtract the Armor value from the damage.	Take the Lethality rating as HP damage. If Armored, subtract the Armor value from the damage.
Transcendent	No damage	No damage	No damage

4.10.2 Hand-to-Hand Weapons

Unarmed attacks, like punching, kicking, and strangling, use the Unarmed Combat skill. All melee weapons use the Melee Weapons skill.

4.10.3 Primitive Ranged Weapons

Old-fashioned ranged weapons that are aimed (e.g., crossbows, bow, and slings) use the **Firearms** skill even though they aren't firearms. All such weapons require some kind of ammunition (arrows, bolts, bow) and are useless if the supply is exhausted. Primitive weapons that are thrown (e.g., spears) use **Athletics** skill.

4.10.4 Firearms

Depending on when and where the game is set, the Protagonists may have easy access to a range of different firearms. Firearms can be heavily accessorized. Popular gun add-ons include tactical lights, sound suppressors, holographic sights, telescopic sights, night sights, and targeting lasers. Many rifles can also be fitted with an under-barrel shotgun or grenade launcher.

Pistols

Lightweight pistols fire low-powered cartridges and are of limited use even against humans. Medium pistols are the standard sidearms in law enforcement and the military everywhere. They fire moderately powerful rounds. Most revolvers hold six shots, but some late models hold seven or eight. Pocket revolvers sometimes take only five. There's a huge variety of ammunition capacities for semiautomatic pistol magazines, but 15 is typical, although 17 or even 20 is not uncommon. Large-caliber pistols often carry less. A typical figure for a heavy pistol is eight.

Shotguns

A typical pump-action shotgun holds five shots, although there are many with extended magazines for eight or more. Double-barrel shotguns hold one shot per barrel and can fire both barrels at one target with one attack roll. Shotguns can fire shot (a spread of small projectiles), slugs (a single heavy bullet), or "non-lethal" ammunition such as bean bag rounds, baton rounds, or rubber shot.

FIRING SHOT: Grants a +20% bonus to hit at all ranges: at point-blank due to the target being so close (see **ATTACK MODIFIERS** on page 34) and beyond that due to the spread of projectiles. If the target has an Armor rating due to armor or cover, double it.

FIRING BOTH BARRELS: You can fire both barrels of a double-barrel shotgun at one target with one attack roll. That inflicts an extra +1D8 damage at base range. It adds no damage beyond base range as the shot or the slugs separate.

Unusual Ammunition

Most small-arms ammunition uses the standard, listed damage ratings. Special types are available.

ARMOR-PIERCING: Pistols, rifles, and submachine guns can fire bullets designed to pierce body armor. An armor piercing bullet reduces Armor by 5 (see **ARMOR PIERCING WEAPONS** on page 41; this replaces the weapon's usual Armor Piercing rating, if any), but it does –1 damage (to a minimum of 1 point).

HOLLOW POINT: Pistols, rifles, and submachine guns can fire expanding bullets designed to cause greater tissue trauma at the expense of penetration. A hollow point round does +1 damage but armor is twice as effective against it.

OTHER GAUGES: These rules assume a standard 12-gauge shotgun. Modify the damage by +2 for a heavier gauge or −2 for a lighter gauge.

Submachine Guns

Submachine guns fire full-automatic bursts but are often also capable of semi-automatic fire. When firing semi-automatic, the weapon inflicts ordinary damage; with automatic fire, it uses a Lethality rating (see **LETHALITY RATING** on page 38).

Rifles and Carbines

Rifles fire more powerful cartridges than pistols or submachine guns, for better penetration, wounding, and range. However, they are also bulkier. Some military rifles — assault rifles in smaller calibers and automatic rifles in heavier calibers — are capable of firing full-automatic bursts with Lethality ratings. Especially heavy rifles have Lethality ratings with single shots.

Older rifles and many hunting rifles use a bolt action that must be manually worked before each shot, which delays aiming. An attack with one in the turn immediately after it's already been fired is at −20%. A bolt-action rifle gets no benefit from the **Aim** action in the turn immediately after it's fired

4.10.5 Heavy Weapons, Demolitions & Artillery

Many unnatural things that Protagonists face are inscrutable perversions of physics no more vulnerable to explosions than they are to crucifixes. This never stops Protagonists from trying.

The Base Range for each weapon reflects the fact that it needs to be accurate enough only to get a target within the Kill Radius. Machine guns fired off their bipod, tripod, or vehicle mount halve Base Range.

Many of these weapons actually fire in automatic bursts as well, which is subsumed under their Lethality ratings and Kill Radius. The Ammo Capacity of these

weapons also varies widely, often depending on the vehicle on which they are mounted.

Only the lightest of Heavy Weapons will be commonly found, usually in military bases and the like. Most of the heavier ones are vehicle-mounted or specialized gear designed for military support units; these will typically be hard for the Protagonists to get their hands on, and even harder for them to transport to where they need firepower.

4.10.6 Weapons with Special Effects

Some types of weapons do something other than (or as well as) inflicting damage to Hit Points.

Tear Gas and Pepper Spray

These irritant chemicals make eyes tear, lungs seize, and exposed tissues sting like hell. If hit, the target must make a **CON×5** test or be stunned and suffer a penalty (usually –20%) to all actions for one hour. If the CON×5 roll succeeds, the target is not stunned and suffers half the usual penalty. As described on page 36, **STUNNED** individuals can't take further combat actions until they succeed at a **CON×5** test, which may be attempted once per turn.

A tear gas grenade only needs to land near a target to have effect, so the attack roll has a bonus of +20%. A tear gas grenade's cloud lingers in the air only a minute or two. Pepper spray is best used before combat begins, when no attack rolls are needed. If a pepper spray attack roll fails, the attacker partially sprays themself. The attacker must make a **CON×5** test at +20% to avoid being stunned and suffers a −20% penalty for one hour.

Wearing a gas mask protects against these effects but incurs a −20% penalty to Alertness and Search tests.

Stun Grenades

A "flash-bang" is a grenade that makes a huge noise and bright flash which deafens, blinds and staggers everyone within a 10-yard radius (indoors) or 5 yards (outdoors).

Each target is stunned (unable to act until a **CON×5** test succeeds; check each turn). After the stun wears off, the target suffers a –40% penalty to all actions for 1D6 turns. (Having eye or ear protection reduces the penalty to −20%.)

A stun grenade only needs to land near a target to have effect, so the attack roll has a bonus of +20%. If someone is tossing it into a closed room with the benefit of surprise, it doesn't even require a roll.

Bright Lights

A bright flashlight in darkness can dazzle someone up to 10 yards away by shining it in the target's eyes. This is an action in combat. It requires a **DEX×5** test, which is **automatically opposed by the target's DEX×5** test. A dazzled target is at a −20% penalty to all rolls for 1D6 turns.



Electroshock Weapons

A conducted energy device or stun gun discharges a high-voltage electrical shock into the target, causing the target's muscles to spasm violently. The victim must roll a **CON×5** test to resist being stunned. If stunned,they are unable to act until a **CON×5** test succeeds (attempted each turn). After the stun wears off, the victim suffers a −20% penalty to all actions for 1D20 turns.

Human bodies are excellent conductors of electricity. Anyone holding the target of an electroshock attack suffers the same effects.

4.11 Other Threats

The world is full of threats, combat isn't the only thing that can kill a Protagonist.

4.11.1 Poison and Disease

Every poison or disease has two ratings: Speed and Damage.

Speed indicates how soon the poison or disease inflicts damage. A poison inflicts damage once and then passes from your Protagonist's system. A disease requires a series of CON tests to resist damage.

Damage is ordinary HP for a disease, while poisons have Lethality ratings.

POISONS: A poison has a Lethality rating. If the Lethality roll fails, the victim makes a **CON×5** test to withstand harm. Success means half damage, and a critical success means the victim loses only 1 HP. A fumble doubles the damage. 'Hospitalization' (makeshift or otherwise) grants +20% to the victim's CON test.

DISEASES: Diseases inflict HP damage. If your Protagonist succeeds at a **CON×5** test, they suffer half damage and recovers from the disease. On a failure, they suffer full damage and must make the CON×5 test again after another Speed interval. A fumbled CON test doubles the damage. While under the effects of a disease, the Protagonist cannot gain Hit Points back. 'Hospitalization' grants a +20% bonus to the CON test. Serious diseases may come with a penalty to the CON test.

Poisons

Poison	Entry Route	Speed	Lethality	Symptoms	Antidote?
Arsenic	Ingestion	1D6 hours	10%	Pain, diarrhea, cramping	No
dangerous drug administered with failed skill use	Varies	1D6 hours	5%	Usually pain, diarrhea, convulsions, or asphyxiation	Yes
Phosgene gas	Inhalation	2D6 hours	15%	Blistering, coughing blood, asphyxiation	No
Hydrogen cyanide gas	Inhalation	1D6 turns	20%	Asphyxiation	Yes
Ricin	Injection or powder inhalation	2D6 hours	20%	Diarrhea, shock, seizures, circulatory failure	No
Sarin gas	Inhalation or absorption through skin	2D6 turns	20%	Muscle contrac-tions, spasms, asphyxiation	Yes
Scorpion or snake venom	Bite or sting	1D6 hours	10%	Pain, weakness, hemorrhaging, convulsions	Yes
Spider venom	Bite	1D6 hours	5%	Pain, chills, nausea; possibly necrosis	Yes
Strychnine	Inhalation, Ingestion, Contact	10+1D10 minutes	10%	Convulsions, paralysis, asphyxiation	No

Diseases in the Modern Era

Poison	Route	Speed	CON Test Penalty	Damage	Symptoms	Cure
Bacterial meningitis	Airborne	1D6 days	–40	1D4	Stiff neck, nausea, confusion	Antibiotics
Bacterial pneumonia	Inhalation	1D6 days	None	1D6	Cough, fever, chills	Antibiotics
COVID-19	Inhalation of Airborne aerosols	1D6 days	–20	1D6	Cough, fever, loss of smell; long term immune dysregulation	Some antivirals to treat short-term effects
Gangrene	Dirty wounds	1D6 days	–20	1D4	Discoloration, oozing, numbness	Antibiotics, excision, or amputation
Plague	Flea bite (bubonic plague), inhalation (pneumonic plague)	1D6 days	None	1D6	Fever, chills, lymph node swelling, coughing (if pneumonic), shock	Antibiotics
HIV/AIDS	Injection or unprotected sex	1D6 months	None	1D6	Weight loss, fever, swelling of lymph glands, total collapse of immune system	No cure; persis-tent; antivirals can stabilize
Ebola virus	Contact with infected blood, bodies, or meat	1D6 days	–40	1D6	Fever, diarrhea, nausea, bleed-ing, shock	None



Some diseases are persistent. That means that even succeeding at the CON test only buys time; the disease subsides and your Protagonist recovers lost HP. But every time the Protagonist is badly hurt (losing more than half their HP) or suffers from some other poison or disease, the Protagonist must make a **CON×5** test to resist a resurgence.

ANTIDOTES: Many poisons and diseases can be cured with medication. If a physician has the antidote for a poison or the right antibiotics for a disease, a **Medicine** or **Pharmacy** test before the ailment takes effect renders the poison or disease harmless. An antidote given after the ailment takes effect halves the Lethality rating and the HP damage.

4.11.2 Falling

Falling is extremely dangerous to humans. Even a bad slip can be lethal. A fall from a short distance (one to three yards) does 1D6 damage, or 2D6 if it's a particularly uncontrolled fall. Beyond that, a fall instead has a Lethality rating of 1% per yard fallen.

A Protagonist who survives a fall must make a **CON×5** test or be **STUNNED** (see page 36).

4.11.3 Suffocation

Suffocation is a slow death. If your Protagonist takes a deep breath before holding it, they can go without breathing for CON×5 turns. After that, your Protagonist's oxygen-starved brain begins to die. Once every turn, make a **CON×5** test. If it fails, your Protagonist suffers 1D6 HP damage. If the CON test succeeds, your Protagonist suffers 1 HP damage instead. This continues until your Protagonist can breathe again or they die.

If your Protagonist *doesn't* get a breath before suffocating, the damage starts immediately and lasts until someone clears their airway with a **First Aid** test. Armor does not protect against suffocation damage.

4.11.4 Fire

Fire damage suffered depends on the flame's intensity. The victim suffers a damage roll every turn of exposure.

Intensity	Example	Damage
Minor	Candle	1 HP/turn
Moderate	Flaming brand; momentary exposure to a larger fire	1D6/turn
Large	Campfire	2D6/turn
Major	Scalding steam; bonfire; furnace	Lethality 10% each turn

After taking damage from any moderate, large or major source of fire, the victim must make a **DEX×5** test or catch fire, suffering half damage each turn until extinguished. Being surrounded by a raging fire also causes suffocation as the fire consumes oxygen. (See **SUFFOCATION** above.)

4.11.5 Cold

Protagonists can last for CON in minutes exposed to freezing temperatures unprepared, or CON×5 minutes if partially prepared. Fully prepared and well-equipped Protagonists can last CON hours.

After this, their bodies start to fail. Players must make a **CON×5** test every five minutes. Each failure reduces CON by 1. When a Protagonist's CON hits 1, the Protagonist can no longer move and suffers 1D8 HP cold damage every five minutes.

Exposure to warmth and shelter restores 1 point of CON per minute. Hit Points heal normally.

4.11.6 Starvation and Thirst

Protagonists deprived of food for longer than a week will begin to die of starvation. Each week, make a test against **CON×2** or a relevant **Survival** skill (whichever is higher), failure leading to a loss of CON. For the first week without nourishment the loss is 1D2, the next week 1D4, then 2D4, 3D4 and so on.

Surviving without water is much more difficult. For the first 24 hours without hydration there are no effects, but for each day thereafter the Protagonist must make a test against **CON×2** or a relevant **Survival** skill (whichever is higher). Failure means a loss of 1D4 STR and 1D4 CON.

If a water supply is re-established these points will return at a rate of 1D2 STR and 1D2 CON each day.

If at any point the Protagonist's STR or CON drops to zero, they have died of starvation or thirst.

4.11.7 Impact

Slamming into a barrier at speed can be deadly. It has a Lethality rating of 10% for every 25 mph (40 km/h) of speed. Double the Lethality rating if your Protagonist slams into a wall and there's nowhere to tumble. A Protagonist who survives an impact must make a CON×5 test or be **STUNNED** (see page 36). For damage from a vehicular crash, see **VEHICLES** on page 49.

4.12 The Aftermath

When the smoke clears and the fighting stops, it's time for the Game Moderator to look to the consequences of combat. There are always consequences.

First, violence damages sanity. Unless your Protagonist is a hardened operator, getting into a deadly fight calls for a Sanity roll. So does getting hurt. So does killing someone. (See **THREATS TO SAN** on page 51.)

Next, was anyone killed or badly hurt? If so … who's going to come looking for them?

5.0 Equipment

Most equipment that your Protagonist will buy, find or use does not require any special rules — if you have the equipment, and it is in working order then you can use it (possibly with a skill or stat test) to do things. Some items that are poorly made or worn-out may incur a penalty (see the box on page 49).

Obtaining equipment can be as simple as purchasing it in a store (assuming such commerce exists in the game setting); alternatively, it can involve scrounging around trying to piece together usable items from junk.

5.1 Buying Equipment

The table below gives some indicative prices for equipment. It also shows the normal range of available financial wealth that is typical for individuals at different strata of society (as defined by the Permanent Resources rating, see **DETAILED DESCRIPTION: RESOURCES**, page 13).

5.2 Scrounging

Some items that the Protagonists want to obtain might not be easy to obtain — either because they are restricted in some way, especially scarce, or illegal. Alternatively, the items might be available, but priced such that the Protagonist simply can't afford them. In such situations, the only recourse might be to scrounge around to see if the items can be 'liberated' from somewhere. This might involve sifting through discarded items to find pieces that are good enough to function as needed, and perhaps lashing them together to make more complex equipment.



If a Protagonist wants to obtain a resource that isn't available to them via simple means, there are two ways:

1. By rummaging through the stockpile of belongings that constitute their personal 'resources', or
2. Searching the environment to try to locate an abandoned or unclaimed supply of that resource.

Each of these methods uses a different game mechanic.

The former is a use of the Protagonist's Resources rating, while the latter is a use of their **Search** skill.

In both cases, the difficulty of the test to locate a usable item depends on the scarcity of the item being sought, as well as:

- [For rummaging the resource pool] — whether the item is small enough to realistically be carried around from place to place.
- [For scavenging] — whether the location being searched is a likely or unlikely place for such resources to have been stored or abandoned.

The results of a test can indicate that an item has been discovered, or describe utter failure of the search/rummaging. However even if the roll is successful there is no guarantee that the resource discovered will be in good condition — the discovered item might be heavily worn or maybe even utter junk (see box nearby).

5.2.1 Resource Categories and Scarcity

As an abstraction, the scarcity of a resource in the game setting can be rated on the following scale (from least to most scarce):

- **Abundant:** The resource is virtually everywhere; the average person probably has at least some of it at any given time.
- **Uncommon:** The resource isn't something that you'd just stumble upon accidentally but if you put concerted effort into it, you would probably find some.
- **Hard to Get:** The resource is in short supply or is somehow heavily regulated; most people don't have ready access to it at all but if you have special access or know the right people, you can probably get some.
- **Very Hard to Get:** The resource is absent from all the common places and even people with special access find it a significant challenge to track some down. Don't be surprised if you can't get any at all.

Income, Assets and Costs

Resources Rating	Financial Assets, Income and Cash-at-Hand		
0	Penury	$0	no assets
1-4	Poor	$20k/annum	cheap car, rented apartment
5-8	Average	$50k/annum	ok car, mortgaged home
9-12	Above Average	$100k/annum	good car, part-mortgaged home
13-16	Well Off	$150k/annum	multiple cars, paid-off home
17-18	Rich	$200k/annum	multiple luxury cars, several homes
19	Very Rich	$500k/annum	several prestige cars, mansions
20+	Super Rich	$1m/annum+	sky is the limit

Some representative costs:

- Average living expenses for a single person (excluding rent): $1100/month
- Renting a 1-bedroom apartment in a large city: $3000/month
- Renting a 1-bedroom apartment in a small city or town: $1000/month
- Buying a 3-bedroom house in a large city: $500k–$1m
- Buying a 3-bedroom house in a small city or town: $100k-$400k
- Meal at a quality restaurant: $75
- Takeout meal: $13
- Public transport pass: $100/month
- New (non-prestige-brand) car: $20k
- Prestige-brand car: $55k
- Single-engine plane: $50k–$100k
- Private jet: $1m–$90m

- **Impossible to Get:** Stockpiles of this resource simply don't exist; people that are especially resourceful might have been prudent enough to snare some for their personal supply, but that's it.

The scarcity rating of a resource affects a Protagonist's attempt to either scavenge from the environment (using the **Search** skill) or rummage through their personal "resource stash" to find it. The table below summarizes the effects of scarcity.

5.3 The Fine Art of Jury-Rigging

Protagonists may often find themselves faced with an inability to track down the exact equipment or devices that they really need to get something done. No amount of scrounging or rummaging through each person's resources pool will track down the obscure item they need. What can a Protagonist group do in that situation? One option is to devise a plan to hunt down a collection of less-scarce component items and cobble together some kind of hodge-podge out of the parts. This is the fine art of jury-rigging.

In modern-era *Cthulhu Eternal*, all attempts to build these kinds of lash-ups are governed by **Craft skill specializations or Technology Use** (GM's discretion).

The players should describe exactly what they plan to construct and what components they hope to use. Ideally there should be some kind of logic or rationale behind why such items might come together in the way imagined, but ultimately it is up to you as Game Moderator to decide whether the planned jury-rigged device has any chance of working.

Once the plan is made, choose a scarcity for each component parts — hopefully somewhat better than the scarcity of the original item — and the Protagonists can venture forth (or rummage around their resource pools) to see if they can find all the pieces they need. Once they have each part, one or more skill tests will be needed to successfully assemble the final item or device.

At best, a lash-up created in this way qualities as a 'heavily worn' version of the real item or device. If any discovery rolls along the way yielded up sub-standard parts, or the skill rolls were only marginally successful, you might decide the lash-up is barely-functional 'junk' (see **JUNK AND HEAVILY WORN ITEMS** nearby).

Acquiring Resources Table

Scarcity	Consumable Resources		Non-Consumable Resources	
	Effect on Search Tests	***Effect on Resources Tests***	***Effect on Search Tests***	***Effect on Resources Tests***
Abundant	No test required; search is automatically successful.	On successful **Resources** test, a full 'unit' of the resource is found in Protagonist's collection, in perfect condition.	No test required; search is automatically successful.	On successful **Resources** test, a pristine version of the item is found in Protagonist's collection.
Uncommon	May be found with a standard **Search** test.	On successful **Resources** test, some quantity of the resource is found. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 20 or less, the discovery is half a 'unit'. A critical success or a standard success with die roll 21+ discovers a full 'unit'	May be found with a standard **Search** test.	On successful **Resources** test, some form of the item is found. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 20 or less, the item is heavily worn A critical success or a standard success with die roll 21+ discovers a pristine item.
Hard to Get	May be found with a **Search** test modified by –20. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 10 or less, a spoiled and potentially dangerous version is unearthed. A critical success or a standard success with die roll 11+ finds a safe supply.	**Resources** tests made at **half** the effective Resources rating. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 20 or less, a spoiled and potentially dangerous version is unearthed. A standard success with a roll of 21+ yields a safe resource but only half a 'unit'. Only if the test was a critical success, is a full 'unit' of perfectly safe resource discovered.	May be found with a **Search** test modified by –20. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 10 or less, a junk version of the resource is found. A critical success or a standard success with die roll 11+ finds a pristine version of the resource.	**Resources** tests made at **half** the effective Resources rating. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 20 or less, a junk version of the resource is found. A standard success with a die roll 21+ finds a heavily worn version. Only if the test was a critical success, is a pristine version of the resource discovered.
Very Hard to Get	May only be found with successes on ***both*** a **Luck** roll and a **Search** test at –40. If the Search test is a standard success and the die roll is 10 or less, a spoiled and potentially dangerous version is unearthed. A critical success on Search or a standard success with die roll 11+ finds a safe supply.	**Resources** tests made at **quarter** the effective Resources rating. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 20 or less, a spoiled and potentially dangerous version is unearthed. A standard success with a roll of 21+ yields a safe resource but only half a 'unit'. Only if the roll was 01, is a full 'unit' of perfectly safe resource discovered.	May only be found with successes on ***both*** a **Luck** roll and a **Search** test at –40. If the Search test is a standard success and the die roll is 10 or less, a junk version is unearthed instead. A standard success on Search with die roll 11+ finds a heavily worn version. A critical success on Search finds a pristine version.	**Resources** tests made at **quarter** the effective Resources rating. If the test is a standard success and the die roll is 20 or less, a junk version of the resource is found. A standard success with a die roll 21+ finds a heavily worn version. Only if the roll was 01, is a pristine version of the resource discovered.
Impossible to Get	No test required; search automatically fails.	**Resources** tests made at **quarter** the effective Resources rating. Any test that is not a critical success fails to find the item in the Protagonist's collection in any quantity or quality. Critical rolls locate spoiled and potentially dangerous stocks unless the roll was 01, in which case a further **Luck** roll is made: failure indicates a half 'unit' of safe resource; success a full 'unit' of safe resource.	No test required; search automatically fails.	**Resources** tests made at **quarter** the effective Resources rating. Any test that is not a critical success fails to find the item in the Protagonist's collection in any form. Critical rolls locate junk versions unless the roll was 01, in which case a further **Luck** roll is made: failure indicates heavily worn items; success indicates pristine.

Spoiled Consumables

If the Protagonist is searching for a type of consumable resource (e.g., water, food) and gains a less-than-perfect outcome, it is possible that some quantity of the resource has been found but in a spoiled condition that may be potentially dangerous to use/ingest.

The Game Moderator will need to interpret what this means in the context of the resource type, and whether the spoiling is obvious or requires a skill test to detect.

- Ingesting spoiled food or water is treated as an exposure to poison (see **POISON AND DISEASE** on page 43). The default toxicity is (Speed 1D4 hours; Lethality 2%), but the Game Moderator can vary this to fit the situation.
- Administering spoiled pharmaceuticals can be considered as per food and water (if the original medicine was something relatively minor), or as per the failure of a Pharmacy roll during administration of a dangerous drug (Poison; Speed 1D6 hours; Lethality 5%).
- Attempting to use other "spoiled" consumables (e.g., gasoline or weapon ammo) usually results in them being inert and useless, although the Game Moderator might decide they result in dangerous situations for the users (explosions, damage to weapons, vehicles, etc.)

Junk

Not all equipment the Protagonists will encounter in the game world are in pristine condition. Indeed, some pieces of equipment they find is damaged, poorly maintained, or just badly made.

If your Protagonist is stuck with a junk piece of gear, it fumbles not just on a failed roll with matching numbers, but also on any roll higher than 95.

A junk item also incurs a –20% penalty to any test which involves it being used.

Heavily Worn Items

Some of the items which the Protagonist finds aren't junk but have seen considerable previous use and be heavily worn out.

Items like this work alright but are at the risk of ***becoming*** junk every time the Protagonist puts them into service. After each use the Protagonist must make a **Luck** test. On failure, the worn item has turned into junk (as per above).

It's up to the GM exactly when a perfectly normal pristine item has had so much wear-and-tear that it qualifies as being **Heavily Worn**. This should only happen to equipment or devices that have received considerable 'on screen' use, or were damaged as the result of a skill or stat test going badly.

It is also possible that items obtained (or 'liberated') from a source who heavily over-used them, might prove to be Heavily Worn.

6.0 Vehicles

Depending on the nature of the game setting, different types of simple or sophisticated vehicles might be common items. If the Protagonists or their adversary have access to such vehicles, the following guidelines may assist when dangerous and/or action-oriented scenes involving vehicles arise during play.

Vehicles have three basic statistics:

- **Hit Points and Armor**, in case they're involved in combat, and
- **Speed** ratings that affect chases.

6.1 Hit Points and Armor

Each vehicle counts as a Huge target (see **HUGE**, page 41). It takes damage from unarmed attacks and small weapons such as knives and clubs only when the Game Moderator thinks it makes sense.

A vehicle that loses **half** its Hit Points is badly damaged. It can't be operated without a relevant skill test (depending on the type of vehicle). The next time such a test *fumbles*, the vehicle fails altogether until repaired. Repairing a damaged vehicle requires time, parts, and successful application of one or more skill tests. Even if repaired, the vehicle might now qualify as 'heavily worn' or 'junk' (see **JUNK AND HEAVILY WORN ITEMS**, opposite).

A vehicle that loses *all* of its Hit Points is demolished. It will never function again.

6.1.1 Speed

There are two broad categories of vehicle speed: Surface and Air. Any vehicle with an Air Speed rating can automatically outrun a vehicle with a Surface Speed rating (except for Hot Air Balloons, which can't outrun any vehicle, and Zeppelins which are considered equivalent speed to a Slow Surface vehicle).

Within the same vehicle category, some are faster than others. A vehicle with a 'Fast' rating grants a +20% bonus to any **Drive** or **Pilot** test to pursue or escape. A 'Slow' vehicle incurs a −20% penalty instead. An 'Average' rating confers no modifier.

Jet planes have a speed rating of 'Special.' A jet automatically outruns any vehicle except another jet, and a fighter jet outruns any other kind of jet.

A vehicle that's notorious for poor handling or that's in bad shape might counts as 'heavily worn' or 'junk' (see above) at the GM's discretion.



6.1.2 Some Example Vehicles

The table to the right shows a selection of Modern Era vehicles for land, sea, and air travel.

6.1.3 Ramming

The Game Moderator decides how deadly a collision ought to be. Here are a few suggestions for a vehicle's ramming damage.

AT LOW SPEED: 1D6 or 2D6 damage.

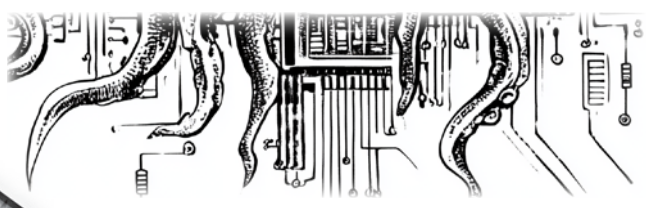
AT MODERATE SPEED: roll half the vehicle's maximum HP as a Lethality rating. A "Slow" vehicle cannot go faster than this.

AT HIGH SPEED: roll the vehicle's maximum HP as a Lethality rating.

If the target is a HUGE creature or another vehicle, the ramming vehicle suffers half ramming damage based on the target's HP.

A vehicle's Armor rating acts as Armor Piercing for its ramming damage.

Every passenger in a ramming vehicle takes 1D6 damage. Every passenger in a rammed vehicle takes 2D6 damage. A worn seat belt halves the damage. A passenger in a vehicle that rams a target less than HUGE size suffers no damage.



Modern Era Vehicles

Vehicle Type	Hit Points	Armor	Speed
Land Vehicles			
Motorcycle	15—20	0	Fast
Medium Car	25—30	3	Average
4WD or Jeep	30—35	3	Average
Armored Car	40	10	Slow
Small Truck	35—40	3	Average
Semi-Trailer	45	3	Slow
Tank	90	20	Slow
Boats and Ships			
Speedboat	25	0	Average
Hovercraft	35	3	Average
Jet Ski	15	0	Fast
Aircraft			
Helicopter	20	0	Average
Light Plane	25	0	Average
Hot Air Balloon	10	0	Slow (see nearby)
Zeppelin	20	0	Slow-Surface
Passenger Jet	50	0	Special (see nearby)
Fighter Jet	40	0	Special (see nearby)

7.0 Sanity

Sanity Points represent the resilience of the relationship between your Protagonist's personality and the world. With high SAN, your Protagonist has confidence in their place in the world. A high SAN score is marked by insight, self-awareness, and a life-affirming view of reality. With low SAN, the deadly truth of the universe has begun to overwhelm your Protagonist. With no SAN, your Protagonist is forever lost.

Unlike the protagonists in many tabletop roleplaying games, *Cthulhu Eternal* Protagonists may begin play with a level of mental scarring due to the harshness of their upbringing. This scarring can manifest itself in different ways — reduced starting SAN, mental disorders, or adaptation to traumatic stimuli. The Protagonist creations rules outline mechanics for determining this psychological damage (**MENTAL DAMAGE FROM HARSH UPBRINGINGS**, page 27).

7.1 Sanity Losses

When your Protagonist faces a threat to sanity, make a SAN test: roll their current SAN or lower of 1D100 to take a diminished loss of SAN points; roll higher than your Protagonist's SAN and they suffer a greater loss of SAN points.

Sanity losses look like: 0/1D4 or 1D6/1D20. The number on the left is how much SAN your Protagonist loses on a successful SAN test; the one on the right is how much SAN your Protagonist loses on a failed test.

7.2 Rules of Thumb for SAN Loss

If the cost of failing a SAN test is 1D6 or less, the cost of success is usually zero. If the cost of failure is 1D8 or 1D10, the cost of success is usually 1. Some unnatural events and encounters are even more catastrophic.

A critical success with a Sanity roll means your Protagonist loses the *least possible* SAN. If the loss for succeeding at the Sanity roll would have been 1D4, they lose 1 point.

Fumbling a Sanity roll means your Protagonist loses the *most possible* SAN. If the loss for failing the Sanity roll would have been 1D20, they lose 20 points.

7.3 Explore the Loss

When your Protagonist loses SAN, take a second to describe it. If the Protagonist loses a few points, how does that look to the people around them? Does the Protagonist jump or cry out in terror? Does the Protagonist stare in shock? Does the Protagonist back away involuntarily? If your Protagonist kills someone and loses no SAN, what does that say about the Protagonist?

What are the long-term effects of repeatedly losing SAN? What strong beliefs or motivations are eroding as your Protagonist's SAN falls? The game is more potent when you play out those details and let them shape your Protagonist.

7.4 Threats to SAN

The three major threats to SAN are Violence, Helplessness and the Unnatural.

These categories can overlap. Being tied up and tortured might trigger both Violence and Helplessness. It's up to the Game Moderator to decide which aspects affects the Protagonist.

7.4.1 Violence

Killing other humans is inherently harmful to sanity. While wrestling and punching people is within biological norms, bludgeoning someone to death is not instinctive. Violence can drive you insane if you're not careful.

In combat, you must make a SAN test for a trauma the first time it happens in that fight. Outside of combat, every individual incident triggers its own SAN loss.

7.4.2 Helplessness

The essential human impulse is to act. True inactivity is unwholesome to the human psyche.

Note that helplessness often makes violence worse, just like violence makes helplessness worse.

7.4.3 The Unnatural

Finally there's the unnatural, the inhuman things of the Cthulhu Mythos that haunt the edges of existence. The unnatural troubles us because it is wholly outside of human experience. It wounds our sense of connection to the world by causing huge gaps in understanding.

This is why your Unnatural skill limits maximum SAN rating. The more you understand of mankind's actual position in the cosmos, the harder it is to navigate in the 'real' world.

If a Protagonist faces the Unnatural and loses 0 SAN, it may mean the Protagonist has adapted to the reality of the Unnatural in some small way — or it may mean simple denial, refusing to admit the Unnatural experience was real. It's up to the player.

Optional Rule: Keep SAN Secret

For greater suspense, each player should keep their Protagonist's current SAN secret from the other players (of course, the Game Moderator must also know all SAN scores). Another approach is for the Game Moderator to keep the current SAN of all Protagonists a secret *even from the players*. You know your Protagonist has lost SAN and you'll know when your Protagonist goes insane, but you won't know the point totals, adding a welcome uncertainty to the game.

SAN Losses: Suffering Violence

Occurence	SAN Loss
Ambushed or hit by gunfire	0 / 1
Find a corpse or a mangled carcass	0 / 1
Find mutilated corpse of infant or loved one	0 / 1D4
Stabbed, strangled or shot	0 / 1D4

Occurence	SAN Loss
Suffer a permanent injury	0 / 1D6
Set on fire	0 / 1D6
Reduced to 2 HP or less	0 / 1D6
Tortured	0 / 1D10

SAN Losses: Inflicting Violence

Occurence	SAN Loss
Incapacitate or cripple an innocent	0 / 1D4
Destroy a teammate's body to thwart discovery*	0 / 1D4
Kill in defense of oneself or another*	0 / 1D4
Kill a murderous enemy in cold blood*	0 / 1D6

Occurence	SAN Loss
Torture a victim	0 / 1D8
Accidentally kill an innocent*	0 / 1D8
Kill an innocent in cold blood, even for a very good reason*	1 / 1D10

* For a failed roll, add 1 per victim beyond the first, up to the maximum possible die-roll: 4 for 1D4, 6 for 1D6, etc.

SAN Losses: Helplessness

Occurence	SAN Loss
Being dismissed from one's role/job	0 / 1
Nearly get an Individual Bond hurt or killed	0 / 1
Losing all personal Permanent Resources	0 / 1
A friend suffers permanent harm or gains a disorder	0 / 1
A Bond's score is reduced to zero	0 / 1D4
Imprisoned or held against will	0 / 1D4
Waking paralyzed or blind	0 / 1D4
Find a friend's remains	0 / 1D4
An Individual Bond suffers permanent harm or gains a disorder	1 / 1D4

Occurence	SAN Loss
Shunned by all members of a Community Bonded organization	1 / 1D4
Flung into a pit of corpses	0 / 1D4
See or hear a friend being gruesomely killed	0 / 1D6
Learn an Individual Bond has been killed	1 / 1D6
See or hear an Individual Bond gruesomely killed	1 / 1D8
Learn that a Community Bonded organization has been destroyed	1 / 1D6
Act in a way that directly leads to collapse of a Community Bonded organization	1 / 1D8

SAN Losses: The Unnatural

Occurence	SAN Loss
Attempting Psychoanalyze on a character who lost SAN to the Unnatural	0 / 1
Witnessing a supernatural effect that's apparently benign	0 / 1
Witnessing a violent supernatural effect	0 / 1D6

Occurence	SAN Loss
Seeing a corpse walk	0 / 1D6
Subjected to an overtly supernatural effect	0 / 1D6
Suffering a violent supernatural assault	1 / 1D8 or more

7.5 Insanity and Disorders

Protagonists who lose excessive SAN lose control of themselves, suffering insanity and mental disorders.

TEMPORARY INSANITY (see below): A Protagonist who loses 5 or more points of SAN in a single roll suffers temporary insanity.

DISORDER (see right): Every time your Protagonist's SAN is reduced to their Breaking Point (see **DERIVED ATTRIBUTES** on page 8), they gain a new disorder. Immediately reset your Protagonist's Breaking Point to your Protagonist's current SAN minus POW. Even if SAN rises back above the old Breaking Point, the disorder and the new Breaking Point remain.

PERMANENT INSANITY (page 56): If your Protagonist hits 0 SAN, they suffer permanent insanity and becomes the property of the Game Moderator.

7.6 Temporary Insanity

In a moment of overwhelming stress — after losing 5 or more SAN in a single roll — your Protagonist loses self-control. We call it temporary insanity. For a short time, you cannot control your Protagonist's actions. Your Protagonist's primitive brain switches to pure panic, with one of three possible responses: Flee, Struggle, or Submit.

Work with the Game Moderator to determine which stance your Protagonist takes. Each is more likely in some circumstances than others.

If the circumstances are calm, it may be possible to talk your Protagonist down from temporary insanity.

Such attempts are tests of the **Psychoanalyze** skill.

In the absence of anything like that, your Protagonist loses control until the insanity runs its course.

7.6.1 Flee

Your Protagonist must move away from the SAN-affecting stimulus at top speed in any direction. Your Protagonist must do this for a number of turns equal to their CON, whereupon your Protagonist falls to the ground exhausted (see **EXHAUSTION** on page 31), or until your Protagonist feels 'safe', whichever happens first. This is a common reaction against Unnatural and Violence SAN threats.

7.6.2 Struggle

This is lashing out randomly at the nearest threat, no matter how insurmountable it might be. Once this course is set upon, your Protagonist has no choice but to fight until they are killed, unconscious, or restrained. This is a common reaction against Helplessness and Violence SAN threats.



7.6.3 Submit

This is shutting down or passing out from shock. If conscious, your Protagonist is catatonic and paralyzed until the Game Moderator decides they snap out of it. When your Protagonist comes to, it's likely they have suppressed the trauma that caused their collapse. Remembering details requires an **INT×5** test and is terribly stressful. This is a common reaction against Unnatural and Helplessness SAN threats.

7.6.4 Understanding the Unnatural

Whenever your Protagonist goes temporarily insane or develops a disorder due to an encounter with the Unnatural, they also gain some deeper understanding of the true nature of reality.

If your Protagonist had no prior knowledge of the Cthulhu Mythos (i.e., has an **Unnatural** skill rating of 0), such an experience causes them to gain +5 percentiles in the Unnatural skill. Even if they already knew about the Unnatural, such an experience grants a further +1 percentile to the Unnatural skill.

This increase also serves to reduce the Protagonist's maximum SAN (and if current SAN is higher than this value, also causes it to drop to the new maximum).

7.7 Disorders

A Protagonist whose SAN reaches the Breaking Point gains a disorder. When suffering from a disorder, the mind maladapts to mental trauma with long-term neuroses. A disorder is like a release valve for intolerable stress. Indulging in it helps your Protagonist cope. It's possible to suffer from multiple disorders at the same time.

Any disorder is negative in the long term, but some are worse than others. Whatever the source of the disorder, it takes the form of an irrational adaptation to the trauma that produced it. It may manifest a few hours after the trauma, or it might take days, weeks, or months to appear.

The player and the Game Moderator negotiate the exact nature of your Protagonist's psychological trauma, so it makes sense. If your Protagonist saw their partner die in a fire, developing pyrophobia makes sense for example.

7.7.1 Acute Episodes

A disorder is a chronic, ongoing condition. It lurks under the surface, threatening to erupt when things get bad. Each disorder suggests triggers that bring on acute episodes. Acute episodes last as long as your Protagonist is in the crisis or in the presence of the trigger and usually for at least a few hours afterward. In an acute episode, the Protagonist succumbs to the disorder's internal logic and must act accordingly. If your Protagonist suffers from more than one disorder, the Game Moderator decides which comes to the fore.

REPRESSING AN EPISODE: When an acute episode begins, your Protagonist can attempt to repress it by projecting the stress and trauma onto a Bond. See **USING BONDS TO REPRESS INSANITY** on page 57.

EFFECTS OF AN EPISODE: Suffering an acute episode of a disorder often means your Protagonist can't take some actions (or can attempt them only with a penalty), or your Protagonist must take some actions. The Game Moderator always decides the exact repercussions, and whether it happens immediately or builds gradually, in the aftermath of the trauma.

When your Protagonist is going through an acute episode, make sure it is obvious to everyone that something is wrong.

An Insight roll can diagnose your Protagonist's particular disorder.

It may be possible for someone to talk your Protagonist down despite the crisis or the presence of the trigger, reducing the impact of the disorder so the Protagonist can regain self-control. That takes a few minutes.

Such attempts are tests of the **Psychoanalyze** skill.

Optional Rule: Insane Insight

Sometimes Protagonists who face massive psychological damage from unnatural trauma come away with strange insights.

If your Protagonist suffers temporary insanity due to an Unnatural trauma, they might gain some special insight into the specific creature or Mythos Power encountered.

Immediately after going insane, the Protagonist can attempt an **INT×5** test — if this roll ***fails***, the Game Moderator can provide the Protagonist with some salient detail about the monstrosity, which may prove helpful in defeating it.

Psychoactive Sedatives

Your Protagonist may have access to substances which can stave off the onset of an acute episode or dull its effects. These are, at best, short-term remedies and come with their own negative impacts.

Taking a benzodiazepine or an opiate (or even opium) gives your Protagonist a +20% bonus to resist an acute episode of a disorder at the cost of a –20% penalty to everything else. Using such drugs frequently makes addiction to them a likely result of your Protagonist's next disorder. If that happens, the drugs no longer confer any bonus to reduce acute episodes of a disorder, but still inflict the penalty.

Heavy drinking, magic mushrooms or marijuana gives your Protagonist a +10% bonus to resist an acute episode at the same –20% penalty to other actions. Alcohol runs the risk of addiction.



7.7.2 Sample Disorders

There are many adaptations the mind makes when exposed to traumatic events, whether they be violence and gore, feelings of utter helplessness, or the inherent 'wrongness' of unnatural Cthulhu Mythos beings. The specific disorder received by a Protagonist should never be a random roll on a table, but something specifically selected to relate to the trauma they suffered.

Addiction

Your Protagonist relies on a harmful habit or substance to get by. However much harm the addiction causes, your Protagonist needs the relief it offers. Losing 2+ SAN in any single roll triggers an acute episode, an overwhelming need. Feeding it usually imparts a −20% penalty to stats and skills for a few hours due to intoxication or distraction. And even in the best of times, going 24 hours without feeding the addiction costs 1D6 WP and prevents your Protagonist from recovering any WP. Every further 24 hours costs 1D6 WP. At 2 or fewer WP, your Protagonist does irrational, self-destructive things to feed the addiction.

Amnesia

This is a common disorder from encounters with the unnatural. Losing 2+ SAN in any single roll triggers an acute episode, which erases all memory of the episode until your Protagonist finds a way to bring it back.

Depression

Acute depression means total despair and a crushing inability to get anything done. It sometimes takes the shape of overwhelming guilt. An acute episode is triggered by reminders of past traumas your Protagonist suffered or inflicted, which can come in the most surprising forms and moments. During an acute episode, every skill or stat test costs 1D4 WP.

Hysterical Blindness / Deafness / Paralysis

Collectively called conversion disorder, this can manifest either as non-physical blindness, deafness, or paralysis (pick one). Losing 2+ SAN in any single roll triggers an acute episode, which leaves your Protagonist blind, deaf, or paralyzed with numbness and tremors until the source of stress goes away.

Mania

Your Protagonist displays a euphoric and perhaps irritable mood that is consistently present. This may include frenzied activity for no obvious reason, uncharacteristic garrulousness, a random stream-of-consciousness flow of ideas, or difficulty sleeping. An acute episode is triggered whenever your Protagonist loses 2+ SAN in a single roll. During an acute episode all tasks which require concentration or fine control are at **one-fifth chance**.

Megalomania / Narcissistic

What does it mean to look upon the face of a dead god and live? Some see themselves as messiahs, or as exempt from ordinary morality. Losing 2+ SAN in any single roll triggers an acute episode, in which every hint of doubt about your Protagonist's superiority fills them with indignation. That causes every use of a stat or skill to get help or make a good impression to fail.

Multiple Personalities

Most of the time, your Protagonist seems fine. Suffering temporary insanity or reaching the Breaking Point triggers an acute episode, in which your Protagonist takes on an alternate identity with its own personality and memories. Over time, more identities may surface. The Game Moderator decides when and whether you keep control of your Protagonist's behavior.

Obsession

Your Protagonist becomes fixated on some person, place, event, act, or idea. Losing 2+ SAN in any single roll triggers an acute episode, which lasts days. In that time, any long-term action or skill use — anything taking more than a few hours — is at −20% because your Protagonist's mind is so often wrapped around its obsession.

Paranoia

A state of extreme suspicion, in which a fear of invisible enemies pervades one's world-view. Losing 2+ SAN in any single roll triggers an acute episode. Unless your Protagonist finds a way to stifle their paranoia, they can't trust or rely on anyone. Every event, every disagreement or source of suspicion is a clue to a conspiracy against the Protagonist.

Phobia or Philia

A common affliction arising from traumatic experiences is the development of an irrational fear of something related (directly or by association) with the incident. These are called phobias and can be quite debilitating. Whenever a Protagonist is in the presence of a trigger for their phobia, they must make a SAN test (even if the trigger is not terrifying in any way to others). Failure means an acute episode has been triggered, during which there's little choice but to suffer the Flee or Submit response to temporary insanity (see page 55). A nearby box provides some examples of phobias; searching online will reveal a huge array of other (sometimes quite weird) phobias.

A less common response to experiencing something shocking is the development of an irrational fetish or allure for something odd that is associated with the situation (perhaps which somehow related to the Protagonist's survival). These are called philias and work in a similar way to phobias in that whenever the afflicted Protagonist is in the presence of their irrational fetish a **SAN** roll is required to maintain any degree of self-control. If

Phobias

ACROPHOBIA: Fear of heights
AGOROPHOBIA: Fear of open places
AILUROPHOBIA: Fear of cats
ANDROPHOBIA (for female Protagonists): Fear of males
APIPHOBIA: Fear of bees
ARACHNOPHOBIA: Fear of spiders
ASTROPHOBIA: Fear of thunder, lightning and storms
BACTERIOPHOBIA: Fear of bacteria
BACTRACHOPHOBIA: Fear of frogs & toads
BATHOPHOBIA: Fear of the deep sea
BELONEPHOBIA: Fear of pins & needles
BOTANOPHOBIA: Fear of plants
CATOPTROPHOBIA: Fear of mirrors
CLAUSTROPHOBIA: Fear of confined spaces
DEMOPHOBIA: Fear of crowds
DENDROPHOBIA: Fear of trees
DORAPHOBIA: Fear of fur
ENTOPHOBIA: Fear of insects
GYNEPHOBIA (for male Protagonists): Fear of females
HEMATOPHOBIA: Fear of blood
HYLEPHOBIA: Fear of forests
IATROPHOBIA: Fear of doctors
MONOPHOBIA: Fear of being alone
NECROPHOBIA: Fear of dead things
OPHIOPHOBIA: Fear of snakes
PYROPHOBIA: Fear of fire
SCOTOPHOBIA: Fear of darkness
TAPHEPHOBIA: Fear of being buried alive
TECHNOPHOBIA: Fear of technology
THALASSOPHOBIA: Fear of the sea
TRICHOPHOBIA: Fear of hair
TRISKADEKAPHOBIA: Fear of the number 13
XENOPHOBIA: Fear of foreigners
ZOOPHOBIA: Fear of Animals

failed, an acute episode results during which the Game Moderator will dictate your Protagonist's actions until they regain control. The list of phobias shown nearby can be converted into philias by simply inverting them: for example, where scotophobia is a fear of darkness, scotophilia is an obsessive and irrational predisposition to shroud oneself in darkness.

Psychogenic Fugue

Your Protagonist may shut down into catatonia or wander off in an unconnected daze. It often manifests in the face of emotional or personal complications. Suffering temporary insanity or reaching the Breaking Point triggers an acute episode during which your Protagonist may disappear for days at a time, returning with no memory of their recent past.

Schizoid

Your Protagonist's personality changes towards an uncharacteristic emotionlessness. They will be perceived as cold or aloof by most people. This can have a devastating effect on interpersonal relationships. In game terms, all personal interaction skill tests or **CHA** tests are halved at any time. Whenever your Protagonist loses 2+ SAN on any single roll, they suffer an acute episode during which the emotionlessness amplifies to the point where CHA tests must be made at **one-fifth chance**. Such episodes usually last a few days.

PTSD aka "Shell Shock"

Post-traumatic stress disorder is a psychiatric disorder that occurs following life-threatening events. Some people shake off such horrors, while others have stress reactions. Victims of Shell Shock/PTSD relive the experience through nightmares and flashbacks, have difficulty sleeping, are subject to depression, and can be overcome by anxiety when presented with a similar situation. An acute episode is triggered by reminders of past traumas your Protagonist suffered or inflicted. In an acute episode, the Game Moderator chooses one effect: your Protagonist either reacts violently to threats only the Protagonist perceives, or suffers an acute depressive episode. (See **DEPRESSION**, nearby, for details.)

7.8 Permanent Insanity

A Protagonist who drops to 0 SAN is effectively 'lost.' Just as being reduced to 0 Hit Points permanently removes your Protagonist from your control through physical death, being reduced to 0 SAN permanently removes your Protagonist from your control through insanity. Protagonists at 0 SAN have embraced a world of violence, helplessness, and death. No therapy or treatment will ever bring them back.

It remains up to the Game Moderator to determine when the Protagonist is 'removed' from play. Sometimes it is instant; after the SAN loss, the Protagonist collapses weeping and refuses to re-engage with reality.

Sometimes it's more subtle. Many dangerous psychopaths get by for months or years without detection. A player who enjoys this kind of challenge may work in tandem with the Game Moderator to keep playing a character with 0 SAN as if things were normal. If you keep all SAN totals secret (see **OPTIONAL RULE: KEEP SAN SECRET** on page 51), this should not be difficult.

Usually, a character who reaches 0 SAN is either Catatonic, Delusional, or Psychopathic.

Catatonia

Catatonia is complete separation. Your Protagonist's mind refuses to engage with the world that injured it. Your Protagonist no longer speaks, or eats (without prompting), or looks after themself; your Protagonist stares into space in a trance. Some catatonics go so deep they no longer react to physical pain. Others rise in and out of consciousness.

Delusions

Your Protagonist is raving, incapable of holding a conversation that does not stray into insanity. Your Protagonist is absolutely certain of the truth of their delusions and acts and responds as though they are completely real, even if that means violence. Nothing can dissuade your Protagonist of their reality.

Psychopathy

This goes beyond ordinary sociopathy. At 0 SAN, empathy has been burned out of your Protagonist. The feelings and needs of others cannot touch them. People are mere objects for their amusement or use. Your Protagonist sometimes engages in appallingly merciless actions for gratification. Some psychopaths with 0 SAN appear fine; they are no longer emotionally functional or concerned with people on a human scale, but they keep a simulated veneer of civility. Many serial killers have been classified as functional psychopaths.

7.9 Resisting Insanity

It's possible to resist SAN loss and insanity through adaptation and by placing stress on Individual and Community Bonds. But suffering a trauma always comes with a cost.

7.9.1 Adapting to SAN Loss

People can become hardened to traumatic stimuli. What sends one Protagonist fleeing may seem mundane to an individual who has survived it often enough. Adaptation to Violence or to Helplessness means you always succeed at a Sanity roll for that type of trauma.

Adaptation to Violence or adaptation to Helplessness occurs after your Protagonist has lost SAN from that kind of trauma three times in a row without going temporarily insane from it or hitting the Breaking Point. The character sheet has spaces to mark your Protagonist's progress toward adaptation. Each time Violence or Helplessness reduces your Protagonist's SAN by 1 or more, mark a box on your character sheet to keep track of it.

If your Protagonist suffers insanity from Violence before all three boxes are marked, erase all the "Violence" boxes and start again. If your Protagonist suffers insanity from Helplessness before all three boxes are marked, erase all the "Helplessness" boxes and start again. If you fill in all three boxes for Violence or all three for Helplessness, your Protagonist becomes adapted to that type of stressor.

ADAPTING TO VIOLENCE: Unfortunately, being adapted to Violence means your Protagonist's empathy suffers. They permanently lose 1D6 CHA and the same amount from each Bond (Individual and Community).

ADAPTING TO HELPLESSNESS: Being adapted to Helplessness means your Protagonist's personal drive suffers. As soon as your Protagonist becomes adapted to Helplessness, they permanently lose 1D6 POW.

ADAPTING TO THE UNNATURAL: There is no adapting to the unnatural. Things that exist beyond human comprehension are beyond 'getting used to.' Every new encounter is a fresh shock. The only way to 'adapt' to the Unnatural is to reach 0 SAN, whereupon the horrors of the Cthulhu Mythos make perfect sense and no longer inflict mental damage.

7.9.2 Projecting Onto A Bond

When your Protagonist loses SAN, you may spend WP to reduce the loss. The amount is always 1D4: roll the die and reduce your WP by that much.

If your Protagonist still has at least 1 WP, reduce the SAN loss by the amount of WP spent — the amount you rolled — to a minimum of zero.

Now reduce one of your Protagonist's Bond scores by the same amount. It could be an Individual Bond or a Community Bond. The next time your Protagonist interacts with the subject of the Bond, decide what shape the projection takes.

Does the Protagonist grow hostile and angry, irrationally blaming their loved one for imagined wrongs? Does the Protagonist abandon his community in favor of relationships with less importance and meaning? The stresses faced by Protagonists often wreck the families, friendships and associations that give them strength.

7.9.3 Using Bonds to Repress Insanity

Sometimes it's easier to cope with mental trauma if you pull strength and motivation from the relationships that give life meaning. You may attempt to repress the blind panic of temporary insanity or an acute episode of a disorder by spending Willpower Points. The amount is always 1D4: roll the die and reduce your WP by that much.

If your Protagonist still has at least 1 WP after spending the 1D4, describe how a Bond might help your Protagonist keep it together and reduce the Bond by the same amount.

Now attempt a SAN roll. If it succeeds, your Protagonist suppresses the insanity or disorder and behaves normally. If it fails, the attempt to repress the effects did not succeed — they occur as normal, despite the points of WP and Bond strength sacrificed in the attempt.

Either way, make a note to describe later how the Bond has strained because your Protagonist has taken so much support from it.

7.10 Recovering Sanity

There are a few ways to restore mental health. These are described below.

7.10.1 Defeating Unnatural Creatures

The Unnatural in Cthulhu Eternal represents such an affront to the human mind that gaining any control over it is a sort of victory. At the Game Moderator's discretion, any destruction of a Cthulhu Mythos infiltration by a Protagonist can restore hope — and in the process, SAN.

As a rule, destroying an unnatural creature or an object known to contain otherworldly power restores an amount of SAN equivalent to the lowest amount that could be lost for encountering it.

If the SAN loss is 1/1D6, for example, destroying it restores 1 SAN. If the SAN loss is 1D6/1D20, your Protagonist gains 1D6 SAN for destroying it.

This can mean your Protagonist gains more SAN from overcoming the threat than they actually lost from facing it. But it can never bring SAN higher than the Maximum SAN score: i.e., 99 minus your Protagonist's rating in the Unnatural skill.

Each Protagonist who was directly involved in putting the threat down gains this SAN increase.

7.10.2 Concluding a Dangerous Adventure

Once a deadly adventure has been successfully brought to a close, all Protagonists left alive can breathe a sigh of relief that — for now at least — the world is a safer place. The Game Moderator is justified in awarding such Protagonists a small increase in SAN (and published scenarios may include specific SAN rewards associated with different levels of success). Such gains can never push the Protagonist's current SAN any higher than Maximum SAN (99 – Unnatural).

7.10.3 Destroying Accounts of the Unnatural

To a Protagonist whose sanity has been blasted by revelations about the horrors of the Unnatural, the fact that accounts exist which lay bare such secrets is disturbing. It is via such dire accounts — ancient tomes, journals or even files in an electronic database — that the madness spreads. Accordingly, some who have lost sanity from unnatural Mythos encounters make it their mission to track down such records and destroy them. What better way to protect humanity than rid it of these dangerous traps? This, in part, explains why true permanent accounts of the Unnatural are so rare.

Protagonists who have experienced the Unnatural and who deliberately destroy a permanent record of secret information can earn a small boost to SAN, at the discretion of the Game Moderator. To qualify, the item in question must contain an actual authentic account of the Mythos (see page 63) and the Protagonist's actions must be deliberate, willful, and cause its permanent and total destruction. The Protagonist must also believe in the veracity of the account.

The amount of SAN increase depends upon the how many Mythos secrets the account reveals — this is measured by the Unnatural skill point gain associated with reading/viewing the account.

Unnatural Skill Gain	SAN benefit of destruction
+1 to +3	1D3
+4 to +6	1D6
+7 to +12	2D6
+13 to +16	2D8
+17 or more	2D10

Such gains can never push the Protagonist's current SAN any higher than **Maximum SAN** (99 – Unnatural).

7.10.4 Getting Help with Mental Illness

After the adventure your Protagonist can attempt to recuperate with empathetic colleagues or by focusing on their Bonds; the things that give your Protagonist strength (see **DOWNTIME**, below). Any such recovery can never push the Protagonist's current SAN any higher than their **Recovery SAN** (POW×5), or **Maximum SAN**, whichever is lower.

7.10.5 Pursuing Personal Goals or Caring for Individuals

Time spent between adventures doing things that naturally reassert your Protagonist's 'normal' life can slightly improve their SAN (see **DOWNTIME**, below). This can only increase current SAN up to their **Recovery SAN** (POW×5), or **Maximum SAN**, whichever is lower.



8.0 Downtime

Games of *Cthulhu Eternal* should feature occasional scenes that focus on Protagonists' everyday lives. These short vignettes should last no more than a few minutes. Typically, they occur between adventures, but the Game Moderator always decides when and whether one is appropriate. These vignettes are a chance to explore the most important things in your Protagonist's life — and to see whether those things are deteriorating thanks to the Protagonist's experience of the secret horrors of the world.

8.1 What Changed

In a downtime vignette, take stock of what changed for your Protagonist in the last adventure.

BONDS DAMAGED OR BROKEN: Describe how each relationship has deteriorated.

PERMANENT INJURIES: Describe what they look like.

DISORDERS GAINED: Did your Protagonist hit the Breaking Point during the adventure? Now's the time for the Game Moderator to decide what disorder the Protagonist gains.

COMMUNITY: If your Protagonist misused their contacts, authority, or resources from their home community, describe how actions during the adventure may have impacted your Protagonist's reputation or standing. Does this impact any Community Bonds?

JUSTICE: Did your Protagonist break the rules of the local community? Does that impact any Individual or Community Bonds?

8.2 Personal Pursuits

For the vignette, the player chooses one of the following pursuits. Describe how your Protagonist is pursuing it, and roll the appropriate stat, skill, or SAN test to resolve it.

Choose from these pursuits:

8.2.1 Fulfill Responsibilities to Individuals

If your Protagonist focuses on day-to-day obligations and relationships, describe something the Protagonist is doing to support an Individual Bond. Roll a SAN test. Success improves the Individual Bond by 1D6 (up to your Protagonist's CHA); a critical success also adds 1 SAN (up to your **Recovery SAN**). Failure adds 1 to the Bond. A fumble means some disastrous conflict reduces the Individual Bond by 1D4 and your SAN by 1. Describe how the relationship has improved because of your Protagonist's efforts or worsened despite them.

8.2.2 Reorganizing and Replenishing Personal Resources

As described in **REPLENISHING RESOURCES, REMOVING CHECKMARKS** (page 16), if your Protagonist actively drew from their personal pool of Resources during an adventure, there will be check marks on the character sheet to record this. By investing some downtime (half a day or more) to reorganize or replenish your stash of resources, all such checks marks can be erased. Describe the lengths your Protagonist goes to tidy up or restock.

8.2.3 Gaining Favor of the Community at Large

Your Protagonist may choose to spend time attempting to improve their status within a group or society, as represented by a Community Bond they ***already have***. This may involve influencing key individuals to build a support-base or working hard to solve the community's problems and earn their respect.

A major investment of time warrants a SAN test — success means that your Protagonist's actions have drawn the attention of key people in the community. A fumbled SAN roll means that some terrible error of judgement by your Protagonist creates a negative reaction: this reduces the bond value by –1D3 and causes a loss of 1 point of SAN.

If the SAN roll succeeded, there is a chance that the positive attention from the community may convert into an increase in status. Make a second D100 roll and compare it to current **Community Bond rating×5**. If the roll is *higher* than the target, the Community Bond value improves:

- If the original SAN roll was a **normal success**: +1 to bond value
- If the original SAN roll was a **critical success**: +2 to bond value

The causes of the increase or decrease in status should be described, along with their impact.

8.2.4 Back to Nature

Your Protagonist can spend time in contemplative seclusion, minimizing stress, distractions, and obligations. This isn't a holiday; it's extended time alone, or mostly alone, in an environment that's physically active but places few other demands on the Protagonist. This reduces one Bond (either Individual or Community) by 1 as you let other responsibilities lapse. Roll a SAN test. Success adds 1D4 SAN, or 4 for a critical (up to your **Recovery SAN**). Failure adds 1 SAN. A fumble costs 1D4 SAN. Describe the impact of this time alone.

8.2.5 Establish a New Individual Bond

Your Protagonist may attempt to create a new Individual Bond with a character. This is not done lightly. It means this new character is developing into an essential,

important part of your Protagonist's life. Attempt a **CHA×5** test. Success establishes a new Individual Bond with a score equal to half your Protagonist's CHA (round up). Unfortunately, devoting so much attention to the new Bond reduces the value of one other Bond — either reduce an Individual Bond by 1D4 or a Community Bond by 1.

8.2.6 Establish a New Community Bond

Your Protagonist attempts to establish membership in a new community and assert some kind of status within its 'pecking order'. You might do this because you have just arrived in a new place, or because you wish to take on a position of standing within a group (e.g., an elite order) that provides social benefits. Getting accepted to a position of trust within a community is not easy. Attempt a **CHA×5** test. Success establishes a new Community Bond with a score equal to **half** your Protagonist's Permanent Resources rating (round up). Devoting energy to currying the favor needed to establish the new Bond reduces the value of one other Bond — either reduce an Individual Bond by 1D4 or a (different) Community Bond by 1.

8.2.7 Get Help With Mental Illnesses

Depending on where and when your game is set, Protagonists may have the option of accessing professional mental health services to try to overcome the ill-effects accrued through traumatic experiences. Prior to the mid-20th Century, such services were very primitive and arguably more damaging to sanity than curative. The GM will be the final arbiter as to whether reliable and high-quality psychotherapy services are available. However, even in settings where no such facilities exist there are still ways to get help in more old-fashioned ways.

Therapy

If your Protagonist chooses to enlist a clinical therapist to deal with their psychological damage, they are committing to an ongoing process requiring honesty and commitment.

Your Protagonist must decide whether to truthfully tell the therapist what caused the SAN loss.

- If your Protagonist tells the truth, there are risks. If the SAN loss came from confronting the Cthulhu Mythos, your therapist might diagnose your Protagonist as suffering from schizophrenia. Alternatively, if the therapist believes your Protagonist's account, they may in turn lose SAN from the shocking details they reveal.

  The outcomes of therapy are determined by a roll against the therapist's Psychoanalyze skill. If your Protagonist described unnatural events and the therapist thinks they're delusions, that skill is halved. If the roll fumbles, your Protagonist loses 1 SAN. If it succeeds, your Protagonist regains 1D6 SAN (or 6 with a critical success), up to their **Recovery SAN**.

  If your Protagonist shares tales of terrible, illegal violence and it sounds like further violence is imminent, the therapist may report it to the authorities. Whether that happens is entirely up to the GM.

- If, on the other hand, your Protagonist *doesn't* tell the therapist the truth, healing is limited. Make a roll against the therapist's **Psychoanalyze** skill. If it fumbles, your Protagonist loses 1 SAN. If it succeeds, your Protagonist regains 1D4 SAN (or 4 for a critical success), up to their **Recovery SAN**.

If your Protagonist suffers from a disorder, a critical success with the therapist's roll cures it (whether your Protagonist told the truth or not). Your Protagonist also develops a Bond with the therapist equal to half your Protagonist's CHA (or add 1D4 to it if your Protagonist already has that Bond, up to the Protagonist's CHA). They also lose points from another bond of your choice (1D4 from one individual Bond or 1 from a Community Bond). Write a note saying "cured" next to the disorder on the character sheet — but do not erase it. The next time you gain a disorder, you must roll another SAN test. If that fails, the "cured" disorder returns in full force alongside the new one.

Regardless of whether the rolls result in improvements, the long hours spent with an empathetic person reduces one Bond (either Individual or Community) by 1 as you let other responsibilities lapse.





Talking it Out

Even if no clinical psychotherapy is available to your Protagonist, there is still the time-honored method of healing a damaged mind through sharing one's burden with an empathic person who one knows and trusts. This other person might be a spiritual adviser, a folk-psychiatrists, or just a kind-hearted fellow member of the community that is willing to reassure you.

Being helped through the process of recovering from mental trauma works in a similar way to therapy although takes a lot longer and has less certain outcomes. As with therapy there are risks to sharing detailed accounts of the events that caused the original SAN loss, both to the empathic person (who could take SAN from the account) and to the Protagonist (if the other individual alerts others).

- As with formal therapy, the effectiveness of folk remedies is determined through skill rolls against the **Psychoanalyze** skill (or an alternate skill substituted by the GM as fits the game's setting). The difference is that for any benefit to be achieved, the empathic person must succeed in two consecutive rolls.
- If the Protagonist has not been truthful in relating their story, they can still gain some benefit: a pair of consecutive successful rolls will give them 1D2 SAN back (2 with a critical success), up to their POW × 5. If the Protagonist was truthful, the reward is 1D3 SAN (3 with a critical success), to the same maximum.

For a Protagonist to have a disorder cured through folk remedies, the empathic listener must get two consecutive critical successes on their rolls. If that occurs, it functions in the same way to a therapist making a critical success.

As with therapists, the hours spent with the empathic listener has the inevitable impact that one other bond (either Individual or Community) is reduced by 1 as you let responsibilities lapse. If the long conversations led to a disorder being cured, you will automatically develop or strengthen an Individual Bond with the empathic listener as noted above for successful therapy outcomes — but at the cost of another bond becoming weaker.

8.2.8 Improve a Skill or Stat

By training or studying extensively, your Protagonist can try to boost a stat or a skill. This reduces one Bond (either Individual or Community) by 1 as you let other responsibilities lapse.

Describe what your Protagonist is doing to improve the stat or skill: poring over crumbling textbooks for INT or a skill, lifting weights for STR, meditating to strengthen self-discipline for POW, socializing or taking leadership courses for CHA, undergoing medical rehabilitation to regain stat points permanently lost from an injury, etc.

If you wish to gain points in a skill you don't already possess and which has a Base Chance of 0%, you can ***only*** do this if you are being trained by someone who has at least 20% in that skill. Under no circumstances can the Unnatural skill be improved through training.

Attempt a test of **the stat × 5** or the skill. If the test fails, your Protagonist has improved. Add 3D6 percentage points to the skill (to a maximum of 99%) or one point to the stat (to a maximum of 18).

8.2.9 Personal Motivation

Your Protagonist indulges in the things that they find meaningful. This reduces one Bond (either Individual or Community) by 1 as you let other responsibilities lapse. Roll a SAN test. Success adds 1 SAN, or 1D4 for a critical (up to your Protagonist's **Recovery SAN**). A fumble costs 1 SAN.

8.2.10 Accounts of the Cthulhu Mythos / Learning Rituals

Your Protagonist may have unearthed records — e.g., ancient tomes, journals or even files in an electronic database — which claim to contain wisdom about the Cthulhu Mythos forces which haunt the world. They can devote time to trying to delve into such accounts or trying to learn the arcane rituals they describe. See **MADDENING REVELATIONS** on page 63 for more on how such research is performed.



PART II: GAME MODERATOR RESOURCES

This section consists of a series of resources which are designed to help a Game Moderator design exciting and dangerous scenarios to challenge a Protagonist Group. It describes:

- The ways in which knowledge of the Cthulhu Mythos may be learned by Protagonists through **Maddening Revelations**, including the study of Tomes of Arcane Lore.
- Mechanics for describing the practice of Mythos-themed magickal **Rituals**; including the means by which Protagonists might learn to perform such supernatural rites.
- Guidelines for **Designing Supernatural Effects**, including the effects of successful rituals or the powers wielded by terrifying entities of the Cthulhu Mythos.

9.0 Maddening Revelations

A common feature of Cthulhu Mythos fiction is the existence of musty old tomes which describe the 'truth' about mankind's perilous place in the universe, and the powers thirsting for cosmic upheaval. In the Jazz Age such revelations might be found buried in ancient tomes, journals or miscellaneous manuscripts. Alternatively, the secret knowledge might be passed down from generation-to-generation through spoken tales and mystic traditions.

Revelatory accounts and the secret information they contain can, if you wish, be important parts of your *Cthulhu Eternal* game. Some of the revelations might describe supernatural powers or "magickal effects" that Protagonists might be able to utilize to fight back the shadows. Often these will require they perform time-consuming rituals drawn from mystical traditions.

9.1 Researching the Mythos

If you as Game Moderator want to include a form of revelatory information in your game, there are a few factors to consider:

- How will the Protagonist's locate it?
- What skill rolls are needed to read it (or view it, or otherwise access its information)?
- How long does it take to study the information before it is understood?
- Does the information cause a Sanity Loss to those who learn it?
- Does understanding the revelations cause an increase in skills?
- Does it impart some other benefit, such as the chance to learn a magickal ritual?

Mythos accounts offer one of the few ways in which Protagonists may increase their rating in the **Unnatural** skill. Each has an associated amount of Unnatural skill gain that it might potentially impart … if only the Protagonist is able to see past its disordered jumble of insane ideas. Simple accounts of the Cthulhu Mythos might impart just a few points (+1 to +3 perhaps) while weighty records (like those immortalized in the infamous Necronomicon) might offer the reader thorough and dangerous insight (+15 or more points of increase in **Unnatural**).

9.1.1 Finding Information

If the 'tome' (or other information source) is hidden away or stored as part of a vast collection, Protagonists may need to exercise a range of skills to track it down. Or maybe interpersonal skills will allow them to get directions to it from people who are knowledgeable about the collection?

9.1.2 Accessing and Understanding the Contents

If the item is expressed in a language other than the common vernacular, understanding it might require a relevant **Foreign Language** test. This is especially true if the information is expressed in archaic or highly specialized language. Other possibilities:

- If the knowledge locked up in the account is highly contextualized or esoteric systems of thought it might also require an **Occult** test.
- If it is so full of references back to antiquated knowledge that it can't readily be understood, perhaps a **History** or **Anthropology** test might be required.
- On the other hand, if the knowledge is closely tied to people, places, folklore and events from a particular geography then maybe a relevant **Regional Lore** test may be needed.
- If the information is locked away in some technological recording — on a video camera or busted server — there may be a need for Protagonists to succeed in **Technology Use** tests, or track down replacement parts, or even use **Craft** skills to build apparatus to decode and display the information in a human-readable form.

9.1.3 Immersion

To the layperson, an account of the Cthulhu Mythos looks like nothing more than a random collection of disjointed thoughts, none of them imparting any real meaning. This is because most people have no prior experience of the Unnatural and thus have no reason to think that the gibbering ravings might be something meaningful.

If the Protagonist undertaking the research has an **Unnatural** skill rating of 0, they will be likewise unconvinced. Such an individual will be unable to become sufficiently 'immersed' in the account's buried secrets to learn anything useful at all.

On the other hand, a researcher with skill in **Unnatural** may be able to see beyond the disconnected rantings and perceive the implied secrets. This requires an **Immersion test:** a roll against the Protagonist's current **Unnatural skill × 10** with a negative modifier based on the account's weightiness (measured by the amount of potential additional Unnatural skill it may afford the cautious reader).

Tome's Unnatural Skill Gain	Modifier to Immersion Test
+1 to +3	0
+4 to +6	-10
+7 to +12	-20
+13 to +16	-30
+17 or more	-40

If this roll fails, the researcher becomes convinced that the account is gibberish. No matter how many days or weeks they invest in studying it, that belief will prevent any deeper understanding of its contents.

If this roll is a *critical* success, the researcher becomes obsessed with the account — and will want to pursue its analysis at all costs. This might present some difficult situations, but also means the research (see below) will be completed in **half** the normal time.

9.1.4 Investing Time

Delving into a weighty account of the Mythos might take months, especially if it is rendered in rambling and confusing language; on the other hand, the information might be presented in a form that only takes a few minutes to comprehend. You as Game Moderator should make a call as to the amount of time that a Protagonist must invest in order to properly appreciate the contents of the knowledge source — in general, the more cryptic and voluminous, the longer it will take. Conceivably, some records featuring elliptical logic might take months to properly understand.

If the Game Moderator determines that some form of skill test is required to comprehend the information (e.g., if it is in a foreign language or recorded in a highly unorthodox way), that roll should only be allowed after the necessary research time has been invested. In general, it isn't necessary for the research process to be uninterrupted, but a long break might prove a setback which lengthens the overall task.

9.1.5 Dangers of Understanding

Lovecraft famously wrote that the most merciful thing in the world is mankind's inability to correlate all the pieces of knowledge at its disposal. It's this "island of ignorance" that saves humanity from going insane from the realization of the true horrors underlying the world. Deliberately diving into the study of the hidden truth is a potentially perilous undertaking.

Revelations about terrible or shocking events or disgusting practices of Cthulhu Mythos entities or their followers, might warrant a SAN Loss.

9.1.6 Skill Increases

The main reason to unlock the hidden wisdom of Mythos accounts or other obscure knowledge-sources is to gain information that is relevant to the state of the current world or the scenario/campaign that is being played. In this regard, you as Game Moderator should reward successful research with some helpful details or facts which will aid in solving a problem or remaining alive in the broken world.

In addition to this, you might rule that the knowledge learned through research increases the Protagonist's skill ratings in some way. The most common 'reward' is an improvement to the **Unnatural** skill (which captures hidden knowledge about the Cthulhu Mythos and its attendant horrors).

A minor account might provide +5 skill points (or fewer) to **Unnatural**, while certain rare and shocking accounts might offer as much as +15.

When improving the Unnatural skill, don't forget that a Protagonist's Sanity cannot ever be higher than (99 minus the Unnatural skill rating). If changing this cap means current Sanity is too high, that number must also be reduced to match the new **Maximum SAN**.

In addition to learning about the Unnatural, successful research might improve other knowledge-based skills as well. For example:

- Information about obscure human beliefs might improve **Occult**
- Information about events or places from the distant past might improve **History** or **Archeology**
- Information about folklore specific to a geography might improve a **Regional Lore** skill
- Information about human civilizations, either past or present might improve **Anthropology**

More mundane knowledge might be learned as well, which improves **Art**, **Craft**, **First Aid**, **Law**, etc.

Usually the amount of skill gained through such means will be variable and relatively small (e.g., 1D4 to 1D10).

9.1.7 Learning Rituals

Mythos accounts may also include descriptions of rituals which, if correctly performed, can create a supernatural effect. Rituals typically involve (potentially complex) patterns of action, chants, and associated paraphernalia. The manifestations created through rituals can be significant, but unlike magic in most tabletop roleplaying games such supernatural workings are laborious. They are typically time-consuming and may require the coordinated actions of a group of people to have any chance of succeeding.

Despite such inherent limitations, supernatural rituals represent perhaps the most powerful source of otherworldly influence which Protagonists (or their human adversaries) are ever likely to have under their control. As such there are some individuals who scour the world searching for tomes which can instruct them in such rituals.

When a Protagonist has successfully read a tome in its entirety you as Game Moderator should provide them with a list of any rituals it contains. Not every account contains rituals, and not every description of supernatural effects in an account is detailed enough to allow it to be reproduced. But for those that are present in such form, you should provide a sketchy description of what the ritual seems designed to do. This should be a description

in vague game-world terms rather than in terms of game mechanics: "seems designed to bring forth a shadow entity" is preferable to "summons a Night-Gaunt".

A Protagonist might decide to attempt to study the specifics of a ritual described in a tome. If so, they will need to devote time and effort to that endeavor. This is in addition to the time spent researching the account itself and represents study that can only begin when its information has been consumed in full.

Exactly how much time is needed to study a given ritual depends on its complexity – that is, whether it is considered **Simple**, **Complex**, or **Elaborate**. Typically, the more powerful the potential effects of a ritual, the more complex it will be.

Simple rituals take research of the order of *hours or days* to learn; **Complex** rituals can only be learned through the application of *days or weeks* of study; and **Elaborate** rituals can take *weeks, months, or years* to master. The time investment to learn a ritual does not have to be a single continuous block of research but can be split across many shorter periods of intense study.

Rolling to Learn A Ritual

If the Protagonist invests the requisite time, they will still need to make a roll at the end of the period to see whether the time invested paid off. The Protagonist must attempt a **SAN roll** — and *fail* the roll — to learn the ritual.

If the roll *does not* indicate a successful learning of the ritual, it means the Protagonist does not grasp the nuances required to master it. They can try again but will need to start from the beginning and again invest the same amount of time again before re-attempting the test.

If, on the other hand, the roll *does* indicate the Protagonist learned the ritual, they lose SAN. This is the price of internalizing unnatural truths about the universe and weird techniques for manipulating it. For **Simple** rituals, the Sanity loss should be modest (e.g., 1 point, 1D4, or 1D6); for **Complex** rituals a more substantial loss is warranted (e.g., 1D6, 1D8, or 1D10), while learning **Elaborate** rituals will always be damaging to Sanity (e.g., 1D10, 1D12, or 1D20 point loss). Learning an Elaborate ritual also grants a Protagonist +1 percentile in the **Unnatural** skill.



Once a ritual has been successfully learned, the Protagonist may attempt to perform it (see below).

Mythos Accounts With Multiple Rituals

Some written accounts, in particular so-called 'grimoires', contain descriptions of many different supernatural rituals. Learning rituals from such sources requires each effort to be attempted separately, using the method described above.

Keeping Failed Rolls Secret

The Game Moderator may choose to keep the SAN roll made at the conclusion of a research attempt secret from the player. If the outcome is a clear success or failure the Protagonist should recognize it as such, but if the roll was a marginal success or failure the Game Moderator might choose to tell the player that the Protagonist believes they have memorized all the subtleties but is not 100% sure. The only way to know for certain is to attempt the ritual — and if the learning attempt was a failure, such an attempt will never properly succeed. Although it may still generate an unintended supernatural effect.

9.2 Performing Rituals

The specific actions, chants, and paraphernalia required to successfully perform a ritual are particular to each and should be designed as part of the ritual's description.

Any attempt to carry out a ritual without the necessary knowledge or components is doomed to failure … although it is possible that flawed ritual activities might still generate some kind of supernatural effect, just not the one intended by the person conducting the ritual. The Game Moderator should use their judgement to determine any such random supernatural side-effects; they should almost always be dangerous and detrimental to those involved.

In terms of game mechanics, the successful performance of a ritual (once the correct pieces are in place) is achieved via an investment of time/effort, the sacrifice of points in one or more game attribute (usually Willpower Points), and a successful **Ritual Activation Test** (see below). If all these steps are successfully achieved, the supernatural effects of the ritual will manifest.

9.2.1 Time Invested in the Ritual

The amount of time required to perform a ritual depends on its complexity rating — **Simple**, **Complex**, or **Elaborate**.

- **Simple** rituals are relatively quick to carry out, requiring somewhere between a turn and a minute.
- **Complex** rituals are more time-consuming, needing somewhere between a few minutes and an hour.
- **Elaborate** rituals are serious undertakings, consuming anything from a few hours to a day or maybe more.

During the time taken to perform a ritual, assume that all participants are completely occupied (chanting, carrying out prescribed actions, using paraphernalia in particular ways). A short interruption might not destroy the momentum of the ritual but a longer break likely will.

9.2.2 Powering the Ritual

The description of a ritual should outline the type and number of personal attribute points that must be sacrificed to provide mental energies that fuel the supernatural effect.

The most common form of sacrifice is Willpower Points — to create relatively minor effects might only require 5 or 6 WPs; a substantial effect might require 15; a vastly powerful effect might require 30; and a truly cosmic-level effect might need 100 or more WPs.

When a Protagonist makes a deliberate sacrifice of WPs, check to see whether the new total carries any effect upon them (see **WILLPOWER POINTS**, page 31). In particular, remember that reaching a WP total of 1 or 2 indicates a mental collapse of some kind, and reaching 0 WP causes unconsciousness.

Whenever a sacrifice of WP is called for, a participant in the ritual may always choose to sacrifice points of permanent POW instead — each such point is equivalent to 10 WPs for the purposes of fueling a ritual. Such sacrificed points do not refresh, but Protagonists can attempt **DOWNTIME** activities to try to get some back (see page 61)

Some rituals also call for a sacrifice of Hit Points, either from the participants or from elsewhere (animal, human, or other living entity). Note that Protagonists who knowingly harm another person, or even cruelly harm or kill an animal are likely to be subject to Sanity loss due to **VIOLENCE** (see page 51).

Depending on the nature of the specific ritual, it may be possible for several people to cooperate in the performance. For especially large effects this may be the only way to generate enough mental energies. While the leader of the ritual must have learned it in full (using the process described in the previous section), helpers can be instructed through simple notes and rote learning. Each assistant chooses for themselves how many points of attributes they will sacrifice.

9.2.3 The Ritual Activation Test

If the requisite amount of time has been devoted to the ritual and the necessary number of attribute points sacrificed, the individual leading the performance may make a roll to see if the effort was ultimately successful.

Successfully activating a ritual depends on the ritual leader's Sanity, but success is more likely the lower that number. The **Ritual Activation Test** is a SAN test that must be failed for the ritual to work as planned.

If the roll indicates the ritual did not work, all the chanting and ceremony has been for naught. The ritual leader has two options — they can either:

- **Abandon the ritual:** nothing supernatural happens at all, and half of the sacrificed points are returned to all participants; or
- **Force a connection** to the supernatural: this involves the leader personally sacrificing 1 POW permanently to turn a failed roll to a successful one. The ritual effects happen after all, despite the roll.

9.2.4 Sanity Costs to Ritual Participants

The simple act of being involved in a supernatural ritual performance is damaging to a character's Sanity, regardless of whether the ritual was successful or not.

If the performance was completed but something went awry (e.g., insufficient mental energy was raised, or the Ritual Activation Test indicated the effort was fruitless), all participants suffer an automatic SAN loss. For rituals intended to create small effects this will be modest, perhaps just 1 SAN point; if attempting a substantial supernatural effect, the loss is 1D4; if attempting a vastly powerful effect it might be 1D6; and for a cosmic effect it might be 1D20.

On the other hand, if the ritual succeeded and the supernatural effect is generated it is quite likely that the experience of witnessing something bizarre created by one's own actions will damage each participants Sanity. The precise losses should reflect the effect that is created, as described by the spell description. As a guideline, a minor supernatural effect might warrant a SAN loss of 1 point, a substantial one might be worth 1D8, a vast effect might lead to a loss of 1D12, and a truly cosmic manifestation might cause a Sanity loss of anything up to 1D100.

9.3 Objects with Unnatural Power

As Game Moderator, you may wish to include in your game items with the power to create supernatural effects reminiscent of those wrought through rituals. Using such an item does not require any special training or learning, and no Ritual Activation Test is needed. The user of an object with supernatural powers may, however, still need to sacrifice attribute points to fuel the effect (as per the GM's description of the item) and might suffer SAN loss from the experience.

10.0 Supernatural Effects

There are lots of weird, supernatural things that can happen in your game of *Cthulhu Eternal*. In most cases, the style of weirdness and its scope of effect should be tied to the specific setting, or the current adventure/campaign/plotline being played out. As such *Cthulhu Eternal* doesn't provide a ready-made catalogue of supernatural rituals and effects to plunder. Effects should relate to significant plot points or elements of the setting rather than being generic RPG 'spells'.

The following guidelines may be helpful to Game Moderators inventing custom supernatural powers for their own game.

10.1 Calculating the Scope of the Supernatural Effect

The manifestations associated with a supernatural effect can be virtually anything the Game Moderator can imagine. Where such effects require game mechanics, these can be designed on a case-by-case basis.

For determining the attribute cost of a ritual, as well as its potential for creating Sanity losses, it is useful to gauge the overall 'magnitude of the effect being generated — this is termed the scope of the effect. For convenience, a scale of eight scope ratings (from least to greatest) is assumed. The table on the next page shows the eight rating categories (left-most column), along with a representative Willpower Point cost for fueling effects at each rating (second column).

The scope of an effect is based on how sweeping a change it causes to the physical (or mental) world. The sections which follow give guidelines regarding how specific types of effects might be rated using this scale.

One basic factor for consideration is the **range** of the supernatural effect (i.e., how far from the ritual site the effect manifests). Generally, it is much easier to create effects nearby and harder to influence reality a long distance away. Column 3 of the table gives a rough guide.

Use these base scope ratings as a starting point, adapting them according to the criteria specific to different effect types as shown on the next page. Wherever multiple criteria apply, always pick the greater of the two possible scope ratings (e.g., if one criterion suggests a Significant rating and another a Vast rating, the scope of the effect is actually Vast).

10.2 Common Types of Effects

As Game Moderator you're free to invent any type of supernatural effect that complements your game world. For settings which emulate the styles of otherworldly phenomena found in H.P. Lovecraft's fiction, a few common categories of effects may prove useful starting points for broader invention.

Designing Supernatural Effects: General Principles

Supernatural effects in *Cthulhu Eternal* are unlike the forms of magic that appear in most roleplaying games, especially games set in the fantasy genre. Rather than wielding a flashy fireball into the midst of combat, a ritual magician in *Cthulhu Eternal* might create a supernatural effect as the result of hours of ritual incantation placing their mind into communion with extradimensional horrors.

The following general guidelines will help you in depicting magic in a suitably low-key and creepy fashion:

- **Supernatural Effects are seldom flashy:** while some spells might create a spectacular if shocking manifestation of unnatural horror, most work with little or no visible or physical effect. Frequently, people who aim to unleash supernatural effects have no way to tell whether their ritual succeeded or not, until hours, days, or even weeks have passed. And even then, its effects may be subtle changes that most people would never notice.

- **Supernatural Effects are usually time-consuming to create:** many supernatural effects require lengthy rituals which are repetitious and wearying to perform. While there are a handful of smaller, casual effects which might be useful in a tactical, fast-paced situation, most play out far too slowly to help in tactical environments.

- **Supernatural Effects are ALWAYS dangerous to invoke:** generating a supernatural effect is equivalent to opening one's mind and essence to the unknowable forces which make up the Cthulhu Mythos. These powers are inherently corrosive to reality as we know it. So, coming into direct mental or physical connection with them always causes some form of lasting damage to the spellcaster, and maybe others as well.

- **Supernatural Effects are the enemy of Sanity:** Connecting with the forces of the Mythos is inherently dangerous to one's Sanity. In game terms this manifests as a mandatory sacrifice of SAN; but in narrative terms you should play up the highly disturbing experience of touching an unknown and unknowable extra-dimensional force whose very existence is anathema to everything that the caster has ever known or experienced. Generating supernatural effects should hurt. Every single time.

Magnitude	Cost to Fuel	Travel/effect Dist.	Cause Dam.	Summon	Mental Contact	Find Entity
Minor	1D4 WP or 3WP	a few yards / meters	1D4	Creature with POW 1–8	Willing colleague	Locate a family member
Small	1D6 WP or 4WP	< 100 yards / meters	1D6	Creature with POW 9–12	Unwilling person	Locate a living person
Significant	1D8 WP or 5WP	to the horizon (i.e., anywhere in line of sight)	1D10	Creature with POW 13–16	Mythos sorcerer	Locate the ghost of a dead stranger
Substantial	1D10 WP or 7WP	anywhere on the same continent	1D20	Creature with POW 17–20	Minor god, like Nodens	Locate a Mythos sorcerer
Major	22 WP (or 12 WP plus 1 POW)	anywhere in the world	10% Lethal	Creature with POW 21–30	Mid-level god, like Bokrug	Travel to e.g., Nodens
Vast	30 WP (or 10 WP plus 2 POW)	anywhere in our galaxy	20% Lethal	Creature with POW 31–40	Major god, like Dagon	Travel to e.g., Bokrug
Sweeping	45 WP (or 15 WP plus 3 POW)	anywhere in our universe	40% Lethal	Creature with POW 41–60	Significant god, like Cthulhu	Travel to e.g., Dagon
Cosmic	110 WP (or 10 WP plus 10 POW)	anywhere in a reachable dimension	99% Lethal	Creature with POW 61–150	Cosmic power, like Azathoth	Travel to e.g., Cthulhu or Azathoth

10.2.1 Summoning Supernatural Entities

In many Lovecraftian settings there exist a family of rituals designed to compel a supernatural being of the Cthulhu Mythos to manifest at the location where the ritual is performed. The specific details of the chants and actions that must be performed to achieve this outcome vary according to the type of creature to be summoned.

In determining the Scope rating for this supernatural effect, the most pertinent factor is the POW characteristic of the supernatural creature summoned.

Column 5 ("Summon") of the table shows representative POW values for entities that can be summoned with each magnitude of effect.

10.2.2 Binding Supernatural Entities

Another category of rituals found in many Lovecraftian settings are those compelling a supernatural creature of the Cthulhu Mythos to obey the will of the ritual leader (at least for a period of time). This control is called binding. As with summoning, the Scope of such an effect is governed primarily by the POW of the creature — use Column 5 of the table. Binding spells which have a long duration (more than a day) may warrant a higher Scope rating than that mentioned on the table.

10.2.3 Mental Contact With Alien Gods

While the Cthulhu Mythos includes numerous races of supernatural creatures, the major Powers are more properly thought of as individual alien 'gods'. This includes vastly powerful entities that are trapped in obscure places on our planet (like Cthulhu) through to cosmic forces that define our very reality (like Azathoth).

Certain insane sorcerers have at different points in history devised rituals to make mental contact with one of these vast unknowable intelligences. In determining the rating for the scope of such an effect the primary consideration is the potency of the Alien God.

Column 6 ("Mental Contact") of the table shows representative POW values for entities that can be mentally contacted with each magnitude of effect.

10.2.4 Opening Physical Conduits to Alien Gods

Some sorcerers are not content with communing with the vast and corrosive intelligences of the Alien Gods, but instead wish to open conduits for their physical avatars to enter our reality.

Again, the primary consideration in determining scope is the potency of the Alien God, although the act of opening a physical conduit is at least one step greater in scope than merely communicating telepathically.

Column 7 ("Find Entity") of the table shows representative entities that can be reached with each magnitude of effect.

10.2.5 Dimensional Traversal

Lovecraftian settings often incorporate the idea of extra-dimensional locales, whether remote parts of our own universe, realms created by the collective human unconscious mind, or entirely different dimensions. Stories set in such worlds may involve a myriad of different supernatural effects that permit mere mortals to cross the barrier between the normal (ravaged) world and one such outside region.

In determining the scope of an effect which allows dimensional traversal, consider the distances involved. Use the Column 3 ("Travel/effect Dist.") of the table provided above, re-imagining the range values as referring instead to the distance traversed.

10.2.6 Cursing and Damaging

Although far less common than in traditional tabletop roleplaying games, supernatural effects may exist in Lovecraftian settings which directly inflict physical harm on individuals.

The scope for such an effect can be estimated by considering the amount of physical damage which may be potentially inflicted, usually represented by a dice value or Lethality rating.

Use Column 4 of the table ("Cause Dam.") to gauge the potential harm created by each magnitude of effect. Where an effect inflicts multiple types of harm, choose the worst/most damaging as the basis for the determination.

10.2.7 Warding and Protection

As counterpoint to supernatural effects which may cause physical harm, it is equally possible for supernatural effects to exist which protect individuals from such harm.

When estimating the scope of such an effect, consider the worst or most-serious type of damage the effect is likely to mitigate then consult Column 4 to find the magnitude of effect required to protect against that degree of physical harm.

For protections against specific types of entities, the GM can base the determination off the POW of the entity (use Column 5 as a guide).





PART III: GAME BUILDING RESOURCES

While the rules presented in this System Reference Document provide a fully-playable (if generic) tabletop roleplaying game, they are designed to also serve as the rules foundation for future games. Several resources are collected here which may assist with the design and definition of such games. This section describes:

- Guidelines for **building new Protagonist Archetypes** which are balanced with the samples provided in Part I.
- Guidelines for **converting game statistics for creatures and Non-Player characters** from other D100 games or from games based around the GUMSHOE roleplaying system.

11.0 Designing New Archetypes

Section 2.5 of these rules describe a representative selection of Protagonist Archetypes suitable for games set in the Jazz Age. While these are varied enough to support a wide range of character types, situations will inevitably arise where none of the pre-defined Archetypes meets the needs of describing a class of Protagonists or NPCs important to the setting.

When this happens, the best solution is to simply create a new Archetype — which is fortunately not difficult.

11.1 Archetype Building in a Nutshell

The notes below give a set of helpful guidelines that can assist in making the design choices that define a brand-new Archetype. However, at its simplest, the mechanical process of defining an Archetype is very simple. Each Archetype needs:

- a suitable **Name** that embodies a character type befitting the setting;
- one or two **Recommended Statistics** that should ideally be higher than average for characters of that Archetype;
- a starting **Number of Bonds** (usually between 2 and 5);
- a **Starting Resources** rating (usually between 2 and 5);
- a set of **Skills** which have a starting value higher than the usual base rating for the setting.

For the last three items, there is a simple system to "balance out" different Archetypes. Each has a budget of 800 points that can be spent as per the table below:

Archetype Feature	Points Cost
For each Starting Bond slot	50 points
For each point rating in Starting Resources	50 points
For each +1 raise to a skill's starting value, above the base value for the skill in this setting	1 point
For each Archetype, there is a total budget of 800 points.	

11.2 Step 1 — Defining the Archetype Concept

Before diving into the specifics of building game-mechanics for your new Archetype concept, it is worth spending some time making sure the idea is built around a clear concept. How is this Archetype going to be different from others already defined for the setting? In what ways is it filling a gap that none of the existing Archetypes can cover? Is the idea too specific to one situation — and could be broadened out to cover a related category of character types? Or is it too abstract, and in need of refinement to bring it back to something that others will intuitively recognize as an appropriate category of characters for this setting? Having a good concept in mind will make everything that follows much easier, so don't rush your thinking about the core concept.

11.3 Step 2 — Picking Recommended Statistics

Each Archetype usually has one or two recommended Statistics that should (ideally) be higher-than-average for characters of that Archetype. Picking these is usually a matter of simple extrapolation from your core concept. Is the Archetype largely driven by knowledge? Then maybe INT should be in the list somewhere. Are individuals of the Archetype defined by their abilities to socialize or establish rapport with other people? Then CHA should definitely be in the list somewhere. If the character type is all about exercising sheer brawn, maybe STR is appropriate … or alternatively if they're all about fine manipulation or skulking in the shadows, perhaps DEX is a suitable choice. There aren't too many character types which revolve around healthiness and fortitude, but if yours does maybe you could consider adding CON to the list. It's fine for your archetype to have just a single recommended statistic, or a couple. More than two is unlikely.

11.4 Step 3 — Starting Bonds and Starting Resources

Each Archetype needs a starting number of Bonds and a starting Resources rating. Of the budget of 800 points, each Bond slot costs 50 and each rating level in Resources costs 50. A starting point for designing an Archetype is to consider a value of 3 starting bonds and 3 starting resources — this reflects an "average" situation for characters; tweak this as seems appropriate.

If your concept for the new Archetype is something that has a wide network of contacts, the initial number of Bonds could be 4 or even 5. Each additional bond will, however, reduce the budget of points available for elevating skills so having an extensive network comes with a cost. Some Archetypes are inherently loners: for them, having a smaller number of starting Bonds (perhaps only 2) captures that insular nature and leaves some additional points for resources or skills, depending on your concept for the Archetype. Creating an Archetype with fewer than 2 starting Bonds risks forcing characters into being cut-off from the world around them, and is not usually realistic.

For a few rare cases, an Archetype might inherently have one bond that is higher than the normal starting value. If your basic concept inherently places the individual in a leadership role (e.g., your Archetype is supposed to be

a local religious leader), it's ok to add a note that says one of the starting bonds will have a rating value of at least 10. This is usually only meaningful for community bonds.

Each Archetype also needs a starting Resources value. Think about how many assets the poorest member of the character type might have access to. If they might be a pauper (at least in terms of access to items), maybe consider a low starting Resources score (perhaps a 2, or in extreme cases a 1). On the other hand, if members of the Archetype would typically have ready access to lots of equipment or assets, a value of 4 or 5 might be worth considering.

Don't forget that during the character generation process, it will be possible to sacrifice skill picks to elevate these base ratings, so leaving a rating at a low level doesn't necessarily mean that every character created using the new Archetype will have a below-average set of items to draw on: it's only those who choose not to further sacrifice skill picks that will have a small pool of items to draw on.

Making the starting Resources value too high will significantly restrict the number of skills that the Archetype will have at an elevated level. (So, while it would be possible to set your Archetype's starting Resources at an impressive score of 12, that would use up 600 of the 800 points in the budget, leaving nothing much for skill enhancement; so characters of that Archetype would all universally "wealthier-than-most" but lacking in any specific skill. This isn't usually an interesting choice.)

Once you've decided on the appropriate number of starting Bonds and starting Resources rating, multiply both numbers by 50 and subtract them from the starting budget of 800. Whatever is left is available for spending on skills.

11.5 Step 4 — Skills With Elevated Starting Ratings

As described on page 20, each skill has a base rating which every character has as a starting value, regardless of their Archetype. For skills that are directly related to the main activities of an Archetype, the beginning rating will be higher to reflect specialized training and/or experience gained through undertaking tasks particular to the Archetype. These elevated starting scores are purchased on a 1-for-1 basis, trading 1 point from the Archetype build budget for a +1 bump in one skill, above its base value. So, if the normal base value for Search is 20 and your concept for the Archetype suggests its members should have a Search value beginning at 50, you would spend 30 points (50 minus 20) from the budget to achieve that goal.

It is traditional to spend points in blocks of 10 (i.e., 10, 20, 30, etc.) to ensure that the Archetype's starting skill ratings remain a neat multiple of 10, although ignoring that convention won't break anything from a game mechanics perspective.

When deciding on which skills to elevate for your Archetype, it is best to think about the common types of tasks that members of the Archetype would perform often in their professional duties, or things would generally be assumed to be good at.

It not unusual for an Archetype's core concept to strongly suggest a half-dozen or so skills which every member of the archetype would excel at, and a larger list of skills which some — but not necessarily all — members would have as a specialty. It is easy to manage this situation by developing two lists:

- A list of **core skills**, universally relevant to every member of the Archetype — usually this won't be more than about six skills; and
- A list of skills which seem like good contenders to be **optional specializations** for the Archetype.

First you can spend most (but not all) of the available points from the budget to increase the starting rating of every skill on the core skill list, remembering:

- The points cost is the amount you raise the starting value ABOVE the normal base.
- There's usually diminishing value in increasing a skill's starting value above 70 or 80 since success is likely and the points might be better spent on elevating another lower-valued skill instead.
- It's not usually beneficial to elevate a core skill by a tiny amount — anything less than a 30-point nudge for a core skill will feel like you're short-changing an important part of the Archetype concept.
- No skill under any circumstance can ever be higher than 99%.

Once you've got most of the points spent on upgrading the core list, divide whatever's left into blocks of 30 or 40 points and specify that the Archetype's skills also include a certain number of picks from your list of optional specializations, with each pick giving that same block-size of elevation to the chosen skill. So, for example, if you were left with 80 points in the budget after core skills had been elevated, you could decide that the Archetype also includes a choice of two skills from your list of possible specializations with each choice elevating the selected skill to a starting value of base plus 40. Alternatively, if there were 90 points left instead you might decide to offer three picks with each offering a 30-point boost over base.

If using this structure to provide a level of customization for the Archetype, you should ensure that there's a good selection of skills to choose from — ideally there should about twice as many options in the list as there are skill picks on offer, to allow plenty of options for diversifying characters. *[So, for example, if you're allowing four picks from the optional specializations list, try to ensure the list has about eight skills to choose from.]*

12.0 Translating Creatures from D100 Games

Game Moderators may find statistics for horrific creatures and supernatural effects in the rules or supplements published for other D100 Lovecraftian horror RPGs. The general-purpose guidelines below give some assistance with converting creature-related statistics for use in *Cthulhu Eternal*.

In most cases, converting horrific creatures found in other D100 games for use in a *Cthulhu Eternal* game is straightforward. A seven-step process for carrying out such conversions is described below.

Step 1: Convert Statistics

As described on page 8, characters and other creatures in Cthulhu Eternal are principally described in terms of six core capabilities: Strength, Constitution, Dexterity, Intelligence, Power, and Charisma. These are measured on a scale of approximately 3–18 for a human being. Most D100 games use a similar set of characteristics although the seventh edition of the world's oldest Lovecraftian roleplaying game chooses to instead measure a character's core statistics on a 1–100 scale.

If the creature or character being translated has game statistics for anything other than the previously mentioned seventh edition game, the translation is simple:

- Strength (sometimes STR) becomes the creature or character's Strength statistic in *Cthulhu Eternal*;
- Constitution (CON), Intelligence (INT), Dexterity (DEX), and Power (POW), all become the identically named statistic in *Cthulhu Eternal*; and
- If a creature/character has a listed Appearance (APP) rating, that translates to its Charisma (CHA) in *Cthulhu Eternal*.

When translating statistics from the aforementioned seventh edition game, the process is effectively the same, but each number is divided by 5 during the translation (e.g., a CON of 65 for a seventh edition creature would translate to a *Cthulhu Eternal* Constitution statistic of 13).

If the creature or character has a listed Sanity (SAN) score, that same number becomes their SAN score in *Cthulhu Eternal*.

Step 2: Derive Hit Points and Will Points (and optionally Resources)

In *Cthulhu Eternal* two key game attributes, Hit Points and Will Points, are derived from the core statistics. The formulae for deriving these may be found in the section on creating Protagonists, on page 8. Once the core statistics have been translated for the Mythos creature or character, these should be calculated exactly as described in the Protagonist generation process.

When translating human characters (as opposed to creatures) it may be important for the Game Moderator to be able to gauge how well-resourced the character is. In that situation, scanning through the list of Archetypes (starting on page 10), the Game Moderator can see which most closely relates to the character's role — the base Resources attribute score for the character can be assumed to be the same as that Archetype. This can be modified up or down by the Game Moderator to reflect a vision for the character's material 'wealth'.

Step 3: Deriving Sanity Loss

For games which list explicit sanity losses for witnessing Cthulhu Mythos horrors, those same sanity losses can be applied in *Cthulhu Eternal*. For games which do not include specific game mechanics for mental stability, use the table on page 52 to pick an equivalent sanity loss based on how disturbing and/or disgusting a creature is described as being.

Step 4: Deriving Skills

All D100-based games measure skill proficiency of a person or creature on a scale of 0—100, the same scale used by Cthulhu Eternal. So, any skill scores assigned as part of the game statistics for another game can be carried across without the need for any arithmetic. However, each different game uses its own list of skills, each of them a variant way of carving the broad field of human knowledge and abilities into different categorizations. Thus, in converting game statistics from another RPG to *Cthulhu Eternal*, it's necessary to decide which *Cthulhu Eternal* skill most closely relates to each skill named in the source stat-block.

There are four situations that can arise:

1. **Obvious Match:** The skill named in the source stat-block has an obvious counterpart in the *Cthulhu Eternal* skill list. In this case, simply give the person or creature the corresponding *Cthulhu Eternal* skill with the same percentile rating assigned to the original skill.
2. **Multiple Match:** The skill named in the source stat-block has similarities with several different *Cthulhu Eternal* skills. In this case, you can either pick one of the *Cthulhu Eternal* skills (ideally the most relevant) and assign all the original skill's percentile rating to that skill, or you can split up the percentiles among multiple *Cthulhu Eternal* skills.
3. **Clash:** Sometimes during the translation of many different skill ratings, it will occur that several different foreign-game skills all translate to the same *Cthulhu Eternal* skill. In that case, the person or creature's percentile rating in that skill should be the highest of all the different skills that translate to that skill.
4. **Novelty Skill:** Some games like to include silly or oddly specific skills (like "bake cookies" or "defuse nuclear bomb"). You can either ignore these skills altogether or carry them across as similar 'additional skills' (i.e.,

presume the existence of a cookie baking skill in *Cthulhu Eternal*, whose definition you can make up as needed).

References to a rating in the "Cthulhu Mythos" skill used in other games should all be carried across to *Cthulhu Eternal's* **Unnatural** skill (see page 25).

Step 5: Deriving Attacks

Every D100-based game describes the basic attributes of an offensive capability (or attack) in terms of a percentage chance that the attack will hit its target, plus a dice roll to determine the HP damage that the attack inflicts.

When converting a stat-block to *Cthulhu Eternal,* each attack mode will typically map to a similar or equivalent weapon skill with the same percentile rating. Damage ratings (die rolls) can either be carried across unchanged, or if the attack mode obviously relates to one of the weapons listed in the examples on page 37, you can just use the Cthulhu Eternal damage rating for the listed weapon. Where the damage die listed in the source stat-block mention adding a "Damage Bonus", consult the material on page 35 to see whether the *Cthulhu Eternal* attack should also include the equivalent bonus.

If converting a stat-block for a creature — especially a large creature, or one with a STR well outside the normal human range — it is probably better to forget about Damage Bonus altogether. Many D100-based games give such massive monstrosities equally massive Damage Bonuses (+3D6 and above): *Cthulhu Eternal's* combat system doesn't seek to model overwhelming damage by means of large pools of dice — instead, it uses the Lethality mechanic. Consider setting the total damage rating of such a creature's attacks based on its overall damage rating in the source system — that is, the attack's base damage plus the creature's stated Damage Bonus. If that total is no-more than 2 dice, then simply set the *Cthulhu Eternal* damage rating for the attack equal to that.

If the foreign-game attack mode lists more than 2 dice to roll for damage overall, it is likely that it would be better to represent the damage in terms of a Lethality rating. The table below gives some approximate translations:

Multiple-Dice Damage	Lethality Rating
3D6	9%
3D8	12%
3D10	15%
For each extra D6	+3%
For each extra D8	+4%
For each extra D10	+5%

Step 6: Deriving Armor value

Creatures or individuals who have innate protection from damage, or who wear protective equipment may have an Armor value as part of their original statistic block. They may also have a description of the particular type of armor.

Armor values from D100-based games can be directly translated across — for example, a Mythos creature with an innate Armor of 2 will have the same Armor rating in *Cthulhu Eternal*.

An alternate method of assigning an Armor value for worn protection is to consult the table in **ARMORED** (page 41), locating a roughly-equivalent type of protective equipment and use the Armor value shown in the table.

Step 7: Defining Special Powers and Defenses

Perhaps the hardest part of converting stat-blocks for creatures (and sometimes human beings) to *Cthulhu Eternal*, is translating special powers and defenses, including unusual modes of attack. These are sometimes written in a manner that is specific to the game-mechanics for the source system.

There are two basic approaches to converting special powers:

1. finding a similar power already possessed by a creature with *Cthulhu Eternal* stats, or
2. converting the individual game mechanics underlying the power into *Cthulhu Eternal* concepts piece-by-piece.

For determining appropriate *Cthulhu Eternal* game-statistics to cover special defenses, a good place to start is considering the categories of Defenses described in **PROTECTION IN COMBAT**, page 40. These are: Fragile, Exposed, Armored, Huge, and Transcendent.

Furthermore, some creatures have physical forms that are less susceptible to Lethal damage: the box nearby summarizes different levels of protection that the Game Moderator can assign to otherworldly monstrosities.

13.0 GUMSHOE Creature Conversions

Creature stat-blocks in *GUMSHOE* are relatively brief, consisting of ratings for: Athletics, Health, Scuffling, Hit Threshold, Alertness Modifier, Stealth Modifier, Weapon, Armor, and sometimes Stability Loss.

The tables below give a (rough) idea of how these ratings can be carried across to *Cthulhu Eternal* creature statistics. Because *GUMSHOE* is quite a different system, some creativity will be required to fill in statistics like INT, POW, etc. since *GUMSHOE* typically doesn't measure such attributes for creatures.

Athletics Rating

In general, a creature can be assumed to have a *Cthulhu Eternal* Athletics skill equal to its *GUMSHOE* Athletics rating × 12%. Physical statistics like STR, DEX, and CON can — if needed — be inferred from this. A higher *GUMSHOE* Athletics rating almost certainly means one or more of those stats will be well above average.

Reduced Susceptibility to Lethal Damage

The following common forms of protection against Lethal attacks may be assigned to creatures/individuals which are harder to kill than normal humans.

- **RESILIENT:** A successful roll on a Lethal attack does not kill the creature/individual but inflicts Hit Point damage equal to 2D10 minus any Armor rating.
- **RESILIENT TO** <attack type, e.g., Firearms>: If attacked with other attack types than the one named, damage/lethality is as per normal. If attacked with Lethal attacks of the nominated type, a successful roll does not kill the creature/individual but inflicts Hit Point damage equal to 2D10 minus any Armor rating.
- **PARTIALLY IMMUNE** (less than <number, e.g., 20>%): If the Lethal attack has a Lethality rating less than or equal to the number mentioned, it cannot harm or kill the target – even a successful Lethality roll will cause it zero harm. For Lethal attacks with a Lethality rating higher than the number mentioned, the creature/individual is still not automatically killed on a successful Lethality roll but suffers Hit Point damage equal to 2D10 minus any Armor rating.
- **IMMUNE:** Is not affected at all any physical attacks, including Lethal attacks.

Some Example Special Attacks

During a translation the GM might need to invent game statistics for special forms of attacks. The following examples provide some example powers that can be used or adapted as needed.

Blood Drain: The bite of the entity drains blood from the victim each turn until forcibly detached. For each turn of blood loss, the victim loses 1D6 STR. If STR reaches zero the victim dies, however if they survive the attack, it will be slowly regained at the rate determined by the Game Moderator.

Cling & Bite: After the entity bites a victim, it will cling to it unless forcibly removed. Each subsequent turn inflicts a further 1D3 Hit Points of damage to the victim.

Engulf Victims: If a victim is pulled into the entity's mass it becomes absorbed within it. An individual trapped inside the entity must separately make an opposed test comparing their STR×5 against the entity's STR×5. If the test is failed, the victim takes Lethal Damage with rating equal to 1% × the entity's CON. Trapped targets inside the entity find it difficult to move or attack: only by making a percentile roll below their STR×5 can such individuals make an attack while inside the entity.

Mental Drain: If the entity wishes to mentally weaken those in its proximity, it can compel an individual to perform an opposed test which matches the entity's POW×5 versus the victim's INT×5. If the victim is defeated in this test, they immediately lose 1D6 Willpower Points + 1D6 SAN. The WPs are added to the attacker's total.

Tentacle Constrict/Crush: If one of the entity's tentacles successfully strikes an enemy it will wrap around it and continue to crush it in later turns. Unless freed by external means, the victim will continue to suffer Hit Point damage equal to half the normal attack damage in each succeeding turn.

Tentacle Grapple: If the tentacle of the entity strikes a victim it wraps itself around a limb, effectively PINNING the target (see page 46). Being held in this way does not inflict any Hit Point damage but the victim is effectively unable to take any actions until they are freed. The entity can use its other attacks against victims held by its tentacle. Breaking free from the entity's grip requires success in an opposed test pitting the entity's STR×5 against the victim's STR×5.

Toxic Venom: The bite of the entity injects a potent toxin with a Lethality Rating equal to the entity's CON.

Some Example Special Abilities

During a translation the GM might need to invent game statistics for special abilities that aren't attacks but still provide the creature or person with an advantage. The following examples provide a few ideas that can be used or adapted as needed.

Hypnotize: The entity's gaze can render a victim in a trance-like state. When a victim locks eyes with the entity, they make an opposed POW×5 vs POW×5 test with it. If the target loses, a hypnotic state quickly descends. Humans controlled in this way will always follow simple instructions. If the commands are inherently self-destructive or injurious to the controlled person, an INT×5 roll can be attempted at the beginning of each turn — success means the person snaps out of the trance.

Invisible: The entity has the power to become invisible to normal vision through a supernatural effect; attempts to hit the entity while it is invisible are halved.

Mental Control: The entity has the power to control humans via mental dominance. Resolve such attempts as an opposed POW×5 vs POW×5 test; if the target's will is overcome, they are compelled to remain in close proximity to the area where the mental control was initiated. Once controlled, a dominated human can be mentally contacted by the entity regardless of where it is, anywhere on Earth. This communication costs the entity 1 Willpower Point.

Regeneration: Regenerates 2 HP per turn after being wounded; if the entity's HP ever reach zero it is dead and will not regenerate.

Trans-dimensional Travel: The entity has an innate ability to travel between different dimensions. Initiating a transition from our dimension to another takes a full (uninterrupted) turn and costs the entity 4 Willpower Points. If the entity is holding anything or anyone (e.g., someone held via a previous pin action), they too make the journey.

Some Example Special Vulnerabilities

During a translation the GM might need to invent some game statistics for a creature's special vulnerability. Here are a few ideas that can be used as starting points for new inventions.

Hates the Light: The entity takes damage from exposure to light. Bright light inflicts 1 HP per turn; bright and dazzling light inflicts 3D6. Full daylight reduces the entity to a pile of grey ash. This damage ignores armor.

Poisoned by <Substance>: The entity's metabolism is particularly susceptible to a common earthly substance. Whenever the entity comes into direct physical contact with the substance it must make a CON×5 test; if it fails, the entity suffers Lethality 10% damage.

Susceptible to Fire: Fire inflicts double damage to the entity. This damage ignores armor.

Health Rating

In general, a creature in *Cthulhu Eternal* will have 2 Hit Points for every single point of *GUMSHOE* Health Rating. For example, a large *GUMSHOE* monstrosity with a Health Rating of 10 will have 20 HP in *Cthulhu Eternal*.

Scuffling and Weapon

The percentage chance that a *Cthulhu Eternal* version of an attack will hit its target is usually given by the *GUMSHOE* Scuffling rating × 4%.

For damage associated with an attack see table nearby.

GUMSHOE Weapon Rating	Cthulhu Eternal Damage
–3 Damage	1 HP
–2 Damage	Either 1D3 HP or 1D4 HP
–1 Damage	1D6 HP
+0 Damage	1D8 HP
+1 Damage	Either 1D8+1HP, 1D10 HP, or 2D6 HP
+2 Damage	Either 3D6 HP, 4D6 HP, or Lethality 10%
+3 Damage	Lethality: 15%
+5 Damage	Lethality: 20%
+12 Damage	Lethality: 40%

GUMSHOE Hit Threshold	Cthulhu Eternal Skill in Dodge
2	0 (Attacker gains +40% chance to hit)
3	15% (easier than normal to hit)
4	30% (average difficulty to hit)
5	50% (harder than average to hit)
6	75% (much harder than average to hit)

GUMSHOE Armor Rating	Cthulhu Eternal Armor
–1	1 point
–2	2 points
–3	3 or 4 points
–4	5, 6, or 7 points*
–5	8—11 points*
–6	12—16 points*
–7	17—22 points*

* Rating may indicate that the creature is **HUGE**, **TRANSCENDENT**, or have some form of **REDUCED SUSCEPTIBILITY TO LETHAL DAMAGE**.

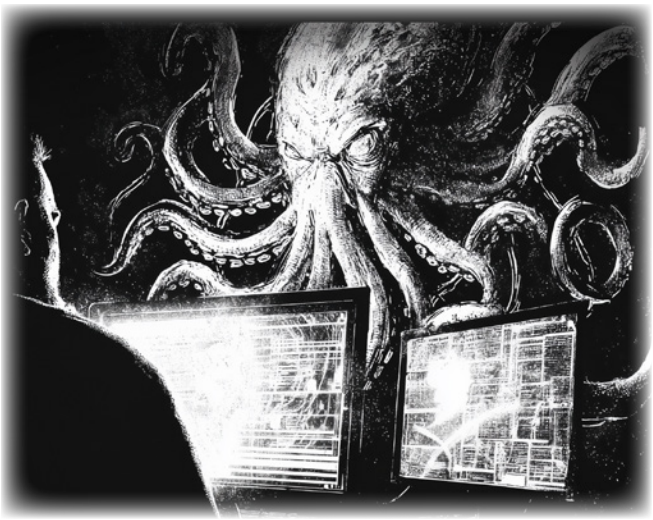
Hit Threshold & Armor; Stability Loss; Stealth Modifier; Alertness Modifier

See tables on the next page for descriptions of how these *GUMSHOE* creature ratings dictate its Armor, Dodge, Stealth skill and Alertness skill. Also the SAN lost by an individual encountering the creature.

GUMSHOE Stability Loss	Cthulhu Eternal SAN Loss
1 point	SAN Loss of 0/1
2 points	SAN Loss of 0/1D3
3 points	SAN Loss of 1/1D4
4 points	SAN Loss of 1/1D6
5 points	SAN Loss of 1/1D10
6 points	SAN Loss of 1D6/1D20
7 points	SAN Loss of 1D8/2D20
8 points	SAN Loss of 1D10/1D100

GUMSHOE Stealth Mod	Cthulhu Eternal Skill in Stealth (or similar)
+1	30%
+2	60%
+3	90%

GUMSHOE Alertness Mod	Cthulhu Eternal Skill in Alertness
+1	30%
+2	60%
+3	90%



Lovecraftian Protagonist Character Record Sheet

Name _____

Setting _____

Archetype _____

Age _____ Gender _____

Home _____

Birthplace _____

Statistics

STATISTIC	SCORE	x5	Distinguishing Feature
Strength (STR)			
Constitution (CON)			
Dexterity (DEX)			
Intelligence (INT)			
Power (POW)			
Charisma (CHA)			

Other Attributes

Willpower Points ❶

MAX _____ CURRENT _____ ☐ Exhausted (-20%)

❶ WP 2 or less = emotional breakdown (-20%), WP 0 = incapacitated

Damage Bonus _____

Body Armor _____

Max/Starting HP _____

Current HP ❹

STUNNED		00	01	02
		03	04	05
06	07	08	09	10
11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20

Max SAN _____ **Recovery SAN** _____ ❶

Current SAN ❸

Insane		01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08	09	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32	33	34	35	36	37	38	39	40	41	42	43	44	45	46	47	48	49	50
51	52	53	54	55	56	57	58	59	60	61	62	63	64	65	66	67	68	69	70	71	72	73	74	75	76
77	78	79	80	81	82	83	84	85	86	87	88	89	90	91	92	93	94	95	96	97	98	99			

Incidents of SAN Loss Without Insanity

Violence ☐☐☐ ❷ Helplessness ☐☐☐ ❷

Breaking Point ❸ ☐

❶ Circle current SAN on meter. Black out numbers above MAX SAN. Draw box around Breaking Point

❷ Third checkbox filled, character is adapted

❸ >5 SAN lost in one roll, temporary insanity. If SAN reaches Breaking Point, acquire a Disorder and reset BP

❹ HP 2 or less = unconscious AND roll for permanent injury. HP of 0 = dead

Permanent Injuries ❹

_____

_____

_____

CTHULHU ETERNAL Modern Age

Skills

Base ratings shown in [square brackets]. All skills with fill-in spaces for specializations have a base rating of 0%.

- ☐ Administration [10%] _____
- ☐ Alertness [20%] _____
- ☐ Anthropology [0%] _____
- ☐ Appraise [10%] _____
- ☐ Archeology [0%] _____
- ☐ Art (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Art (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Athletics [30%] _____
- ☐ Charm [20%] _____
- ☐ Craft (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Craft (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Disguise [10%] _____
- ☐ Dodge [30%] _____
- ☐ Drive [20%] _____
- ☐ Firearms [20%] _____
- ☐ First Aid [10%] _____
- ☐ Foreign Language (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Foreign Language (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Forensics [0%] _____
- ☐ Harangue [10%] _____
- ☐ Heavy Machinery [10%] _____
- ☐ History [10%] _____
- ☐ Insight [10%] _____
- ☐ Law (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Medicine [0%] _____
- ☐ Melee Weapons [30%] _____
- ☐ Military Training (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Natural World [10%] _____
- ☐ Navigate [10%] _____
- ☐ Occult [10%] _____
- ☐ Persuade [20%] _____
- ☐ Pharmacy [0%] _____
- ☐ Pilot (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Pilot (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Psychoanalyze [10%] _____
- ☐ Regional Lore (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Regional Lore (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Research [10%] _____
- ☐ Ride [10%] _____
- ☐ Science (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Science (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Science (_____) [0%] _____
- ☐ Search [20%] _____
- ☐ Stealth [10%] _____
- ☐ Surgery [0%] _____
- ☐ Survival (_____) [10%] _____
- ☐ Survival (_____) [10%] _____
- ☐ Swim [20%] _____
- ☐ Technology Use [0%] _____
- ☐ Track [10%] _____
- ☐ Unarmed Combat [20%] _____
- Unnatural [0%] _____
- ☐ _____ _____
- ☐ _____ _____

Bonds

Individual Bond **Score**

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Community Bond **Score**

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Motivation / Mental Disorder

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Permanent Resources _____

Resource Checks ✪ ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ✪ Black Out Unavailable Boxes

MAX 6	MAX 6	Unlimited
AT HAND	STOWED	IN STORAGE

Protagonist's Story So Far

Terrible Tomes & Arcane Rituals

Gear

Record Pristine/Worn/Junk

Weapons

(db) = damage bonus
(ap) = armor piercing

WEAPON	SKILL %	BASE RANGE	DAMAGE	(db)	(ap)	Pristine/Worn/Junk	LETHALITY %	KILL RADIUS	AMMO
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			
						☐ ☐ ☐			

CTHULHU ETERNAL RULES CHEAT SHEET

Test Outcomes: Roll d100. If under test → **Success**; if digits of dice match also *(or roll 01)* → **Critical**.
Roll over test → **Failure**; if digits of dice match also *(or roll 00)* → **Fumble**.

Opposed Tests: both sides roll and compare results Critical beats Success beats any failure. If both parties succeed or crit, whoever rolled **HIGHER** wins

Combat Options: Aim, Attack, Called Shot, Disarm, Dodge, Escape Pin, Fight Back, Move, Pin, Wait.

Resisting Insanity: Project SAN loss onto Bond, Use Bond to Repress Temp Insanity / episode of Disorder

Notes

Fellow Characters

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